



Days of Governance



A Government for Generations

Singapenn Special Task Force for Women Safety	Special Task Force for Interdiction of Narcotics and Gangs (STING) - 65 Special Task Force constituted to combat drug trafficking	200 units of free electricity for domestic consumers using upto 500 units of electricity every 2 months
Thaaimaaman Thanga Mothiram Scheme Every newborn delivered in Government Hospital will receive 1 gram gold ring. Rs.560 crore allocated	Annan's Seer Scheme Women will be provided with 8 gram gold coin and a silk saree for their marriage. Rs.812 crore allocated	Expansion of Perunthalaivar Kamarajar Breakfast Scheme - Benefitting 15.14 lakhs additional students in Classes 6-8 across 15,414 Government and Government-aided schools. Rs.710 crore allocated
Vettri Tamil Nadu Investment Conclave 2026 Rs. 1 lakh crore investment	Special Incentive Sugarcane - Rs.4,000 per tonne Paddy - Rs.2,750 per quintal	Rs.6,000 crore crop loan waiver for farmers
717 liquor shops located near educational institutions, temples and bus stands have been closed	Vettri Housing Scheme Rs.3,500 crore allocated	Vettri Laptop Scheme for college students Rs.2,000 crore allocated
Vettri Skill Training Scheme Skill Development Training for 12 lakh students and 1 lakh youth	Vettri 150 Scheme 150 days of guaranteed employment	Modern Branded bicycles with helmets and water bottles to Class XI students in Government and Government-aided schools
TN-VETTRI : Rs.6,000 crore allocated annually to improve Water Supply, Solid Waste Management, Sanitation and Rural Connectivity	Vettri Magalir Goat Rearing Scheme 5 goats or sheep will be provided to disadvantaged women & transgenders	Honest & Transparent governance Speedy Plan Approval, Faceless Property Registration

Signature of the Director, Information and Public Relations Department



Families shelter at a makeshift evacuation centre after the earthquake in Maumere, East Nusa Tenggara, Indonesia, on Sunday. REUTERS

Thousands evacuated after Indonesia quake kills 53; aftershocks hamper rescue efforts

Reuters
Maumere, August 16

AROUND 5,000 PEOPLE have been evacuated after a magnitude-7.7 earthquake rocked eastern Indonesia, killing at least 53, blocking roads and causing landslides, officials said Sunday.

They added that more than 130 people had been injured, many with broken bones. Saturday's quake was the Southeast Asian nation's deadliest since a 2022 quake killed hundreds in West Java.

More than 3,300 people in Indonesia's eastern Sikka region self-evacuated or were in a sports arena, according to the country's national disaster mitigation agency, known as BNPB.

Some residents were stranded outside collapsed homes under a makeshift tent made out of tarpaulin, while others received treatment in a tent outside a hospital.

A sprawling archipelago of 290 million people, Indonesia

straddles the "Pacific Ring of Fire", a seismically active zone where tectonic plates meet, triggering frequent earthquakes and volcanic eruptions.

At a now-closed port in Maumere, littered with debris from a collapsed roof and walls, residents told Reuters they were scared of aftershocks. The disaster agency said Sunday nearly a thousand aftershocks had been recorded since the quake.

Nearby, hundreds of residents filled a sports stadium, which has been designated as an evacuation spot.

As the sun was setting, residents stood in line to get warm drinks. Some mothers hooked pieces of clothing to their frames to form makeshift cradles for their babies. Other children played soccer outside.

Margaretha Movales Da Maga Bapa, head of the region's disaster mitigation agency, said the quake had brought back memories of the one residents experienced in 1992.

RUSSIA'S DEFENCE MINISTRY SAYS 822 UKRAINIAN DRONES SHOT DOWN

Kyiv launches biggest drone attack on Russia so far, kills 6

Romania downs suspected Russian drone over airspace

Associated Press
Moscow, Kyiv, August 16

UKRAINE LAUNCHED hundreds of drones across Russia on Sunday, killing at least six people in one of Kyiv's largest aerial attacks of the war. Kyiv has stepped up its attacks on Russia this year, with long-range missiles and swarms of drones targeting military industries and energy facilities.

It has also increasingly pummeled giant Wildberries depots, burning billions of dollars' worth of merchandise belonging to the Russian online retail giant. Those attacks have brought the war home to the Russian public nearly five years into Moscow's full-scale invasion of Ukraine.

Meanwhile, Ukraine also came under Russian attack, with drone strikes destroying homes and torching Kyiv's landmark book market.



Emergency personnel at the site of a book market hit by a Russian missile strike, in Kyiv, on Sunday. REUTERS

Russia's Ministry of Defence said it had destroyed 822 Ukrainian drones overnight. Some 600 drones were detected headed toward the Russian capital, Moscow Mayor Sergei Sobyanin said, with a third of those destroyed over the Moscow region itself.

An 83-year-old man was killed after a Ukrainian drone hit a private home in the Moscow region, local Gov. Andrey Vorobyov said. He also confirmed that a Ukrainian attack had

sparked a blaze at a Wildberries warehouse in town of Podolsk. A drone attack targeted three towns in Russia's southwestern Rostov region, killing five people, local Gov. Yury Ilyusar said. The attack, with more than 150 drones, damaged several homes and a railway station and sparked a forest fire.

A Russian missile attack on Ukraine's Kyiv Rih killed two people and wounded 14 others, Ukrainian President Volodymyr Zelenskyy wrote on social

media Sunday. He also said that one more person had been killed in the city of Sumy.

ArceforMittal Kryviy Rih, Ukraine's largest steel producer, confirmed that one of its sites had been hit in a missile attack and that operations had been partially suspended.

Russian attacks also sparked fires throughout the Ukrainian capital, Kyiv, wounding six people. A blaze took hold at one of the city's largest book markets, tearing through kiosks huddled close to Pochaina metro station.

Meanwhile, an F-18 fighter on a NATO air policing mission shot down a drone that illegally breached Romanian national airspace, the fourth unmanned aircraft shot down this year, Romania's defence ministry said on Sunday.

A spokesperson for NATO's military headquarters, US Army Colonel Martin O'Donnell, said the alliance is constantly on watch and prepared to defend itself from any threat. "Additional details regarding Sunday's incident remain under investigation, but the drone appears to be Russian," he said.

—WITH REUTERS INPUTS

Trump envoys meet mediators, Israel strikes Gaza

Reuters
Cairo, August 16

DONALD TRUMP'S envoys met with Egyptian, Qatari and Turkish mediators in Cairo on Sunday, a diplomatic source said, in a bid to advance the US president's Gaza peace plan, even as Israel pressed on with airstrikes in the enclave.

Hamas officials were present at some of the meetings between mediators and with Trump's envoy and son-in-law, Jared Kushner, and Nickolay Mladenov, Trump's Board

of Peace envoy for Gaza, the diplomat said.

A senior Israeli official said Kushner and Mladenov were scheduled to meet Monday with Israeli PM Benjamin Netanyahu, who on August 9 said Trump's latest roadmap for Gaza peace was "unacceptable".

The official said Israel was concerned about Washington's demand to end targeted assassinations of Hamas militants in Gaza as it rebuilds its forces.

Trump's peace plan calls for the immediate cessation of military operations in Gaza.

It foresees Hamas disarming as Israeli troops withdraw from the enclave and Gaza is rebuilt under a new civilian Palestinian administration.

After scaling back its attacks in the enclave earlier this month, Israel's airstrikes have resumed in the past few days.

The Israeli military said on Sunday that its aircraft struck two Islamic Jihad and Hamas militants in Khan Younis and Nuseirat. At least five Palestinians were injured in the strike which hit a tent encampment, medics in the enclave said.

A separate airstrike, which the Israeli military said targeted another militant, hit an apartment in the Nuseirat camp in central Gaza, wounding several people, medics said.

Earlier on Sunday, five Arab countries together with Turkey, Pakistan and Indonesia condemned Israel's rejection of US President Donald Trump's plan for Gaza. In a joint statement, the countries including Egypt, Qatar, Saudi Arabia and UAE, said the rejection threatened Trump's intensified efforts to end war in Gaza.

Qatar captured 3 of our pilots, says Iran; Doha denies claim

Yeganeh Torbati & Lelly Nikounazar
August 16

IRAN ACCUSED Qatar on Saturday of capturing three of its bomber pilots in the early days of the US-Israeli war with Iran, a claim that a Qatari official publicly denied.

General Seyed Mohammad Bagherzadeh, commander of the Iranian armed forces' missing persons search committee, made the accusation in a letter to the International Committee of the Red Cross, which was published by Iranian media.

He said the men were flying Su-24 fighter jets in an operation on March 2, days after the outbreak of the war, when their planes had been hit by "enemy defenses" and the pilots ejected.

They survived but were captured by the Qatari authorities, according to General Bagherzadeh, who named the men as Javad Salehi, Abdolmajid Dashedian and Omran Behraveshtian. A fourth pilot, Majid Kazemi, died, he added.

But Majed al-Ansari, a spokesman for Qatar's foreign ministry, denied the country had detained the Iranians.

"We categorically deny the claims circulating regarding

“We categorically deny the claims circulating regarding the detention of Iranian pilots & are surprised by these misleading statements... amid the ongoing diplomatic efforts & initiatives aimed at de-escalating tensions in the region”

MAJED AL-ANSARI,
SPOKESPERSON FOR QATAR
FOREIGN MINISTRY

the detention of Iranian pilots & are surprised by these misleading statements at this particular time, amid the ongoing diplomatic efforts & initiatives aimed at de-escalating tensions in the region", al-Ansari wrote on social media on Saturday evening.

Qatar, a close US ally that hosts a major American military base, said in early March that its Air Force had shot down two Iranian Su-24 bomber jets. Al-Ansari said on Saturday that "contact was established with the pilots concerned following their violation of Qatari airspace." NYT

Iran votes to criminalise 'hostile' media interviews

Dubai: Iran's parliament approved a bill on Sunday that would criminalise interviews and other communications with media deemed hostile to the Islamic Republic, including US or Israeli media and outlets financed by other country, Iran's Sharh newspaper reported.

Under the bill, which must still be reviewed by the Guardian Council before it can become law, interviews or participation in discussions with such media

would be banned and violations punishable by six months to two years in prison.

Interviews with other foreign media would require notification to the intelligence ministry, while contact with foreign embassies, offices of foreign organisations or other non-Iranian institutions without notification and written permission from the foreign ministry would be punishable by a fine and deprivation of certain social rights. REUTERS

Ex-Cambridge prof's death tragedy on many levels: UK PM

Associated Press
London, August 16

BRITAIN'S PRIME minister called for reflection on Saturday after a Black professor who faced a storm of plagiarism accusations died suddenly, days after resigning from a prestigious role at the University of Cambridge.

Jason Arday, who became Cambridge's youngest Black professor in 2023, was found dead inside an address in south London on Friday.

He resigned last week as

professor of sociology of education after coming under intense media scrutiny, with weeks of news headlines alleging plagiarism in his academic work and questions surrounding claims about his athletic and fundraising accomplishments.

His death has prompted outcry that allegations against Arday, 41, were magnified into a cruel public takedown motivated by racism and longstanding hostility to diversity, equity and inclusion policies at universities and other institutions.



Jason Arday was found dead

Prime Minister Andy Burnham said Arday's death was "a tragedy on so many levels." "It's not a moment for any

rushing to judgment. It's a moment for reflection, I would say, reflecting on how things came to this," Burnham told reporters.

Police said the death was being treated as "unexpected" but not suspicious. They said officers were called to an address in south London on Friday afternoon and a 41-year-old man was pronounced dead at the scene.

They did not name Arday, in accordance with police policy.

A friend said Arday had told him that he "felt he couldn't go on" in a voice note earlier Friday.

"He was being subjected to relentless scrutiny, including ridicule, discrediting absolutely every detail of his life, and he wasn't coping with the loss of his career, the loss of his reputation," Cambridge professor and director of the Autism Research Centre, Simon Baron-Cohen, told the BBC.

Arday's family said in a statement that he had been subjected to a "campaign of harassment" and "sustained abuse" ever since he took up his post as professor at Cambridge.

South Korea fires warning shots as N Korea troops cross 'military line'

Reuters
Seoul, August 16

SOUTH KOREA'S Joint Chiefs of Staff (JCS) said on Sunday that warning shots had been fired when North Korean soldiers violated the military demarcation line between the two countries, prompting them to return.

The Yonhap news agency reported earlier on Sunday that warnings shots had been fired last week, citing an unnamed source.

"Recently, on the Eastern Front, North Korea forces crossed the military demarcation line, prompting our military to fire warning shots according to operational procedures," a JCS statement said without giving the date of the incident.

"Our military is closely monitoring North Korean movements while maintaining a firm military readiness posture," Yonhap said. The incident was the first reported violation of the military demarcation line by North Korea this year and that the soldiers were likely to have been patrolling the area when they crossed the MDL.

• BRIEFLY

ITALY

Thieves steal 4 Antonello da Messina artworks in Sicilian museum heist



The Madonna and Child by Antonello da Messina, which was stolen. REUTERS

FOUR ARTWORKS by 15th century painter Antonello da Messina have been stolen overnight from the Museo Regionale di Messina, Italy's culture minister said on Sunday, expressing confidence in the police inquiry. The theft deprives Messina of parts of the only surviving work by the Renaissance painter to have remained in his native city, as well as a small painting acquired by the Sicilian Region two decades ago.

"I've learnt of the theft with shock and sadness," Culture Minister Alessandro Giuli said. REUTERS

HUNGARY

12 killed after bus overturns

TWELVE PEOPLE were killed and at least 10 injured after a Polish-registered bus overturned on the M3 motorway in Hungary on Sunday, Hungarian Prime Minister Peter Magyar said. Police said bus veered off the road into a ditch and overturned, with probe suggesting the driver likely fell asleep. AP

PAKISTAN

Security forces kill 7 militants

TWO WOMEN of a Sindh family were shot dead in a terror attack while security forces killed seven terrorists in two separate incidents in Balochistan, officials said on Sunday. The terrorists were killed during an operation while several other terrorists injured, according to the military's media wing. PTI

Morocco arrests 111 migrants headed for Spain's Ceuta in security crackdown

Reuters
Ceuta, August 16

MOROCCAN POLICE arrested at least 111 people on Saturday as they tried to enter Spain's North African enclave of Ceuta, amid tightened security on both sides of the border after social media posts called for another mass migrant crossing.

The attempted crossing came two weeks after more than 72,000 migrants surged into

Ceuta, sparking tensions within the EU and fuelling anti-immigration rhetoric among far-right parties worldwide. At least 96 people died in the attempt to reach European soil.

A source in Morocco's Interior Ministry told Reuters that those detained included 109 migrants from Africa and two Moroccan citizens arrested in or around Fnideq, the Moroccan city opposite Ceuta.

According to Spanish news

agency EFE, Moroccan police used tear gas to disperse groups of migrants gathered on hills about 3 km from the border.

Reuters later saw hundreds of police officers, some in riot gear and others in plain clothes, returning from the hills outside Fnideq. EFE and Spanish state broadcaster TVE said Morocco's Interior Ministry ordered their journalists to leave Fnideq immediately, without providing an explanation.

Belgium's biggest wildfire on record heads towards Germany

Brussels: Firefighters worked through the night to battle Belgium's biggest wildfire on record, which by Sunday had burned 3,000 hectares of land and was heading towards German border, authorities said.

The blaze in the High Fens, a nature reserve in the east of the country, has been burning since Friday and firefighters from across Belgium and neighbouring Germany and Luxembourg have sought to contain it, as have the army and farmers.

Responders Sunday were focused on the front line of the fire moving towards Germany and were hopeful that cooler, more humid weather would support efforts to contain it. Stephanie Ernoux, spokesperson for the administration of the Belgian region of Wallonia, told Reuters.

The fire is more than double the size of a blaze in 2011 that burned close to 1,400 hectares, the data from European Forest Fire Information System showed. REUTERS



More than 4,000 gold coins and dozens of gold bars were found sealed in a cellar below the construction site. WPT

to ensure nothing was lost or stolen. "An amount like this, it's always a risk," Chief Feys said, adding that he did not relax until

the stash was in federal custody. Geert Hillaert, the director of the social services nonprofit that owns the property where

Forbes fires top editor over secret \$6 million payment

Benjamin Mullin
August 16

THE TOP editor of Forbes was fired last month after the company discovered he had received a payment of about \$6 million from the founder of a firm that does business with the magazine, according to three people familiar with the decision.

Randall Lane, the magazine's chief content officer, was paid by RJ Shook, whose company, Shook Research, has teamed up with Forbes since 2016 to publish rankings of wealth advisers. The payment was made after Shook sold a majority stake in Shook Research to PPC Enterprises, a pri-



Randall Lane, former chief content officer of Forbes

vate equity firm, Last August, two of the people familiar with the transaction said.

Forbes has policies requiring its employees to seek permission before conducting outside business activities and prohibiting them from gaining personally — directly or indirectly — from the company's business dealings, according to a copy of the employee handbook obtained by The New York Times. NYT

• CONSTRUCTION WORKERS IN DENDERMONDE HAD BEEN DRILLING BENEATH WHAT USED TO BE THE FOUNDATION OF A BREWERY BUILT IN THE 1890s

\$10 million in gold found buried under former brewery in Belgium

Zane Irwin
August 16

WHEN THE police chief learned what workers had found, sealed inside a small brick cellar as they drilled below a defunct brewery, he was sure someone had interrupted his Tuesday meeting with a prank. "I thought it was a joke," said the chief, Patrick Feys, "because things like that normally don't happen in real life."

But workers had plenty of proof: 49 gold bars and over 4,000 gleaming coins, a cache worth an estimated \$10 million, its origin and fate unknown.

Construction workers in the Belgian city of Dendermonde

had been drilling this week beneath what used to be the foundation of a brewery built in the 1890s. The site was undergoing renovations for a project to create transitional housing for homeless people. At first, the workers thought they had only found one-euro coins, and kept boring through the cellar's brick walls, Chief Feys said.

Instead, they started finding gold bars, leaving dents and scratches on a few with their tools. After the discovery, Chief Feys's mounting excitement merged with anxiety, he said.

The police hurried the trove to the station for inventory, where four people counted each piece under a surveillance cam-

the gold was found, said in an interview that two questions sprang to mind when he heard about the buried treasure: "How does this happen?" and "How do we get it safe?"

Local prosecutors will investigate whether the gold has been stolen or involved in any crime, Hillaert said. If not, Belgian law gives family members or other heirs five years to claim the bounty, he and the police said. But there do not appear to be any direct, living heirs of the brewery's original owner, whom former mayor Piet Buysse has identified as a man named Théophile van Assche. In an interview with Dutch-language Belgian outlet HLN, Buysse said

the brewery was built in the late 19th century, and van Assche's three children ran the business until it shut down in 1970.

None of the children married or left heirs, Buysse said, and there are few ready clues as to the origin of the gold. The authorities said a stamp on one of the gold bars dated it to the 1960s. In 1982, the property was left to a local Benedictine monastery, which used it as transitional housing for formerly incarcerated people, Hillaert said. Last year, the monks gave the property to CAW Oost-Vlaanderen, the nonprofit that Hillaert directs. (The monastery did not respond to a request for comment.) NYT



राजस्थान सरकार



श्री नरेन्द्र मोदी
माननीय प्रधानमंत्री



श्री भजनलाल शर्मा
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

प्रगति पथ पर गतिमान राजस्थान



17 अगस्त, 2026 | प्रातः 11:30 बजे | कृषि उपज मण्डी, बारां

गरिमामयी उपस्थिति

श्री भजनलाल शर्मा
माननीय मुख्यमंत्री

श्री शिवराज सिंह चौहान
माननीय केन्द्रीय कृषि एवं किसान कल्याण तथा ग्रामीण विकास मंत्री

बारां एवं झालावाड़ जिलों के लिए

₹1,258 करोड़ के 98 विकास कार्यों का शिलान्यास एवं लोकार्पण

प्रधानमंत्री आवास योजना-ग्रामीण

राजस्थान को वित्तीय वर्ष 2026-27 के लिए 2.89 लाख आवासों के निर्माण हेतु ₹ 4600 करोड़ आवंटित

पंचायत समिति मुख्यालयों पर स्वीकृत प्रोटोटाइप आवासों का शिलान्यास

लाभार्थियों को नवीन आवास की चाबी का वितरण

विकसित भारत रोजगार गारंटी एवं आजीविका मिशन-ग्रामीण

कन्वर्जेंस के तहत लगभग ₹2,400 करोड़ के कार्यों को युक्त धारा पोर्टल पर कार्ययोजना में सम्मिलित करना

• प्रमुख कार्य •

अमृत पोषण वाटिका | अमृत ग्रामीण हाट बाजार | ग्रामीण पुस्तकालय
अमृत संजीवनी पार्क | कांजी हाउस पशु आश्रय स्थल | नमो नर्सरी

डीबीटी के माध्यम से राशि हस्तांतरण

मुख्यमंत्री दुग्ध उत्पादक संबल योजना
5 लाख पशुपालकों को ₹280 करोड़

गौशाला अनुदान
751 गौशालाओं को ₹250 करोड़

महिला उत्थान

स्वयं सहायता समूह की दीदियों को ₹10 करोड़ के क्रेडिट लिंकेज चेक का वितरण

राजस्थान महिला निधि की लखपति दीदी ऋण योजना अंतर्गत 957 लखपति दीदियों को ₹8 करोड़ के चेक का वितरण

राजस्थान महिला निधि की समर्थ सखी योजना अंतर्गत स्वयं सहायता समूहों की दीदियों को स्कूटी वितरण

"सशक्त सीएलएफ, समृद्ध दीदी डिजिटल अभियान-2026" का शुभारंभ

ग्राम श्री राजसखी मार्ट 11.77 लाख, बारां का शुभारंभ

Happening today

● **THE JHARKHAND** government has invited students protesting over alleged irregularities in recruitment exams for a fresh round of talks.

● **SUPREME COURT** will hear TN government's plea seeking directions to Karnataka for immediate release of the share of Cauvery water to it.

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Business as Usual

By EP UNNY
Awards unrighted power. After Gen Z, your leaders must address Genists.



BODY FOUND ON TMC OFFICE PREMISES

Bengal ex-Dy Speaker found dead; never took a single penny for any work, says 'suicide note'

Sweetie Kumari
Kolkata, August 16

FORMER DEPUTY Speaker of the West Bengal Assembly and five-time MLA from Rampurhat in Birbhum district, Asish Banerjee, was found dead on the premises of the local Trinamool Congress office on Sunday morning, the police said.

"Primarily, it's a suicide case. We have found a suicide note in which he has written—'no one is responsible for my death,'" Birbhum Superintendent of Police Vidit Raj Bhundesh told *The Indian Express*.

Banerjee lived at Hattalpara in Rampurhat and the

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 2



TMC leader Asish Banerjee's funeral at Rampurhat in West Bengal's Birbhum, Sunday. PTI

Bookies, players, teams: State-run T20 leagues under anti-graft lens

Varinder Bhatia & Venkata Krishna B
Chandigarh, Chennai, August 16

THE BCCI's anti-corruption wing is putting all T20 leagues run by state associations under the scanner to track suspected corruption-related activities by some team owners, organisers and players, sources aware of the crackdown told *The Indian Express*.

"The ACSU (Anti-Corruption and Security Unit) has found increasing instances of bookies and suspicious persons getting in touch with the players,

E. EXPLAINED

Weak links

Franchises in state-level T20 leagues have struggled for big-ticket sponsorships, mainly after the ban on online fantasy gaming platforms. This has opened the door for bookies offering easy money.

team owners, managers, which is against the code of conduct and rules governing the game. It

is the first time that ACSU is covering all matches at state leagues, unlike previously when only Test matches, IPL and other main matches were covered thoroughly," the sources said.

ACSU officials are also tracking those who meet players and team officials in their hotels during these T20 games, they said.

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

IITs go beyond BTech, expand their academic brand: Surge in mid-career courses

Pallavi Smart
Mumbai, August 16

FROM SHORT-TERM certificates to master's degrees, Indian Institutes of Technology (IITs) are increasingly turning their academic brand and industry links toward a domain once associated more with Indian Institutes of Management (IIMs): executive programmes.

The shift has been driven by rising demand for upskilling, growing acceptance of online and hybrid learning after the pandemic, expanding industry partnerships — and the fact that, unlike government-subsidised BTech programmes, these courses pay for themselves through fees.

The trend is clearest at the first-generation IITs, which have expanded their offerings in emerging technology domains over the past four to five years. Almost all IITs now run full-fledged master's programmes and postgraduate diplomas on a line or in hybrid mode, letting working professionals earn an IIT qualification without leaving their jobs.

Artificial intelligence, machine learning and data science dominate demand among working professionals. But IITs are also introducing specialised

● EXECUTIVE EDUCATION AT THE SEVEN FIRST-GENERATION IITs

IIT KHARAGPUR

- At least 10 full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses
- AI, cybersecurity, marketing technology, applied data science

IIT BOMBAY

- Four e-PG diplomas; short-term courses
- AI and ML, e-mobility, design thinking, computer science engineering

IIT KANPUR

- At least nine full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses
- Construction engineering, wireless networks, micro-electronics, smart grid, AI and ML, economics, data analytics

IIT MADRAS

- At least 20 full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses
- AI, EVs, sustainability, manufacturing, digital transformation, supply chain, finance

IIT DELHI

- At least five full PG or master's programmes; short-term courses
- EV technology, advanced



"Today's kids are brilliant... you have to be with a dream for a long time, work on it, only then will it happen"

GROUP CAPTAIN SHUBHAJIT SHUKLA
PAGE 14

Extradite Hasina to set stage for Rahman's visit, Dhaka tells Delhi

Shubhajit Roy
New Delhi, August 16

THE BANGLADESH government said on Sunday that a "propitious environment needs to be created" for Prime Minister Tarique Rahman's visit to India.

"To this end, we have requested the Indian authorities to expeditiously act on our request to extradite Sheikh Hasina and other fugitive criminals, and to hand over to Bangladesh the accused killers of Shaheed Sharif Osman Hadi in compliance with our bilateral

extradition treaty," the Bangladesh Foreign Ministry said in a statement.

While many in Dhaka see this as a 'red line', there is a sense in New Delhi that it needs to convey the "next steps" and give a "coherent response" to the Bangladesh Government's request for extradition. The extradition request was first moved by the interim government led by Prof Muhammad Yunus in 2024, and has been reiterated by the BNP government which assumed office in

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

AT JANTAR MANTAR, 'A LOT OF GROUPS SPEAKING FOR THEIR OWN CAUSES'

Mere degree doesn't prepare for market, that's the fix we need: FM

Sitharaman says private sector won't invest unless there is demand for a certain set of people for a certain set of jobs, so there's need to create situations, identify people

Nirbhay Thakur & Drishti Jain
New Delhi, Jaipur, August 16

IN AN interview with *The Indian Express*, Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman, responding to questions in the wake of the Jantar Mantar protest, spoke on concerns driving India's youth — from exam paper leaks and unemployment to the education-to-employment gap, the quality of government schools, the role of the private sector in creating jobs and the opportunities and challenges facing Gen Z. The interview was conducted on the sidelines of the 1st BRICS Finance Ministers and Central Bank Governors meeting in Jaipur on August 12-13. Excerpts:

When you saw the protest at Jantar Mantar, what was your first impression? Do you think it was just about the NEET paper leak? The protesters were not only NEET aspirants but also people raising concerns about employment, especially the lack of opportunities in the job market.

When such young people come to protest at one place, the issues will never be limited to one thing. That age, between 16 and 26, is a very dynamic age. Jobs? Yes, why not... Paper leaks? Yes, we should... because they are still very idealistic. And at that age, every-



NIRMALA SITHARAMAN
UNION FINANCE MINISTER

thing which is going wrong, even if it is confined to one part of the world, they take it on. Yes,

we will fight for this also. So NEET exam leak expanding to other things is very typical of

that age group.

So there were multiple issues that bothered them?
There was one very distinct feature. There wasn't one coherent narrative or one hierarchical leadership that voiced all the concerns of everybody. Yes, there was a set of people in a group who were the leaders, and they voiced concerns about the paper leaks. But there were other groups with other interests. Those interests were not getting uploaded onto this leadership... There were others with other issues. Whether it was jobs or something else somewhere, they were being talked about to a few groups of journalists who approached them. There were a lot of groups speaking for their own causes. It is common... everybody understood it.

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

EXPRESS special

No full stops in Bengal SIR. Those 'excluded' now in dark about what next

EC tightlipped about cases in tribunals; as SC nudges for clarity, those deleted don't know what is coming: detention, deportation, or pause of govt schemes

Ravik Bhattacharya
Kolkata, August 16

AT LAST court, which was June, around 36.6 lakh cases were still to clear the serpentine Special Intensive Revision (SIR) of poll rolls in West Bengal, their final hurdle being 19 tribunals scrutinising their applications for "logical discrepancies". But, that may not be the end of it.

The Election Commission of India (ECI) has been tightlipped on the details of this unprecedented exercise in Bengal, with another gentle nudge coming from the Supreme Court recently to divulge the figures (the next hearing is on



August 25). There is no clarity even on how many of the "38,000 cases" that the ECI said the tribunals had "disposed of"

till June were of those deleted from the voter list.

The Indian Express managed to track down 10, who now



Among the deleted voters are (above) Amina Paswan, who makes garlands; rickshaw puller Sheikh Bibi Chota and his wife Guria Bibi. PARTHA PAUL

either have "excluded" against their names in the voter list, after tribunal rulings, or who

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 9

VANDE MATARAM ROW

Shah targets Sonia, seeks apology; full version of song played, says Cong



Vice President C P Radhakrishnan, PM Narendra Modi, Speaker Om Birla, Defence Minister Rajnath Singh, Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and BJP chief Nitin Nabin arrive to pay tribute to former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee on his death anniversary, in New Delhi, Sunday. ANI

'Deep pain, anger': Bankim descendant, a BJP MLA, writes to Congress leader

Hamza Khan & Jatin Anand
Jaipur, New Delhi, August 16

A POLITICAL row erupted Sunday after Union Home Minister Amit Shah accused Congress leader Sonia Gandhi of attempting to stop the full rendition of Vande Mataram at the Congress headquarters on Independence Day and said the party should apologise to the nation.

The Congress rejected the charge and defended its leader, saying the full version of the Vande Mataram was sung at the party's Independence Day function.

Speaking at Nimbahera in

Rajasthan's Chittorgarh where a statue of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee was unveiled on his death anniversary, Shah said the Congress had not given Vande Mataram its due respect.

"Chanting Vande Mataram, thousands of people went to the gallows, faced bullets, endured lathi charges, and spent many years in jail. But in its vote-bank greed, the Congress forgot Vande Mataram," he said.

"Look how shameless they are. Vande Mataram was being sung at the Congress party headquarters. During the song, Congress leader Sonijai asked the Congress president to stop the song. We all watched it on TV. After 80 years, Bankim Babu's immortal mantra, his immortal song, was once again receiving respect, but Sonijai didn't like it," Shah said.

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

'Not aimed at Opp': Rijiju clarifies PM's 'dimagi Naxal' remark

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

A DAY after Prime Minister Narendra Modi, in his Independence Day address, called for identifying and isolating "dimagi Naxals" — those allegedly espousing a Maoist mindset — Union Parliamentary Affairs Minister Kiren Rijiju on Sunday sought to clarify that the remark was not directed at Opposition leaders.

Rijiju said Modi had referred only to those who support Maoists, separatists and people who do not believe in the Constitution. He also shared a clip of jailed student leader Sharjeel Imam's speech in which Imam had spoken of cutting off Assam from the rest of India through the Siliguri corridor, referred to as the Chicken's Neck, to draw the Union government's attention.

PM @narendramodi ji

EDITORIAL PAGE P 10

IN YOUTH-DRIVEN VISIT BHARAT, CELEBRATE 'DIMAG'

POLITICS P 5

TDP MP BACKS REMARK, SAYS NEW FORM POSSES THREAT TO YOUTH

didn't say opposition leaders were Dimagi Naxals. Only following are Dimagi Naxals: Who support Maoists and reject Indian Constitution. Who stand with separatists & support Article 370. Who want to cut chicken neck to separate North-East from India," Rijiju said in a post on X.

Rijiju's clarification came a day after Modi said that while armed Naxalism was nearing its end in the jungles, its ideological

▶CONTINUED ON PAGE 2

MCD sanitation worker stabbed to death in East Delhi

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

A 28-YEAR-OLD contractual employee of the Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) was stabbed to death on Sunday while collecting garbage in East Delhi's Kalyanpuri, police said, adding that the motive appeared to be personal enmity.

According to the police, Anil Kumar was standing near a garbage van when the attacker approached and assaulted him. No one has been arrested so far, they said. The incident was captured on a CCTV camera. Police said that a man in a yellow t-shirt was spotted in the footage approaching Anil. He was then seen grabbing Anil by the collar and repeatedly stabbing him before casually walking away, they said.

The MLAs also said that two men, who were seen standing nearby and watching the attack, did not intervene.

A senior police officer said Anil worked as a helper on the garbage collection van. The driver, who was nearby, immediately took him to a hospital in an e-rickshaw, where doctors resuscitated him. The police said the attacker has been identified and is a private sanitation worker from the area.

"Prima facie, it appears to be a case of personal enmity... the accused allegedly held a grudge against Anil and the driver for visiting his house in his absence. We are trying to ascertain the exact motive behind the murder," a police officer said.

Following the incident, local residents and members of Anil's family gathered in the area and



A CCTV grab of the incident.

demanded immediate action against the attacker.

Several sanitation workers of the MCD also staged a dharna, demanding the immediate arrest of the accused. They also sought a government job for one member of Anil's family and proper compensation for the bereaved family. The sanitation workers also raised slogans seeking justice for the victim. AAP MLA Kuldeep Kumar said that he also joined the dharna.

The MLAs met Anil's family at the hospital and protested on its premises, demanding compensation for his family and a police "encounter". "The law-and-order situation in Delhi is out of control. A man who gets up early in the morning to collect garbage from your house has been killed like this. We demand compensation for the victim's family and an encounter," he said.

He also threatened to halt garbage collection work in Delhi. "Till the family gets justice, no sanitation worker will work, and no one will collect garbage in Delhi," he said.

Police reached the hospital and tried to pacify Kumar and Anil's relatives, assuring them that appropriate action would be taken against the attacker. Police said an FIR was filed and further probe is underway.

On Delhi's roads with no seatbelt or helmet? CCTV may be watching

Traffic Police's CCTV surveillance now covers a wider range of offences under pilot project

Sakshi Chand
New Delhi, August 16

TRAVELLING WITHOUT a seat belt in your car or a helmet on a two-wheeler in Delhi? A CCTV camera installed by the Delhi Traffic Police may have possibly captured the violation. Apart from speeding and jumping of red lights, the Delhi Traffic Police's CCTV-based surveillance system is now covering a wider range of offences under a pilot project launched earlier this year, including helmetless rides, ignoring seat belt norms, travelling in the wrong direction and making improper lane changes without prior indication.

"The expansion of camera-based enforcement comes as the Traffic Police increases its reliance on digital monitoring alongside personnel deployed on roads, with the aim of improving compliance with rules and reducing road crashes," Vijayanta Goyal Arya, Additional Commissioner of Police (Traffic) told *The Indian Express*.

EXPRESS special

The Traffic Police has increased reliance on digital monitoring alongside its officers. FILE

What numbers reveal

Delhi first introduced CCTV-based traffic enforcement in March 2019. The system primarily used two types of cameras — Over-speed Violation Detection (OSVD) cameras, and Red Light Violation Detection (RLVD) cameras, which detect red-light jumping and violations at zebra crossings.

By March 2021, Delhi had 125 OSVD and 203 RLVD cameras. Since then, another 125 OSVD cameras — with expanded capabilities — have been added, with the latest installations completed by March. The process of installing 125 additional RLVD cameras is underway, said officers. In the past four months, OSVD cameras with expanded capabilities have issued more than 20,000 challans for various traffic violations, officers added.

Till August 10, according to official data, 3,044 people were challaned for riding two-wheelers without helmets,

while more than 13,405 motorists had been issued challans for driving without seat belts, according to official data. This works out to an average of about 25 helmet violations and 103 seat-belt violations being detected and challaned every day. The cameras are also being used to detect improper lane changes and what traffic officials describe as zig-zag driving. Changing lanes without using an indicator or driving outside the designated lane is a traffic violation, officers said.

Road safety in focus

Earlier, such violations were detected largely by traffic personnel on the road. The penalty for such violations ranges from Rs 500 to Rs 1,000.

Officers said the installation of new OSVD cameras is intended to encourage motorists to follow traffic rules and improve road safety. "Digital enforcement through cameras is being expanded along with the deployment of traffic personnel to ensure better compliance with traffic rules and improve road safety," Arya said.

The scale of automated enforcement is particularly evident in cases of speeding and red-light violations. This year, 1,56,528 vehicles have been challaned for jumping red lights and 1,60,796 vehicles have been issued challans for speeding.



Former Vice-President M Venkaiah Naidu, Delhi Chief Minister Rekha Gupta and others at one of the newly inaugurated canteens in New Delhi on Sunday. ABHINAV SAHA

Capital gets 25 more Atal Canteens; CM recalls Vajpayee's 'reaching the last person' philosophy

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

THE DELHI government has fulfilled the promise of setting up 100 Atal Canteens — aimed at providing nutritious meals to needy citizens for Rs 5 — across the Capital within eight months, Chief Minister Rekha Gupta said on Sunday as former Vice-President M Venkaiah Naidu inaugurated 25 new canteens across the city. The inauguration marked the eighth death anniversary of former Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee.

The Atal Canteen scheme was launched on December 25, 2025, on Vajpayee's birth anniversary. According to the Delhi government, around 95 lakh subsidised meals have been served through the scheme so far. With 100 canteens now operational, the network is expected to serve around one lakh people every day and has the capacity to provide nearly 365 crore meals annually.

"The goal is to provide affordable and nutritious food to the poor, slum dwellers, labourers, and people arriving in Delhi from various parts of the country in search of employment," Naidu said, speaking at the inauguration, adding, "This is no ordinary scheme, but a true example of sensitivity and service towards the most vulnerable sections of society."

Naidu inaugurated the 25

new canteens from the Vishwavidyalaya Metro Station in the presence of Gupta, Urban Development Minister Ashish Sood and BJP MP Manoj Tiwari. Transport Minister Pankaj Kumar Singh and Social Welfare Minister Ravinder Indrajit inaugurated canteens in other parts of the Capital.

The canteens, CM Gupta said, were inspired by Vajpayee's philosophy of Antyodaya, which referred to his philosophy of "reaching the last person in society". She said the government wanted to ensure that no person in the Capital went hungry.

"A canteen has also been opened today near the Delhi University Metro Station. In this university area, students live away from their families in hostels and PG accommodations; now, needy students can access nutritious and affordable food at this canteen," CM Gupta also said.

The 25 canteens inaugurated on Sunday are spread across areas, including Janakpuri, Vikaspuri, Mundla, Mangolpuri, Rohini, R K Puram, New Delhi, Matia Mahal, Model Town, Karawal Nagar, Seemapuri, Vivek Vihar, Timarpur, Mukherjee Nagar, Rithala, Adarsh Nagar, Narela, Shalimar Bagh and Rohini Sector 26.

The CM along with Naidu and her Cabinet ministers also sat down for a meal at one of the canteens.

Eying recovery of Rs 6,000 cr, Delhi extends water bill late payment waiver

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

IN A bid to recover outstanding dues worth Rs 6,000 crore, the Delhi government has extended its scheme offering a full waiver on late payment charges on water bills by another seven months, giving consumers time till March 31, 2027, to clear their principal dues. This is the second extension of the scheme.

The extension was announced by Water Minister Parvash Sahib Singh on Sunday. He said the decision was aimed at providing consumers with an opportunity to settle old dues while also helping the cash-strapped Delhi Jal Board (DJB) recover its "genuine, outstanding revenue".

"For a family, an old water bill can remain a worry for years. When Late Payment Surcharge (LPS) keeps getting added, the amount can become difficult to clear. We wanted to give people a genuine opportunity — pay the principal amount and leave the burden of LPS behind," Singh said, adding, "We are not asking people to pay more. We are asking you to pay what they actually owe. If the principal amount is paid, 100% LPS will be waived. This is real relief for consumers and a responsible way of strengthening the Jal Board's finances."

The waiver applies to both domestic and non-domestic consumers. It covers 14.09 lakh domestic and 70,312 commercial consumers. Earlier, the deadline for availing the scheme was August 15.

The total outstanding pending water bills (including all categories — domestic, government, and commercial) that DJB had to collect under the scheme was Rs 87,589 crore. Of this, the principal amount was Rs 7,125 crore and the charge was Rs 80,463 crore, which is 98% of the total bill.

The scheme covers 14.09 lakh domestic and 70,312 commercial consumers. Earlier, the deadline for availing the scheme was August 15.

The DJB has so far collected Rs 8,118 crore in principal dues from consumers under the scheme.

All 1BHKs under new DDA housing scheme sold out on Day 1

Devansh Mittal
New Delhi, August 16

MORE THAN half of the 1,218 flats on offer under the Delhi Development Authority's (DDA's) new housing scheme in Narela for government and private sector employees were booked on the very first day of sale on Saturday. The entire stock of 1-BHK flats was sold out under Karmajeevi Awas Yojana 2026.

Of the 1,218 flats to move flats put up for sale, 661 were booked on Saturday, a DDA spokesperson said, adding that demand was strong across the 1-, 2- and 3-BHK categories. Bookings had opened on the occasion of the 80th Independence Day on

a first-come, first-serve basis.

"The exceptionally strong response reflects growing demand for DDA housing in Narela and the confidence of homebuyers in DDA's affordable, ready-to-move housing initiatives," the spokesperson said.

Officials said the response builds on DDA's recent sales momentum in Narela. During the first quarter of the current financial year, DDA sold 1,284 flats, generating revenue of over Rs 1,020 crore, of which Narela alone accounted for 1,153 flats — nearly 90 per cent of the total sales, officials said.

The scheme

The scheme offers a flat 25

per cent discount on 1,218 ready-to-move flats at Pocket-11, Sector A1-A4, in Narela. After the discount, prices start at Rs 33,400 lakh for a 1-BHK, Rs 75,55 lakh for a 2-BHK and Rs 1,065 crore for a 3-BHK flat.

The scheme is designed for serving and retired government employees as well as professionals from the corporate, business, entrepreneurial and professional sectors.

The flats are being offered on a freehold basis, with no restriction on existing property ownership for applicants, and amalgamation of adjoining flats is permitted, subject to DDA's prescribed norms and approval. The entire booking

process is online.

According to the DDA, the housing complex is located about 1.2 km from an upcoming Metro station, 1.9 km from a proposed RRTS station, 2 km from the Narela Sports Complex, 5 km from an upcoming education hub and 9.2 km from an upcoming integrated sports stadium. It is also around 500 metres from Urban Extension Road-I, 1.1 km from GT Karnal Road and 6.15 km from Urban Extension Road-II, and overlooks the Mamurpur Forest.

History of Narela

The scheme assumes significance as DDA has historically struggled to sell flats in

Narela owing to connectivity gaps and city issues. Data submitted by Tokhan Sahu, Minister of State for Housing and Urban Affairs, in the Lok Sabha in December last year highlighted the unsold inventory of the DDA. According to the reply, since the early 2000s, DDA has constructed 62,801 flats in Narela, but has been able to sell only half of them.

Narela, recently renamed Vindhyachal, is one of the DDA's three major sub-city projects, along with Dwarka and Rohini.

Address civic concerns or stir grows: Protesting Burari residents to LG

Protest triggered by dilapidated roads, waterlogging and drainage issues

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

DILAPIDATED ROADS, waterlogging and drainage issues triggered a protest in North East Delhi's Burari on Sunday as residents gathered to seek accountability from the public representatives. The security in the area was intensified as protesters grew in number. In a memorandum submitted to the eutenant Governor Tarant Singh Sandhu's office, protesters warned that they would intensify their agitation through "democratic and Gandhian" means if their concerns were not addressed within a month — by September 16.

Organised as a 'Chakka Jam' (road blockade or traffic shutdown) under the banner of the collective, 'Voice of Burari', the demonstration saw residents taking to the streets to highlight what they described as long-standing civic problems. Several residents in Burari, they claimed, including the main 100-foot road, are in dire need of repair. The situation, they said, worsens during the monsoon, when waterlogging and damaged stretches make commuting difficult. They said students, elderly people, women and two-wheeler riders are particularly affected.

According to a police officer, around 200 people gathered near the Burari Chowk and tried to block the road. "Security arrangements were put in place to avoid any untoward



The protest on Sunday. INSTAGRAM/MANGESHYADGIC

incident. They later submitted a memorandum to us which was later submitted to the LG office," an officer said.

Congress's Karawal Nagar district committee chairman and Head of Federations of RWA, Burari Mangesh Tyagi, said the agitation was a reflection of residents' frustration over basic civic amenities. "We are sorry for causing traffic on the road, but the MP, MLA and councillors are all responsible for this condition," Tyagi said. He added that the residents were demanding basic facilities, including roads that are safe and clean enough to walk on and clean drinking water.

Burari MLA Sanjeev Jha, who is also the Chief Whip of the Opposition Aam Aadmi Party in the Assembly, did not respond to queries from *The Indian Express*. BJP MP Manoj Tiwari represents North East Delhi in the Lok Sabha. The memorandum submitted to the LG's office flagged pending road construction work and related drainage works in Burari and sought clear, time-bound directions to the departments concerned and regular updates for residents on the progress of the works. It said the residents were not seeking a confrontation with the government, but wanted a solution to their civic problems.

CISF official suspended for clicking photos of a woman in Delhi Metro

Alok Singh
New Delhi, August 16

A CISF official was suspended for allegedly taking photographs of a woman without her consent inside a Delhi Metro train, police said on Sunday.

The CISF initiated an inquiry against the official, an Assistant Sub-Inspector.

The official was confronted by other passengers after the woman allegedly noticed him taking her photos. The Delhi Police said that the woman, however, refused to file an official complaint against him.

According to a police officer, the incident took place on Saturday evening near AIIMS Metro station on the Yellow Line. The official initially denied taking any photo. However, passengers claimed that multiple photos of the woman were found on his phone.

Some passengers also recorded the incident on their mobile phones. A purported video of the incident was uploaded on social media later. In the purported video, the woman and other passengers are seen confronting the CISF official, who is dressed in uniform.

EXPRESS Careers

Children Welfare Centre (Trust)
CHILDREN WELFARE CENTRE'S COLLEGE OF LAW
(HINDI LINGUISTIC MINORITY INSTITUTION)

APPLICATIONS ARE INVITED FOR THE FOLLOWING POSTS FROM THE ACADEMIC YEAR 2026-27

UN-AIDED
B.A. LL.B (5 YRS. COURSE) & LL.B (3 YRS. COURSE)

Sr. No.	Cadre	Subject	Total No. of Post	Category
1	Principal	---	01	01-OPEN
2	Assistant Professor	Law	25	25-OPEN
3	Assistant Professor	Political Science	01	01-OPEN
4	Assistant Professor	Economics	01	01-OPEN
5	Assistant Professor	English	01	01-OPEN

The above posts are open to all. However, candidates from any category can apply for the post. Candidates having knowledge of Marathi will be preferred.

*Qualifications, Pay Scales and other requirement are as prescribed by the UGC. Application with full details should reach the GENERAL SECRETARY, CHILDREN WELFARE CENTRE'S COLLEGE OF LAW, Valsai Village, Marwa Road, Orlem Bypass, West, Mumbai - 400064 or Email to: career@cwcll.org.in within 15 days from the date of publication of this advertisement.

This is University approved advertisement.

Sd/-
GENERAL SECRETARY

ICL Fincorp
ICL FINCORP LIMITED

This is an advertisement issued for information purpose only.

ICL Fincorp Limited ("our Company" or "the Company" or "the Issuer" or "ICL") was originally incorporated as Jawahar Finance Limited at Chennai, a public limited company under the provisions of the Companies Act, 1956, pursuant to a certificate of incorporation dated December 9, 1991, issued by RoC. The name of our Company was changed to 'Inrijalakuda Credits & Leasing Company Limited' pursuant to a fresh certificate of incorporation dated April 26, 2004, issued by the RoC. Later, the name of our Company was changed to 'ICL Fincorp Limited' pursuant to a fresh certificate of incorporation dated May 8, 2016, issued by the RoC. Our Company holds a certificate of registration dated June 09, 2016, bearing registration number B-07.00437 issued by the Reserve Bank of India ("RBI") to carry on the activities of a non-banking financial company without accepting public deposits under Section 45-IA of the Reserve Bank of India Act, 1934. For further details about our finances, see "General Information" on page 39 of the Prospectus and "History and Certain Other Corporate Matters" on page 127 of the Prospectus.

Registered Office: Plot No. C308, Door No. 66/40, 4th Avenue, Ashok Nagar, Chennai-600 083, Tamil Nadu, India. Tel: +91 44 4208 2381, 2958 0014
Corporate Office: ICL Fincorp Limited, Main Road, Inrijalakuda, Thrissur - 680121, Kerala, India. Tel: +91 480 267 0400, 282 8071, 283 1305;
Corporate Identification Number: U65191TN1991PLC021815; **PAN:** AAACJ1806C; **E-mail:** info@iclfincorp.com; **Website:** www.iclfincorp.com;
Company Secretary and Compliance Officer: Visakh T.V., Email: cs@iclfincorp.com; Tel: +91 480 267 0400, 282 8071, 283 1305;
Chief Financial Officer: Madhavakutty Thekkedath, Email: cfo@iclfincorp.com; Tel: +91 480 267 0400, 282 8071, 283 1305;

PUBLIC ISSUE OF UP TO 10,00,000 SECURED, REDEEMABLE, NON-CONVERTIBLE DEBENTURES (NCDS) OF FACE VALUE OF ₹1,000 EACH

NOTICE TO INVESTORS

This notice is with reference to the public issue of up to 10,00,000 secured, redeemable, non-convertible debentures of face value of ₹1,000 each, ("NCDS") at par for an amount up to ₹5,00,000 thousand ("Base Issue Size") with an option to retain oversubscription of up to ₹5,00,000 thousand aggregating up to ₹10,00,000 thousand (the "Issue") by ICL Fincorp Limited ("Company") in accordance with Securities and Exchange Board of India (Issue and Listing of Non-Convertible Securities) Regulations, 2021, as amended (the "SEBI MCS Regulations"), the applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013, as amended from time to time, and rules made thereunder the SEBI Circular no. SEBI/HO/ODHS/ODHS-Pd/P/CIR/2025/0000000137 dated October 15, 2025, as amended ("SEBI Master Circular"). The Company has filed prospectus dated July 28, 2026 ("Prospectus") with the Registrar of Companies, Tamil Nadu at Chennai ("RoC"), Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") and BSE Limited ("BSE") (the "Stock Exchange"). THE ISSUE IS NOT PROPOSED TO BE UNDERWRITTEN.

ADDENDUM TO THE PROSPECTUS DATED July 28, 2026 ("ADDENDUM")

With reference to the prospectus dated July 28, 2026 ("Prospectus"), filed with the Registrar of Companies, Tamil Nadu at Chennai ("RoC"), BSE Limited ("BSE") ("Stock Exchange") and Securities and Exchange Board of India ("SEBI") in relation to the public issue of secured, redeemable, non-convertible debentures for an amount up to ₹5,00,000 thousand with an option to retain oversubscription of up to ₹5,00,000 thousand, aggregating up to ₹10,00,000 thousand ("Issue") by ICL Fincorp Limited ("Company" or "Issuer"). In this regard, please note the following: The Board of Directors of the Company at their meeting held at the corporate office of the Company on August 14, 2026 has considered and approved the unaudited financial results of the Company for the quarter ended June 30, 2026 ("Financial Results"). The Financial Results have been submitted to BSE Limited and are available on the website of BSE Limited at: <https://www.bseindia.com/xml-data/corplisting/AttachLive/48c82467-43b9-4e87-3a02-63d8d87132a89.pdf> Accordingly, the disclosures appearing in the section titled "Material Developments" on page 153 of the Prospectus shall be read together with the unaudited financial results of the Company for the quarter ended June 30, 2026.

A copy of this Addendum is being filed with RoC in accordance with Section 26 and Section 31 of the Companies Act, 2013. The above information should be read in conjunction with the Prospectus. The information in this Addendum supplements the Prospectus and updates the information in the Prospectus and the Abridged Prospectus, as applicable. All references to the Prospectus shall also include this Addendum. All capitalized terms used in this Addendum shall, unless the context otherwise requires, have the meaning ascribed to them in the Prospectus. The Addendum is available on the websites of SEBI, Lead Managers, Stock Exchange and the Company that is www.sebi.gov.in, www.vvvo.net, www.bseindia.com, and www.iclfincorp.com.

ISSUE PROGRAMME
ISSUE OPENS - AUGUST 10, 2026 (MONDAY)
ISSUE CLOSURES - AUGUST 21, 2026 (FRIDAY)

* The Issue shall remain open for subscription on Working Days from 10:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time), during the period indicated in this Prospectus, except that the Issue may close on such earlier date or extended date as may be decided by the Board of Directors of our Company or the Finance and Management Committee, subject to relevant approvals (subject to a minimum period of two working days and a maximum period of ten working days from the date of opening of this Issue). In the event of an early closure or extension of the Issue, our Company shall ensure that notice of such early closure or extension is given to the prospective investors through an advertisement in a national daily newspaper and a regional daily newspaper in Tamil Nadu where the registered office is located, with wide circulation on or before such earlier date or extended date of closure.

Application Forms for the Issue will be accepted only from 10:00 a.m. to 5:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time) or such extended time or such extended date as may be permitted by the Stock Exchange, on Working Days during the Issue Period. On the Issue Closing Date, Application Forms will be accepted only between 10:00 a.m. to 3:00 p.m. and uploaded until 5:00 p.m. (Indian Standard Time) or such extended time as may be permitted by the Stock Exchange.

Potential Investors can view the detailed Addendum to Prospectus through the QR code and web link given below: (please scan this QR code to view the Addendum to the Prospectus)

Web link: <https://www.iclfincorp.com/filesupload/0Ug9PL94>

Capitalized terms not defined herein shall have the same meaning as assigned to such terms in the Prospectus.

All the potential investors are advised to please provide attention to the above mentioned update and take an informed decision accordingly.

For ICL Fincorp Limited
Sd/-
K.G. Anilkumar
(Chairman & Managing Director) DIN: 00766739

Date: Inrijalakuda
Date: 16/08/2026

A DOSE OF TRUST

In February, India rolled out a critical public health initiative aiming to vaccinate adolescent girls against cervical cancer. Progress has been uneven so far. **VIDHEESHA KUNTAMALLA** made a spot check at Delhi government schools across the Capital.

THE FIRST student in Sarvodaya Kanya Vidyalaya in South Delhi's Fatehpur Beri to take the HPV vaccine was made class monitor.

It was an unusual reward for taking an injection. But in a school where parents were still asking whether the vaccine was safe, whether it could cause illness, or even whether it could affect their daughters' ability to have children, the teachers wanted the girl to become an example for others.

It was a reward, teachers said, for the courage to go first.

The Class X student had first heard about HPV — Human Papillomavirus — only a few weeks earlier, during a morning assembly in the school. "I was the first to get this vaccine in my school, just before my 15th birthday in June," she said.

On the day, she joined 10 other girls, all aged between 14 and 15, and walked to the neighbourhood dispensary. Two teachers accompanied them. Each girl carried a consent form signed by a parent or guardian. Inside, health workers verified their identities before administering the vaccine in the upper arm.

"It felt like a small pinprick," the girl said. "There was no fever, no allergy, nothing happened afterwards."

In Delhi's government schools, the early experience of India's nationwide HPV vaccination drive, launched on February 28, suggests that getting adolescent girls vaccinated may depend as much on winning over their parents as on making the vaccine available. Delhi has administered over 14,000 vaccine doses. In July, the government had made a renewed push in schools with an ambitious target of vaccinating 1.49 lakh girls over the next 100 days.

Teachers and school principals across several schools told *The Indian Express* that concerns about safety, fertility and a lack of awareness about cervical cancer continued to hold parents back, even after several rounds of awareness sessions. Their accounts suggest that building trust through simple language, personal stories and sustained awareness efforts will be key to reaching the government's ambitious vaccination targets.

Back at the school, when the Class 10 student was made class monitor, girls began approaching her with questions, the most common being: "Does it hurt?"

"I told them there was nothing to worry about. Everyone is scared of injections. I told them it was just like a tiny pinprick," she said.

Her father had heard about the vaccine through friends who work at AIIMS. When the school informed us about the drive, he immediately said, "Yes, go ahead." I wasn't scared," the girl said.

Before any girl received the vaccine, a consent form had to be signed. Routed through the government's U-WIN portal, it asks a parent or guardian to declare they understand why the child's personal data is being collected, and that they are aware of "the risks and benefits of the vaccine(s) to be administered".

But signing a consent form did not necessarily mean trust.

Response on the ground

At Fatehpur Beri, when the principal convened a meeting for hesitant parents and students in the school library, the girl and three other vaccinated students were asked to stand before the gathering.

"The principal asked us in front of everyone whether we had fever, allergy or any health problems," she recalled. "We told them nothing had happened."

For many parents in the room, it was perhaps the first time they were hearing directly from a child who had already taken the vaccine.

The school's science teacher quickly realised that "Human Papillomavirus" meant little to many families. Even cervical cancer was unfamiliar.

So, she abandoned medical jargon altogether. She began calling it "bachcheadani

ke muh ka cancer" — cancer at the mouth of the womb.

"We had to speak in the language people understood," she told *The Indian Express*.

The teacher also had a personal reason for encouraging girls to take the vaccine — her sister had tested positive for HPV.

Months of training sessions — online and offline, working through PowerPoint slide decks on HPV, cervical cancer and the questions parents were likely to ask, gave her the vocabulary and her sister's diagnosis gave her the reason to use it.

During a school assembly, she told her students about her decision to get vaccinated.

"The training helped us understand how to explain it simply," she said, but it was the personal disclosure, students and colleagues said, that made parents in the room understand better.

Soon, the response spilled out of the classroom and onto the walls. "Students designed posters and charts in schools explaining cervical cancer," she said, describing rows of hand-drawn diagrams of the reproductive system and slogans urging classmates not to be afraid of "the pinprick."

The exercise, she said, "created more confidence in students and in parents".

Slowly, the girls in her class began coming forward. "We would escort the students to the nearby dispensary almost every alternate day with whoever would come forward," the teacher said.

The response, however, was not the same everywhere. Barely 25 km away, at a CM Shri school in North Delhi, around 20 to 25 girls were eligible for the vaccine. Fourteen parents signed consent forms. Yet, not a single girl, teachers said, has been vaccinated so far.

Among the eligible girls was a 14-year-old whose parents still did not sign the consent form. "My khala (aunt) said I might get sick after the injection," the student recalled. "My mother said we should wait and see what happens to the other girls first."

Two of her friends had also been keen to get vaccinated, she said, until their parents changed their minds after hearing similar stories doing the rounds in the neighbourhood.

A government school in Northeast Delhi's Yamuna

Vihar tells another story. Extensive awareness campaigns here were held in the school — doctors visited, morning assemblies were devoted to the vaccine, school counsellors spoke to students. Still, of roughly 259 eligible girls, the principal said, only close to 60 eventually got the shot. "I honestly didn't expect the numbers to be so low," she said.

The bottleneck

Across the three schools, language was a serious hurdle.

While some teachers explain what HPV and cervical cancer are in simple terms, others reach for family memory instead — mothers, aunts, grandmothers who fell ill. The science teacher at Fatehpur Beri school points to another hurdle: bandwidth.

"Teachers treated it like another duty," she said. "Lists were prepared. Data was sent. But when students didn't go for vaccination, there wasn't much follow-up. No one has taken them to the dispensary yet."

Twice a week, outside her regular classes, she tries to fold HPV into lessons on cells and cancer that students are already studying, but says the school simply doesn't have the staff to do sustained, individual follow-up. "We have very few teachers. Every teacher already has a heavy workload. Sometimes programmes become administrative exercises... we complete the paperwork because that's what we're required to do," she said.

In Yamuna Vihar, the principal identifies "suspicion" as another hurdle.

"They (parents) felt developed countries conduct research here because we have such a large population... Some believed private companies were driving the programme... Others worried about fertility: What if my daughter cannot have children later?"

"The biggest issue is awareness," she

Timeline

2008: Gardasil and Cervarix vaccines enter private market yet inaccessible

2009-10: Vaccine demonstration in Andhra Pradesh and Gujarat suspended after seven girls die. Government probe finds no link.

2016: Punjab launches a pilot in Mansa and Bathinda. Delhi runs a hospital-based programme.

2017: India's vaccine advisory body, NTAGI, recommends including vaccination in the Universal Immunisation Programme. Global vaccine shortages delay the rollout.

2018: Sikkim becomes the first state to offer free, school-based vaccination statewide, reporting over 95% coverage.

2022: CERVAVAC launched. India gets its first indigenous HPV vaccine.

said. "Unless parents understand, nothing changes."

She believes public messaging around HPV has never matched the scale of the campaign. "There should have been much more publicity. People need confidence that this is genuinely in their children's interest."

"The girls listened to us in school when we tried to amplify the awareness around HPV," she said. "It was the parents who needed convincing," she added.

"The kids who come to our school are first generation learners. They come from labour class families... it is harder for us to impart the idea of a vaccine to them than it is for schools in the private sector," the principal said.

The stakeholders

Outside Delhi's government schools, the campaign begins much earlier than the classroom. Every morning, ASHA (Accredited Social Health Activist) workers fan out through narrow lanes carrying lists of names of adolescent girls in their respective neighbourhoods. Their job: explain what HPV is, persuade parents and, and then get them to actually make the trip to the dispensary.

By 9.30 am, Poonam Sharma (43), an ASHA worker for about a decade now, is already knocking on doors in Nanjot.

"We explain that this vaccine protects girls from cervical cancer. But if I explain it to eight or ten families, maybe only one or two eventually go," she said.

The reasons, she added, are rarely medical. "The reasons travel faster than the government," she said. "They tell us the vaccine isn't good. They say girls won't be able to have children later. Sometimes parents understand everything I explain. Then they speak to a neighbour, and the neighbour tells them not to get the vaccine."

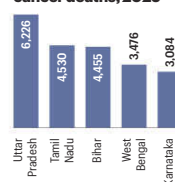
When persuasion fails, she calls in reinforcement: "I ask the ANM (auxiliary nurse midwife) to speak to them. Sometimes they

The numbers: Cervical cancer's burden

Year	India: Estimated cases	India: Deaths	Delhi: Estimated incidence	Delhi: Estimated mortality
2019	—	32,246	—	—
2020	—	33,095	—	—
2021	77,000	33,938	793	428
2022	77,426	34,806	767	414
2023	77,959	35,691	741	400
2024	78,499	—	716	387
2025	79,239	—	692	374

SOURCE: MINISTRY OF HEALTH AND FAMILY WELFARE

Estimated cervical cancer deaths, 2025



listen to her."

In the months since the drive began, Poonam estimated she has spoken to nearly a hundred families. But only around 12 girls in her neighbourhood have been vaccinated, she claimed. Unlike the pulse polio campaign, she points out, the HPV drive has had no memorable public jingle, no slogan to trail it into every home.

So, she has found another way to build trust. "I tell them I have a daughter too... I have got her vaccinated. When they hear that, they feel more confident," she added.

Nearly 20 km away, in Kailash Nagar, Ashu (33), has spent seven years working in the same neighbourhood. Unlike in Nanjot, almost all eligible girls in her area have now been vaccinated.

For Ashu, the difference is familiarity. "We've been visiting these families for years. We work on family planning, malaria, leprosy, routine immunisation, pregnancy, polio. They know us. Trust is built long before any vaccine arrives," she said.

"Five fingers are never the same. Some families agree immediately. Some don't. It also depends on how we explain it. If we don't speak patiently, how will they ever

reach the dispensary?"

Inside Delhi's private schools, the same stakeholders show up in a different light. At ITL Public School in Dwarka, HPV awareness didn't begin with the government's campaign. It had been part of the school's annual adolescent health programme for several years.

Instead of hurried classroom announcements, the school brings doctors, alumni and parents into its auditorium, usually on a Saturday, so working parents can attend. "The biggest questions are always the same," said Surabhi, a teacher who is in charge of the vaccine programme in school. "Parents ask whether the vaccine is safe. They ask whether it will affect fertility." Increasingly, the answers come from former students, many now MBBS graduates, who return to speak to parents and girls. "They immediately connect, because these are girls who once studied in the same classrooms," Surabhi said.

Unlike government schools, ITL doesn't take the students to the dispensary.

"We can only create awareness," she said. "The decision ultimately belongs to the family."



ILLUSTRATION: SUJIT DEY



Showing Up

FORMER NICE President M Venkiah Naidu made a rare appearance at a BJP event in Delhi on Sunday when he inaugurated 25 Atal Canteens to mark former PM Atal Bihari Vajpayee's 8th death anniversary. Naidu, who had resigned from the BJP after being named NDA's candidate for the post of Vice President in 2017 and usually stays away from the party events, made an exception to break bread with Delhi CM Rekha Gupta, BJP Lok Sabha MPs from Delhi, and other senior leaders.

Moving Out

WITH THE demolition of one of the oldest post-Independence government offices in Lutyens' Delhi, Krishi Bhawan, likely to start soon, the Ministries of Agriculture and Animal Husbandry are set to move out of the iconic building and out of Lutyens' Delhi altogether. It is learnt that the two ministries will soon be relocated to the government office complex at Netaji Nagar in South Delhi, while the sites of Krishi Bhawan and neighbouring Shastri Bhawan are to be redeveloped into new secretariat buildings.

Change, Clarity

WEEKS AFTER the Cabinet Secretariat issued a notification bifurcating the Ministry of Housing and Urban Affairs in July, sources say the two new departments are still adjusting to the change. While the CPWD and NBCC, the two construction arms of the ministry, have been listed under Department of Capital Development, sources say the majority of their projects are outside Delhi. Urban transport as a subject is under Department of Urban Development, while Delhi Metro and NRTC are under Department of Capital Development, even though DMRC works as a consultant on metro projects outside the capital. It is learnt that efforts are on to bring clarity on some of the issues.

Gujarat CM heads to US, Canada

Almudabad: Gujarat CM Bhupendra Patel Sunday departed for the US and Canada to promote Vibrant Gujarat Global Summit 2027 to be held in January. The delegation, led by Patel, will hold conferences in Washington DC, New York, San Francisco and Toronto with industrial investors and leaders from tech sector. The visit will conclude on August 24. **ENS**

Why faces of CJP Delhi stir 'missing' in Ranchi

Outfit claims it wants to empower local student leaders, not 'hijack movement'

Shubham Tigga & Alok Singh Ranchi, New Delhi, August 16

HAVING PLAYED a central role in Jantar Mantar agitation against exam paper leaks only weeks ago, the CJP has largely remained in the background in Ranchi as students continue to protest against alleged irregularities in state government exams. The CJP's well-known faces from the Delhi protests — national convener Abhijeet Dipke and co-conveners Saurav Das and Ashutosh Ranka — have been absent from protest. And that, the CJP claims, is by design.

On August 9, Dipke had a video call with Jharkhand Loktantrik Krantikari Morcha (JLKM) leader Devendra Nath Mahato, who has been on a hunger strike. The following day, asked if he would travel to Ranchi, Dipke told reporters in Maharashtra: "Mahato is leading the Jharkhand protest. He was leading the protest and the protest should not be hijacked by the CJP."

Dipke said he was in touch with Mahato and other student leaders and that a CJP team was in Jharkhand. Leading the 25-member delegation is Mukesh

Allrounder, an activist from Rajasthan with a past in AAP like many in the CJP, including Dipke and Ranka.

However, questions have been raised why the outfit that recently led one of the largest student agitations of the past few years — and is now looking to establish its presence across the country — has stayed away from Ranchi demonstrations.

"We have seen that students here have not supported the CJP... If they want to come, they can come, but they should follow the right way of protesting. They should not repeat what the Left organisations did at Jantar Mantar in Delhi, where the protest turned violent," ABVP leader Sauryan Mishra told *The Indian Express*. The RSS's student wing is one of the participants in the protests against the JMM-Congress government.

Mishra said the ABVP does not want outsiders to interfere with the protest and that the protest should remain peaceful. "Slogans like 'Azaadi' are not required here. We don't need such an agenda in Jharkhand. We can protest peacefully," *The Indian Express* reached



Mukesh Allrounder (left) is leading CJP delegation in Ranchi

out to both Abhijeet Dipke and Saurav Das to ask them about their absence from Ranchi, but they did not respond.

However, the CJP's legal affairs lead Ratna Singh told *The Indian Express*, "We have been saying our protest at Jantar Mantar was also supposed to be a leaderless movement and now, going forward, CJP is supposed to act like a political pressure group. We don't want people to hero-worship or think of the CJP as having three faces and expect everything from them. Since the July 25 victory (Dharmendra Pradhan's resignation), the youth have been empowered. They are capable of organising and fighting in their own way towards seeking accountability from any government."

"The people who are protesting over there should feel empowered, not hijacked. We should not feel that they are not capable of bringing that change. The CJP wants that all of them should feel empowered and think that they are capable of organising the protest and demanding accountability from the government," she said.

Singh said she, along with the other top CJP leaders, was in touch with the students in Jharkhand and would join them if their presence was required. "Our 20 to 25-member delegation has already met with them and later more joined. They have been with students who were beaten up badly by the police on August 10," she said.

Mukesh Allrounder said that upon arriving in Ranchi, the CJP delegation first met students and volunteers to understand their demands and what they expect from the outfit. He said the students wanted to know primarily about managing security and keeping the protests peaceful. "Everyone's common response was: how did you win such a big fight at Jantar Mantar? We need your management and your experience," he said.

After receiving feedback from the protesters, the delegation conferred with CJP's national leadership, which in-

structed them that its support would be "from below the stage, not from the stage."

The person behind the outfit's Jharkhand chapter is Amit Singh, a Jharkhand HC advocate who knows Dipke and Ranka through their association with AAP. The Jharkhand chapter, however, remains limited to Ranchi at the moment and has not yet developed district-wise teams.

Ummeh Habiba, a 27-year-old one of the faces of Ranchi protests, told *The Indian Express* she had also spoken to Dipke. "He said he stood with us but that his health was not good at the time and he would come once he recovered," said Habiba, one of the students on hunger strike. While many students allied to BJP do not want CJP's presence at the protest, Habiba said the outfit's role in building this momentum could not be denied.

Chandan Rajak, one of the organisers of JPSC-JSSC Abhyarthi Nyay Manch, said the protesters would welcome CJP's continued solidarity but did not necessarily want its leaders to take a more leading role in the movement. "We welcome solidarity from CJP as it has sparked that enthusiasm in India to fight against injustice and corruption. However, we do not want anyone to hijack the stage."

Protesters: If demands not met, Soren should quit



Students during an indefinite hunger strike in Ranchi on Sunday.

Shubham Tigga Ranchi, August 16

AS THE JPSC-JSSC students' protest entered its 23rd day, protesters on Sunday announced a change in the "framework of their movement" as they issued an ultimatum to the Jharkhand government and warned of a march to Chief Minister Hemant Soren's residence on August 20 if their demands were not fulfilled.

The students also officially announced, for the first time, that they would demand the CM's resignation if the government fails to meet their demands. They also announced plans to burn the effigies of Soren, Congress leader Rahul Gandhi and other leaders associated with the ruling alliance across all 24 districts of Jharkhand on Sunday evening.

The announcement marks an important turn in the student agitation, which has intensified since the August 10 march towards the Jharkhand Assembly, when protesters clashed with police and faced water cannons, tear gas and baton charges.

Piyush Singh, a spokesperson for JPSC-JSSC Reform Manch, said the students have four principal demands: Cancellation of the JSSC-CGL (Jharkhand Staff Selection Commission-Combined Graduate Level) examination, cancellation of the 11th to 13th JPSC exams, cancellation of all exams conducted

through or linked to TDPL (the testing agency), and involvement of CBI in the inquiries.

Last week, as the government announced cancellation of three JPSC-linked exams, a minister said the CGL exam results could not be cancelled as the process was conducted under the monitoring of the Supreme Court and the High Court.

"If these demands are not fulfilled by the government, we will march towards the Chief Minister's residence. We are officially announcing for the first time that if these demands are not met, the Chief Minister will have to resign," Singh said.

Another student leader, Ravindra Paswan, said the protesters would now change the framework of their movement. "The time has come to change the framework of the movement. The Gandhian movement is over. Now we will become Bhagat Singh. Even if we have to take a bullet, we will take it on our chest," Paswan said.

Responding to the students' ultimatum, spokesperson of the ruling Jharkhand Mukti Morcha Manoj Pandey said the government has been taking the issue seriously since the beginning. Questioning the involvement of coaching operators and teachers, Pandey said, "Why is there a need for coaching operators or coaching teachers to come into this matter? Why are they guiding the students?" he said.

Harsimrat writes to Shah, seeks NIA probe into attacks on Sukhbir

Raakhi Jagga & Divya Gopal Gopal Ludhiana, August 16

MP HARSIMRAT Kaur wrote to Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Sunday seeking a National Investigation Agency (NIA) probe into the August 13 kirpan attack on her husband and SAD chief Sukhbir Singh Badal in Maharashtra and an assassination attempt on him at the Golden Temple in December 2024.

Harsimrat Kaur described the August 13 incident in Maharashtra's Nanded as a "dastardly and heinous assassination bid".

The two assassination at-

tempts had "several disturbing parallels" and raised serious questions about whether they were connected and a "larger conspiracy" behind them, the former Union Minister said in her letter to Shah.

"I write with a mix of personal pain and profound concern for our society, our state of Punjab and our country, particularly over the manner in which violence is being normalised and even justified by persons holding positions of power in Punjab, apparently as a means of pursuing political battles," wrote Kaur, who was present at the time of the attack at Gurdwara Mata Sahib Devan Ji in Nanded.



Army Chief begins Nepal visit

Army Chief General Dhiraj Seth arrives in Kathmandu on a four-day official trip on Sunday. He is set to visit the Nepal Army Headquarters on Monday.

TDP MP backs PM's 'dimagi Naxal' remark: New 'form' threat to youth

Press Trust of India New Delhi, August 16

TDP MP and former IPS officer Tenneti Krishna Prasad, an NDA ally, on Sunday backed PM Narendra Modi's "dimagi Naxals" remark, saying a new form of "intellectual Naxalism" has emerged and poses a danger to the country and its youth.

"The forest Naxalites and Maoists have been removed from the forests; now this new form has emerged. Therefore, we have to remain extremely vigilant and protect our country, especially our youth," he said in a video statement.

The "dimagi Naxal" reference came from Modi's Independence Day address to the nation, in which he warned against people who were looking for an opportunity to trigger violence. In an apparent reference to Congress leader Rahul Gandhi, Prasad said, "Today, the forest Naxalites have gone, and a new form has emerged. I call them 'intellectual Naxalites'. They do not operate in forests; they operate in cities. They organise seminars in AC halls."

"They take foreign money and work to destroy our country. Those who run this so-

called intellectual Naxalism live in our country but repeatedly go abroad and conduct seminars and bring money from outside," he said, without taking any name.

Prasad said he served as an IPS officer for 35 years and during that period he fought Naxalism in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, where he witnessed the impact of the extremist left ideology on the lives of the young people.

"Whether it is Maoist, Naxalism, forest Naxalism or what I call intellectual Naxalism, both are prepared to destroy our country," he added.

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"They take foreign money and work to destroy our country. Those who run this so-

With multi-layer barricading, Haryana seals Khanauri border to stop farmers' Delhi march

Express News Service Chandigarh, August 16

HARYANA POLICE have set up multi-layer barricading along the inter-state border point Sunday and sealed it as farmers under the banner of SKM (Non-Political) gathered to enter Haryana through the Khanauri-Datla Singh Walia border.

The Samyukta Kisan Morcha (Non-Political) had given a call for a 228-km "Kisan Bachao Padayatra" from Datla Singh Walia village on Haryana-Punjab border to Jantar Mantar in Delhi, which would culminate in a farmers' panchayat in Delhi on August 29. The march has been



At Khanauri border in Jind after farmers' 'Kisan Bachao Padayatra' call to march to Jantar Mantar, on Sunday.

planned against the proposed India-US trade deal and to press for a legal guarantee for MSP. On the Haryana side of Kha-

nauri inter-state border point, authorities have put up concrete barricades, positioned riot control vehicles, while barbed

wire has also been installed. A police official from Jind district Sunday said the farmers do not have permission for the march. SKM (non-political) leader Jagjit Singh Dallewal said the barricading has exposed the BJP government. "Earlier, they had a problem when farmers came with tractors. Now, a small group of farmers wants to march to Delhi, they still are not allowing us to proceed. This exposes the anti-farmer face of the government."

He also claimed that Haryana Police detained some leaders of the outfit at different places ahead of the march which was to start from Khanauri.

FROM JANTAR MANTAR TO RANCHI, YOUTH PROTESTS HAVE PROMPTED CMs ACROSS PARTY LINES TO ANNOUNCE A SLEW OF WELFARE MEASURES IN THEIR INDEPENDENCE DAY SPEECHES

Jobs to exam coaching, how CMs are trying to douse discontent among youth

Lalmuni Verma Lucknow, August 16

RATTLED BY the youth protests in Delhi and Ranchi, a theme running through the Independence Day speeches and announcements of political leaders — from PM Narendra Modi to CMs of BJP and Opposition-ruled states — was "yuva shakti (youth power)."

BJP CMs in Uttar Pradesh, Uttarakhand, and Goa — all go to polls next year — made promises designed for the youth.

UP CM Yogi Adityanath announced a new youth policy to strengthen skills, innovation, abilities, and employment of youngsters aged 16-35 years. "The government has taken strict action against cheating mafia and recruitment mafia, and the state's demographic dividend is being transformed

into a 'development engine'. For Gen Z and Gen Alpha, work has been rapidly advanced in areas such as AI, Machine Learning, semiconductors, startup ecosystem, data centres, defence manufacturing, cyber, robotics, EVs, agri-tech, fintech, ed-tech, and med-tech," he said.

In Uttarakhand, CM Pushkar Singh Dhami announced "Mukhya Mantri Yuva Bhavishya Nirman Yojana", allocating Rs 7 crore for it, to improve opportunities of government school students for competitive exams. Free online coaching will be provided to 10,000 students in Classes 11 and 12.

Dhami also announced a "Yuva Ayog (youth commission)" and that the "Mukhya Mantri Yuva Swarojgar aur Udhamsita Protshan Yojana" (youth self-employment and entrepreneurship incentive scheme)"

will be launched for those in the 18-30 age group.

Goa CM Pramod Sawant announced that more than 2,000 jobs will be offered to youngsters through the Goa Staff Selection Commission.

A BJP leader in UP said the recent protests in Delhi had brought the period he fought Naxalism in Telangana and Andhra Pradesh, where he witnessed the impact of the extremist left ideology on the lives of the young people.

"Whether it is Maoist, Naxalism, forest Naxalism or what I call intellectual Naxalism, both are prepared to destroy our country," he added.



CM Yogi Adityanath pays tribute to Atal Bihari Vajpayee in Lucknow on Sunday.

CMs have been made to convince the youths that the government is taking steps for their employment and skill development and that they should not fall into the trap of the Opposition that is trying to mislead them."

Like in the states going to polls early next year, announcements poured in from other BJP-ruled states too. **GUJARAT:** In the state where elections are due in late 2027, CM Bhupendra Patel announced that "for youth from the non-creamy layer section (in reserved categories), the family's annual income limit for foreign study loans has been increased from Rs 6 lakh to Rs 10 lakh."

ASSAM: In his 11 resolutions for a Viksit Assam, CM Himanta Biswa Sarma said a new department of "youth empowerment and development" would work for youth welfare. Sarma, how-

ever, said he doesn't believe in demographic concepts such as Gen Z or Gen Alpha. "These are concepts from Western culture. For me, they are my sons and daughters. For our new generation, we have a responsibility to work for them and use the state's resources."

BHARAT: Samrat Choudhary announced a State Examination Reforms Committee to make exams smooth, transparent, fair, and modern. A "student support portal" will be launched on August 17 to help redress students' grievances within 30 days, said the CM. **CHHATTISGARH:** CM Vishnu Deo Sai announced a "CG Assistant for Competitive Exam" scheme for financial and logistical support to youth preparing for major competitive tests. **MADHYA PRADESH:** CM Mohan Yadav said his govern-

ment had decided to observe 2027 as "Yuva varsh" and focus on quality education, skill development, entrepreneurship, employment opportunities in public, private sectors and support for start-ups, among others.

RAJASTHAN: Though there were no youth-specific announcements in Rajasthan, CM Bhajan Lal Sharma in an interaction with youngsters in Bikaner assured them his government was fully committed to their all-round development.

Opp states join in

In Himachal Pradesh, CM Sukvir Singh Sukhla said, "Our Congress government provided government jobs to thousands of youths and ensured transparency in recruitment process. During our tenure, not a single recruitment paper was leaked, whereas during previous

BJP government's tenure, the police recruitment paper was leaked and large-scale irregularities occurred in SSC's recruitments, to the extent that papers were even sold."

Himachal goes to polls later next year. Sukhla said the government has dissolved the State Election Commission Board and ensured that those responsible were in jail.

In Jharkhand, where students are protesting alleged irregularities in JPSC and JSSC exams, CM Hemant Soren said protecting the dreams of youths was his personal responsibility. Soren said he had acted against the guilty and would ensure reforms in the system.

The CM also said his government had initiated an interactive programme "Chhatron Ki Baat — Chhatron Ke Sath" to seek students' suggestions.



100

DAYS OF BHOROSHA



A
New Chapter Begins
in West Bengal



Shilpo | Swastho | Siksha | Sushashon
Shoshoktikoron | Seva | Suraksha | Samriddhi



सत्यमेव जयते
পশ্চিমবঙ্গ সরকার

পশ্চিমবঙ্গ সরকার
Government of West Bengal

100 DAYS

PORIBORTON AT A GLANCE

» 100 DAYS OF SHILPO

- ₹54,000+ crore worth investment proposals
- ₹5,000 crore Investment Promotion Framework
- Single-window clearance for investments above ₹100 crore
- ₹100 crore Startup Fund to encourage new ventures and young entrepreneurs

» 100 DAYS OF SUSHASHON

- Anti-Goonda Act brought into force
- Janatar Darbar brings people's grievances directly to the Chief Minister
- Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita and Bharatiya Sakshya Adhiniyam implemented across the State
- Toll-free helpline to report bribery, extortion, illegal toll booths and illicit liquor trade

» 100 DAYS OF SURAKSHA

- 1,000+ acres transferred to the BSF to strengthen border security
- Durga Suraksha Squads and Pink Patrols patrolling streets to ensure women's safety
- Cyber Help Desks in every police station to combat cyber fraud
- Women's Police Stations in every subdivision and Women's Help Centres in every police station

» 100 DAYS OF SAMRIDHI

- West Bengal's first Atal Incubation Centre (AIC Techno) launched in Kolkata, to nurture young entrepreneurs and startups
- Transparent OBC reservation framework ensures the annulment of the unlawful 17% reservation and ensuring a fair 7% reservation
- 2 crore+ trees already planted across the state under the Ekti Gaach Mayer Namey initiative
- New airports to come up in Purulia, Balurghat and Malda, with a second greenfield airport underway in Kalyani

» 100 DAYS OF SWASTHO

- Free treatment up to ₹5 lakh under the Mukhyamantri Swasthya Yojana
- 1.43 crore families covered under Ayushman Bharat
- 2,000-bed state-of-the-art hospital coming up in New Town, with 1,000 beds reserved for the underprivileged
- AIIMS and a state-of-the-art cancer hospital in North Bengal, along with modern state-run hospitals in the Sundarbans and Jangalmahal

» 100 DAYS OF SHOSHOKTIKORON

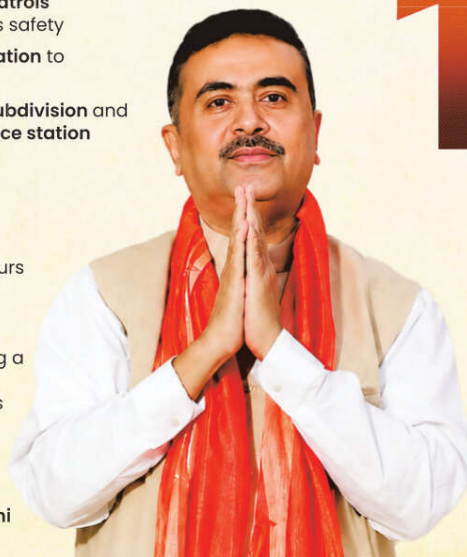
- ₹3,000 monthly credited to the bank accounts of 1.19 crore Annapurna beneficiaries
- Free travel for women on government buses
- To secure the future of the youth, work has already commenced for creating 1 lakh government jobs by the next year
- 33% reservation for women announced in government jobs

» 100 DAYS OF SIKSHA

- Higher Mid-Day Meal allocation and improved food quality in collaboration with ISKCON
- Nearly 35,000 books from libraries across West Bengal made easily accessible online
- ₹296 crore financial assistance to improve government and Bengali-medium schools
- Sanitary napkin vending machines installed in government schools; 10 lakh+ girl students covered under Kanyaratna

» 100 DAYS OF SEVA

- ₹60,000 provided to 10.20 lakh beneficiaries under Awas Yojana
- Fish and rice now served at Maa Ahar canteens
- ₹500 increase in monthly pensions for senior citizens, widows and persons with disabilities
- Daily food allocation for patients in government hospitals increased from ₹56 to ₹110



DAYS OF BHOROSHA

A commitment to development.
A vision for a prosperous West Bengal.

**NEW GOVERNMENT | NEW DIRECTION
NEW WEST BENGAL**

ICAND1263(17)/2026

CJP volunteer's father who was assaulted after 'assessing' govt school dies in Bengal

Tanuserree Bose
Kolkata, August 16

THE COCKROACH Janta Party (CJP) on Sunday demanded the immediate arrest of the assailants responsible for the alleged assault that led to the death of Janab Mafik, father of CJP volunteer Shaik Abdul Hafeez, in West Bengal's Bankura district. Hafeez and his family were allegedly attacked on Thursday after they visited a government school in his village in the Karinda area to assess it as part of the CJP's ongoing 'School Thik Karo' (improve the schools) campaign. Mafik died Saturday from severe head injuries sustained during the alleged attack, the CJP said in a statement.

The CJP announced Sunday that a CJP National Working Committee delegation, led by co-convenor Ashutosh Mondal, will visit West Bengal on Monday to stand in solidarity with Hafeez.

In a social media post, CJP founder and national convener Abhijeet Dipke alleged that the volunteer's family was attacked by "goons allegedly from the BJP". According to Hafeez, on August 13, he visited the local government school in his village in the Karinda area to assess the condition of the school's infrastructure as part of CJP's nationwide campaign.

He alleged that later that evening, armed individuals, whom he identified as alleged "local BJP karyakartas", allegedly forcibly entered his house and demanded that he record a



Janab Mafik, father of CJP volunteer Shaik Abdul Hafeez, died of injuries on Saturday. EXPRESS

video statement apologising for highlighting the school's conditions while claiming that he had done so under external influence. When Hafeez refused to comply, the miscreants allegedly attacked him. Hafeez sustained a severe neck injury, while his father, Janab Mafik, who had intervened to save his son, suffered a critical blunt-force trauma to the head. His father succumbed to his injuries on Saturday.

Speaking to the media, Hafeez said, "Police arrived and we rushed my father to the hospital, but many BJP workers had surrounded the hospital and were not allowing us to leave. While we were returning home from the hospital, the assailants again surrounded us in a dark area and assaulted us for the second time. They took my mobile phone and deleted all the videos from social media."

Meanwhile, Chief Minister Suvenudhi Adhikari claimed no BJP workers were involved in the incident, and vowed strict action against those responsible.

THREE SUSPECTS ARRESTED

Bengal Congress leader, son shot & hacked to death

CM flags 'TMC link' of assailants; Mamata faction distances itself

Tanuserree Bose
Kolkata, August 16

CONGRESS LEADER Anisur Rahman and his son Abu Sufian, 24, were first shot at and then hacked to death by unidentified miscreants near the Bethuadahari railway crossing in Nadia district on Saturday evening.

The attack was carried out just 200 metres from their residence returning home in a car. Meanwhile, the police have arrested three persons in connection with the murder.

Rahman was a member of the Pradesh Congress Committee and General Secretary of the Nadia District Congress Committee. According to family members, Rahman's son was studying law and planned to go to London for further studies.

The assailants allegedly opened fire at the vehicle before attacking the two men with sharp-edged weapons. The car



in which the duo was travelling has been riddled with bullets and the windows were smashed. Both died on the spot due to excessive blood loss, officials said.

The bodies of both the father and the son have been taken to the local Nakhshipara hospital for a post-mortem examination.

Mourning his death, a relative of Rahman said, "He (Rahman) was a long-time Congress leader who worked for the people. He must have been a victim of political enmity, but his son had nothing to do with politics. We want justice."

The arrested accused are Fatema Bibi — the head of Har-

nagar Gram Panchayat from the TMC; Sageb SK; and Mithu Sheikh. The arrests were made after Rahman's family alleged that Bibi was linked to the murders.

The three accused were produced before Krishnanagar court, which remanded them to nine days in police custody.

The police are also scanning CCTV footage from the area to track down the assailants.

Reacting to the double murder, Chief Minister Suvenudhi Adhikari said in a press conference on Sunday, "The SP (Superintendent of Police) informed me that Jabbar Sheikh, who is in jail, is responsible for



(Top) Congress leader Anisur Rahman; (left) West Bengal Congress chief Shubhankar Sarkar with Rahman's kin. PTI

the murder. Already, his wife, who is a TMC pradhan, has been arrested."

Tinamool Congress MLA from the Mamata Banerjee-led faction, Kunal Ghosh told mediapersons, "We condemn the killings; the police should investigate the matter. The blame is now being given that a TMC leader is involved; now we have to see whether that person belongs to the 'good TMC'."

Senior Congress leader Adhir Ranjan Chowdhury said, "We demand a proper and impartial investigation and exemplary punishment for the guilty at the earliest."

—WITH PTI INPUTS



The flooded school in Kendrapada. Over 5 lakh people have been affected due to flood-like situation in northern Odisha districts.

Flood water cuts off Odisha residential school, leaves 300 students stranded

Sujit Bisoyi
Bhubaneswar, August 16

NEARLY 300 STUDENTS, including over 100 girls, of a state-run residential school in Odisha's Kendrapada district are stranded after rising waters of Brahmani River inundated the area amid incessant rainfall over the past 24 hours.

Officials said on Sunday that the students of the Kula-sahi Ashram School in the district's Pattanmunda block have been shifted to the first floor of the school building after flood water entered the school premises. At present, the school is completely cut off due to the rising water level. The students were still on the premises when the last reports came in.

Speaking to *The Indian Express*, Kendrapada district collector Raghuram Iyer said all the students are safe. "The school premises are surrounded by flood water due to rising water levels in the Brahmani River. Senior officials were sent to the school to take stock of the situation. We haven't taken any decision to evacuate the students from the campus," said Iyer.

The administration is keeping a close watch on the situation, the collector said, adding, adequate food and drinking water are available for the students.

An official, who visited the school, said the kitchen and drinking water system at the school is intact. A fire service team with boat has been deployed near the school. "In case there will be a rise in the water level, and if there is a need for evacuation, we are ready for it," said an official.

Officials said the school, run by the scheduled caste and scheduled tribe department of the state government, is located in a low-lying area close to the riverbank.

Meanwhile, over 5 lakh people have been affected due to flood-like situation in several northern districts due to heavy rain while the situation is grim in Bhadrak, Balasore and Jaipur. More than 2.5 lakh people from the low-lying areas of the affected districts have been shifted to safe shelters after flood water inundated several habitations.

Odisha Chief Secretary Anu Garg on Sunday directed the district collectors to keep a close watch on the situation. Three senior IAS officers have been deputed by the state government in Balasore, Bhadrak and Jaipur to monitor the overall relief, evacuation and restoration measures on the ground.

At least 36 teams of Odisha Disaster Rapid Action Force (ORDAF), seven teams of NDRF and 36 fire service teams have been deployed with boats and other equipment in the affected areas to help the administration in relief and rescue operations.

"The administration has been put on alert while leaves of all government officials in the affected districts have been cancelled. The water resources department has also sent senior engineers for surveillance on the situation and for necessary intervention," said the chief secretary.

Chief minister Mohan Charan Mahli is scheduled to visit the flood affected areas in Bhadrak and Jaipur on Monday, said officials.

Navy sailor, wife, 2 children found dead at Mumbai home; cops suspect suicide

Apoorva Agashe
Mumbai, August 16

AN INDIAN Navy sailor, his wife and their two children, including a two-month-old infant and a three-year-old boy, were found dead at their South Mumbai home in Navy Nagar, Cuffe Parade police said Sunday.

The deaths came to light on the night of August 15 when police received information that a family has been found dead in Navy Nagar.

"It is suspected that the sailor died by hanging and the wife and children died due to

poisoning. The bodies have been sent for postmortem," a senior police officer said from South Mumbai said.

Police have identified the deceased as Puranmal Shambhulal Mehra, 30, the sailor, his wife Oma Puranmal Mehra, 28, and their son, Yash Puranmal Mehra. Police said no far suicide note has been recovered.

"We suspect the couple had disputes due to which the family took extreme steps," police said.

In a statement, the Indian Navy said it was providing all necessary assistance to the family.

Mahender Singh Manral
New Delhi, August 16

THE MINISTRY of Home Affairs has asked states and Union Territories to ensure timely processing of extradition requests for fugitives abroad, flagging that delays by state police and investigating agencies can hamper efforts to bring them back, while also directing setting up of prison facilities in central jails that meet international standards, *The Indian Express* has learnt.

According to a source, "The MHA has sought updated details on the status of international treaty compliance, prison facilities and cases proposed to be withdrawn from extradition proceedings."

India has brought back 274 fugitives from 36 countries since 2021 — a sharp escalation in extradition and deportation efforts. Earlier this month, in a communication to Chief Secre-

taries and DGPs of states/UTs, the MHA has said it had been observed that even after fugitives are traced or arrested abroad on the basis of Interpol notices, the state police or investigating agencies concerned often delay sending provisional arrest requests or formal extradition requests to the ministry, the source said.

Such delays, the communication said, adversely affect India's efforts to secure return of fugitives, as foreign authorities are bound by their domestic laws and treaty obligations. "If formal extradition requests are not submitted within the stipulated time, the fugitive may be released, the period of provisional arrest may lapse, or the person may flee from the foreign country's jurisdiction, making the process of tracing and arresting them again extremely difficult," the source said.

This comes after an official meeting last month with top officials of

states/UTs, and central agencies, where issues related to strengthening extradition processes were reviewed, the source said. According to the source, the ministry has underlined that preparing a legally sound extradition request is primarily the responsibility of the investigating agency or state police concerned. The extradition process, however, requires coordination among the investigating agency or state police, the CBI through Interpol, the Union Home Ministry, the Ministry of External Affairs and the Indian mission concerned.

The MHA has advised all states/UTs and law enforcement agencies to prepare extradition dossiers in advance for cases in which Interpol Red Notices have been issued, so that provisional arrest or extradition requests can be sent immediately once a fugitive is located or arrested abroad, the source said.

During the meeting last

month, the source said that discussions were held on "setting up extradition cells with collector staff, developing prison facilities in accordance with international standards, converting Interpol Blue Notices into Red Notices, and delays in forwarding extradition requests in cases where fugitives had been located abroad."

The MHA also noted that some states and agencies had been reluctant to proceed with extradition in matrimonial disputes and other cases which, according to them, may not meet the legal threshold of extradition. However, decisions in such matters had not been communicated to the MHA, the source said.

The ministry has also directed that all pending extradition matters be reviewed and cases unsuitable for extradition be identified or which they propose to withdraw from the extradition process.

{ FROM PAGE 1 }

No full stops in Bengal SIR

fear they have been deleted as they are yet to even get an acknowledgment from tribunals on their applications.

All remain unsure of what awaits them next: detention, deportation, denial of government benefits, a long court case, or re-application from the start?

The state BJP government has been accused of deleting SIR status, while the opposition has said it is a "new voter" — is an option.

Sabia Khatun, 42; father Samsul Alam, 72; residents of Bolpur, Sabia and Samsul have been struck off the voter list by a tribunal, though Samsul's son Intekhab Alam has got in. They heard in May that the tribunals had ruled against them, says Intekhab.

While Samsul works as a helper at a cloth shop in Kolkata, Sabia is divorced. Before the 2026 elections, in which they contested, Sabia was due to their SIR status, but she had been voters in the Bolpur Assembly constituency.

A factory worker, 43-year-old Intekhab says, "There is panic and fear in the family. My name, my uncle's name that are in the voters' list, but that of my father and sister are deleted. My father worked in Kolkata and therefore his name was not on the voters' list of 2002 (which is seen as conclusive proof by the ECI). My father and sister were called for hearings, where they gave all the documents, including their secondary board and

higher secondary board certificates. But then their names went to the tribunal. In May we learnt that their names had been deleted. They got no notice."

The family then moved the Calcutta High Court. On August 4, the court directed the tribunal to once again adjudicate Samsul's case, while Sabia's petition is yet to be heard. In his order, Justice Krishna Rao said, "...the Appellate Tribunal is requested to consider and dispose of the appeal preferred by the petitioner as early as possible, preferably within a period of three months from date."

Speaking over the phone from Birbhum, Sabia tells *The Indian Express*, "What can I say? Every day I see ministers saying that those struck off the voter list will not be a part of government schemes like ration. I am still getting my rations. But we live in fear."

In his very first Cabinet meeting, Chief Minister Suvenudhi Adhikari said that those deleted in the SIR will not be able to avail state government welfare schemes, though exceptions will be made for those whose applications are pending before tribunals or who have applied under the Citizenship (Amendment) Act. Other ministers have since repeated the warning.

Sabia and Samsul's Booth Level Officer (BLO), Kabita Rajak, told *The Indian Express*, "Samsul's parents too are not in the 2002 voters' list. They may

have given school certificates, but I don't remember."

Manjura Begum, 31, a resident of Arambagh in Hooghly, the 31-year-old says she came to know on July 1 that her name was "excluded" from the voter list. Married to Sheikh Jiadul Hussain, a carpenter, Manjura has three children, and has voted earlier in the Arambagh Assembly seat.

Says Hussain, "My wife's parents were voters in 2002. We gave this and other documents to the BLO, but then her name went to adjudication. Again, during the hearing, we gave all the documents. Then her name went to the tribunal. Now she is not a voter anymore."

The process was marked by errors, Hussain says. "Manjura has four siblings, but the notice to her stated there were seven of them. Now, all her brothers and sisters have cleared the SIR, but she has been dropped."

On July 28, Manjura moved the Calcutta High Court, and is waiting for a hearing. Her lawyer Saloni Bhattacharya says: "This is purely harassment of people. When we were pleading the case, the ECI lawyer said it was not necessary to call people for a hearing (before the tribunals). But we contested saying that my client had a right to be heard."

Questioning the functioning of the tribunals, Bhattacharya says, "My client, like me and wife's names are there, but mine was dropped. They did not even call me to ask for my documents," says Khan, who has been a voter in the Sreerampur

Assembly seat. A construction worker, the 48-year-old, who lives with his wife, son and mother, is not clear what to do next. "My father's name was in the 2002 voter list. But mine was deleted. I asked the BLO, he too is clueless."

BLO Khurshid Anwar said, "I really don't know why his name has been deleted."

Amina Paswan, 50: The 50-year-old lives in a slum along the railway tracks near Nimtolla in Kolkata, and makes flower garlands for a living. After losing her husband 17 years ago, she raised her son on her own.

Amina says that she found out in April that while her son Rabi, 30, had made it to the voter list, she was out, despite attending a hearing. "Then, with the help of a local NGO, I submitted my appeal to the tribunals offline." She never heard anything from the tribunals, she says, not even an acknowledgment.

The ECI website shows "excluded" against her name.

Amina, who earlier voted in the Shyampur Assembly seat, says: "My husband's name was not in the 2002 voters' list, though he came from Bihar long back. But his brother's name was there. I gave my documents linked to my husband's, along with other documents. My son submitted papers linking to his uncle, and his name was cleared."

Scared of what is to come, Amina says: "I get a widow pension from the government along with rations. This has not stopped, but I fear it will soon. I do not have money to go to

court. I just earn Rs 200 daily selling flower garlands."

Her BLO Kalyan Bisi said: "I don't want to talk about it." Pinki Das, 34: Amina's neighbor at the Nimtolla slum, Pinki works as a domestic help. Her husband Sachu, 45, is originally from Madhubani in Bihar but settled in Kolkata years back, she says. He is in the voter list.

"We got our voter card, Aadhaar card, e-shram card, everything made here. I have never been here (in the Shyampur Assembly seat). I have four children, all born here," she says.

Pinki says after her name didn't make it to the SIR final list, despite her attending a hearing at a local school on January 6, she applied to the tribunals. "I never got a receipt," she says, leaving her in the dark about her status.

Pinki, who has four children, says her family depends on her earnings. "My husband, a rickshaw puller, is a drunk. What will I do if my name doesn't make it to the voter list? My rations are continuing, but how long? I am not a Bangladeshi."

Of Pinki's four children, three are in school while another is training in hotel management with an NGO. "What will their future be?" Her BLO Kalyan Bisi said: "I don't want to talk about this."

Soni Devi, 30: A neighbour of Amina and Pinki, Soni says she finds herself in the same boat. "My in-laws are from Begusarai, Bihar. But, we are not voters there. For years we have

lived here and made our voter card here, along with Aadhaar and other documents... This is our home."

It's not just her "but also my three children who are at the mercy of the government", Soni, who voted in the Shyampur Assembly seat earlier, says. "If I am not a voter, what will be their status when they grow up?"

BLO Kalyan Bisi said: "I don't want to talk about it."

Sheikh Chotu, 35: wife Guria Bibi, 31: A rickshaw puller, Sheikh lives with his wife Guria in a slum in Rajabazar area of Kolkata. Both are now "excluded" from the voter list, after a tribunal order.

It makes no sense, Sheikh says. "In the last elections, we both voted (in the Beglata Assembly seat). We filled our SIR forms and submitted the papers. While not even a response came for my wife, nor was she called for hearings, in my case, the BLO first told me everything in my form was fine. Then he said I have to come for hearings. I gave all the papers. But still they deleted my name."

Sheikh, whose brothers have been cleared as voters, says he along with him had papers establishing their links to their father, whose name was in the 2002 voters' list.

Guria says their life may never be the same. "Our neighbours, other adults, who are deleted from the voter list, may have a different opinion about us. Moreover, till now we get rations. I don't know whether it will continue."

Their BLO Md Fakrudin says: "We submitted their forms

and papers. Now, the office and the (tribunal) judges will decide. What can I say, I am just a BLO."

Asma Khatun, 30: Asma, whose husband is a rickshaw puller, says she was confident her case had no loopholes as the names of both her parents were in the voters' list of 2002.

"Then came the 'excluded' notification. Pointing out that she has voted in four previous elections in Bengal (in the Beglata Assembly seat), Asma says: "Now I don't know what will happen. I gave my ration card, voter card, birth certificate and other papers to the BLO. I was called for a hearing but later told my name was deleted. Now, even my application to the tribunals has been rejected... I have three children, where will I go now, if they drive us away."

BLO Md Fakrudin BLO said: "The office and judges will decide... I am just a BLO."

Kahakasa Shukla, the coordinator of NGO Mukta Kantha Mahila Samity, which is helping the deleted voters in Kolkata slums, says: "There are a number of such people. We helped them submit appeals to tribunals on April 10. Out of the 54 people for whom we helped file appeals offline, no (acknowledgment) receipt has been received for 17. We don't know why."

The court option is not either, adds a local "We wanted to approach the Calcutta High Court on behalf of these people. But the procedure, we were told, is that it is the individuals who have to appeal. These are poor people... they cannot afford the expense."

The Editorial Page

The Indian EXPRESS
— FOUNDED BY —
RAMNATH GOENKA
— IN 1932 —

BECAUSE THE TRUTH
INVOLVES US ALL

In youth-driven Viksit Bharat, celebrate 'dimag'

IN HIS speech marking the 80th Independence Day, Prime Minister Narendra Modi returned to themes he has eloquently outlined earlier — and sought to connect them to a new motif. As he has done often, he divided the nation's journey into two, before and after 2014, with everything from poverty alleviation to the embrace of new technologies, picking up pace in the last 12 years. "Yeh raftar, yeh vistaar", this speed and this scale, he said, was visible for the first time since Independence. Several by-now familiar keywords and exhortations were embedded in his picture of a nation on the move, guided by "shakti ki saptaadhar", a seven-point reform vision — "atmanirbharata", "innovation hub", "vocal for local", "start-up India", "reform express". He framed the nation's trajectory against the backdrop of mounting global crises, from the pandemic to the weaponisation of resources amid wars in Ukraine and the Middle East. What was new at the Red Fort, however, was the PM's invocation of "yuna shakti", or youth power, and his attempt to link it to the goal of "Viksit Bharat". In a speech that comes on the heels of a student movement that drew national attention to the education and employment crises, the Prime Minister sought to reclaim and restate the "young" — from the image of the protester on the street, ranged against government and establishment, to the driving force of the India reform story, which is also prime "labharthi" or beneficiary.

The young received special attention from the PM. He announced a programme for AI training and free online coaching classes for competitive examinations. He spoke of the Innovation Fund, and promised to bring together "sapke sapne", especially Olympic dreams, with "sunsadhar" or resources. The young, said the PM, could also help official enumerators conduct the ongoing Census exercise more accurately. With echoes of the upsurge at the end of the 19th century, these evocative mentions of the young, the invitation to them to join a nation-wide project, were an attempt to restore and retrieve, and take the edge off the moment.

But the speech had a sharp edge of its own. Talking about his government's successes in tackling the scourge of Naxal violence, the PM articulated a remaining challenge — while "hathiyaari Naxals (armed insurgents)" have been defeated, there is a need to remain wary of the danger posed by "dimagi Naxals (those with Maoist thinking)". The latter, he said, must be identified and isolated so that the youth can be brought together to build a developed country. The connection the PM made in this formulation — his equation of an armed insurgency with ideas/dissent/ideology, and his linking of both to the young — are troubling. For, there is no equivalence between "hathiyaari" and "dimagi", and the bogey of the enemy within is at odds with the country he paints in the rest of his speech. There is no place for isolating or targeting anyone on the basis of their ideas — their "dimag".

The PM is right when he says yuna shakti will fuel the journey to Viksit Bharat, but that calls for celebrating the power of thought and freedom from fear, so that questions are asked and there is an unfading search for answers. Only that can shape and refine what it means to be viksit.

Attack on Sukhbir Badal deepens Punjab unease

THE ATTACK on Shiromani Akali Dal president Sukhbir Singh Badal in Nanded is reprehensible. The investigation will shine more light on this disturbing episode, but in Punjab, it can be said to be the latest in a recent series of developments that have deepened a sense of unease. In no particular order: Chief Minister Bhagwant Mann called on the Governor to seek a 10-day parole for Jagtar Singh Hawara, one of the convicts in the 1996 assassination of former Chief Minister Beant Singh; *Satguru*, a film that streamed for a few hours, has revived memories of Punjab's dark decade of militancy; a march to Chandigarh by the Shiromani Akali Dal (Wara Punjab) De demanded the release of its jailed leader, Khadoor Sahib MP Amrinder Singh, and other prisoners of the militancy era, the Bandi Singhs.

It is striking that a state confronted by a host of pressing challenges, be it drugs, gangsters, a faltering agricultural economy or the continuing exodus of its young, should be spending so much political energy looking backwards. The renewed threat under the Bandi Singhs, particularly among the young, shows how unresolved history can travel across generations. Issues rooted in the panthic imagination can be recast for a generation that did not experience the violence but has inherited its unanswered questions. Political parties must take the blame for turning such issues into electoral instruments, but failure to resolve several longstanding questions has handed them this ammunition. Chandigarh, the sharing of river waters and the status of Sikh prisoners are unresolved legacies that have been allowed to fester for decades. It's time to confront these issues rather than repeatedly rediscover them in election time.

The question of Punjab's river waters must be settled through constitutional processes. The cases of Sikh prisoners, including those convicted in high-profile assassinations, must be considered through the framework of law and justice, though the passage of time has added another layer to the debate. The perception of discrimination. Political parties must understand that emotions cannot be turned on and off, come elections, at will. Once unleashed, they acquire a life of their own and can overwhelm the very political actors who sought to harness them.

FREEZE FRAME

BY EP UNNY



Bring back E10 for older vehicles. Work out food versus fuel trade-off



V ANANTHA NAGESWARAN
AND AKASH POOJARI

A COMPLAINT has been travelling fast online that the government's E20 petrol wrecks engines and empties the tank faster. The charge is loud, but it is also, on the main point, wrong. However, dismissing it outright would be a mistake because beneath the noise lies a real problem and a much larger question.

Start with the engine, and the evidence does not support the fear of damage. Ethanol carries about two-thirds the energy of petrol, so a litre of E20 takes you a little less far, but the loss is small and does not signal any malfunction. Ethanol is only a fifth of the blend, so the energy penalty is around 6 to 7 per cent, not the 30 per cent doing the rounds. Carbon monoxide and unburnt hydrocarbons actually fall, which is good for the environment. On durability, which is the primary point of contention, the record is reassuring and counters the online narrative. The US, one of the global leaders in ethanol blending, had the Oakridge National Laboratory run 86 vehicles for a cumulative total of nearly 10 million kilometres on blends up to E20 and found no increased wear in cars not rated for E20. India's own testing by ARAI, the petroleum institute, and Indian Oil reached the same conclusion. Thus, social-media worries about engine damage do not hold up.

However, one exception is genuine, that is, India has roughly 75 to 80 million older two-wheelers built before BS4 that run on carburetors. A carburetor can sense the extra oxygen in the blend and adjust for it, so on E20, the engine draws in too little fuel for the air it draws in and runs hot. Further, older rubber seals that are not rated for ethanol are a separate problem, as they degrade on contact with the fuel regardless of engine temperature. Retrofitting those seals with ethanol-compatible ones is cheap. Still, it happens one vehicle at a time, and covering 75 to 80 million two-wheelers that way will take years, even if every workshop starts today. The original roadmap anticipated this and requested that a lower-blend fuel remain on sale for these vehicles, but that fuel quietly vanished from the pumps and needs to return. Restoring a lower blend at the pumps, say, E10, alongside the option to buy E20, would calm most public concern, lower total ethanol use instead of raising it, and protect the existing fleet while the retrofit programme catches up.

With the engine argument settled, one must also ask the harder question that nobody is shouting about. How much further should blending go? Moving from E20 to E27 or E30 is a different decision altogether, because that is where fuel begins to crowd out food.

Consider the two import bills India is trying to shrink. The crude oil bill is huge, around Rs 11-12 lakh crore a year. The edible oil bill is far smaller, roughly Rs 1.6 to 1.75 lakh crore. Ethanol at E20 trims only 3 to 4 per cent of the crude bill. The edible oil gap looks less daunting and is far more closeable. India already produces about 40 per cent of its cooking oil and aims to reach

72 per cent by 2030-31. A gap that the government can not only close fully but also stop subsidising is worth more than one you can only nibble at for shelter.

The feedstock has shifted, and that turns a distant trade-off into a direct one. Maize now supplies about half of India's ethanol, and grains together nearly 67 per cent. Maize competes with soybean, groundnut and mustard for the same fields. Two forces pull land towards it. First, ethanol from maize is procured at a fixed price well above the sugarcane route, which keeps the crop attractive, whatever the market says. Second, the leftover grain from distillation is sold as animal feed, undercutting soybean meal. Weaker meal prices, in turn, drag down soybean prices. The oilseed farmer loses twice.

Similarly, water needs a clearer eye too, especially when it comes to the headline figures, that is, thousands of litres of water used for every litre of ethanol. The figures generally sensible mix two very different things. Green water is rain that the crop would have received anyway. Blue water is drawn from rivers, canals, groundwater pumps and wells. It is the blue water that is scarce, and came in Maharashtra and Karnataka draws heavily on already-stressed sources. So the water rule should target blue-water use, not the frightening total.

Even the climate case is unsettled. Any blending beyond E20 would come almost entirely from grain, and Indian life-cycle studies do not agree on whether grain ethanol is cleaner than the alternatives once cultivation and processing are counted. The green argument for going further may not withstand closer scientific scrutiny.

That is not to say that the ethanol programme has not delivered

material gains. It has cleared sugarcane dues, lifted rural incomes and built an assured market. On the flipside, holding at E20 also carries its own costs. Those include distillery capacity built for more, loans taken against expected demand, and a sugar surplus that ethanol helps absorb. These belong in the reckoning too, and like most public policy dilemmas, the honest course of action is to weigh both sides carefully.

Here is the principle that should guide the choice. Some instruments can be changed within a season and reversed if the evidence turns, such as the procurement price, the protection fuel, the water rules and the import duty on edible oil. However, the blend level cannot. Once land and water are committed to fuel, and distilleries and cropping patterns are built around it, pulling back is bound to be slow and painful. When some moves are easy to undo, and others are not, prudence says to move the reversible ones first and hold off on the irreversible ones until a thorough cost-benefit analysis is done.

In this context, the recommendation is modest. Bring back a lower blend, such as E10, for the older fleet of vehicles. Fix the price and water distortions that unintentionally favour maize over other crops, relax at the import duty on edible oil to support the push towards domestic self-sufficiency, and hold at E20 until India has thoroughly costed the food-versus-fuel trade-off, rather than assuming it away. The engine row we witnessed was never the real argument. The real one is about what we choose to grow, and what we will not be able to take back.

Nageswaran is Chief Economic Advisor to the Government of India
Poojari is consultant, Department of Economic Affairs. Views are personal

The historian who didn't lose hope



CLAUDE MARKOVITS

SUMIT SARKAR, who passed away on August 13 at the age of 87, was that rare combination of a great historian and a lovely human being. I leave it to others, more competent, to appraise in detail his considerable contribution to the history of modern India. I will dwell instead on my personal memories of him. I was privileged to get to know Sumit through a personal connection: My wife, Piyali Chakravarty, was a childhood friend of his till the end, a friendship I shared.

Although we met first in Calcutta, and later in Oxford, where Sumit and his wife Tanika were spending a year, we really became friends in the late 1970s when they spent some time with us in our Parisian flat and we had long chats in the evenings, very much in the tradition of *addas*, while listening to records of French revolutionary songs. When it was our turn to spend a year in Delhi, this friendship grew and we were constantly in and out of each others' homes.

I have particularly fond memories of the few days Sumit and I spent together in Paris in the late 1980s. I was then trying to learn Bengali and, as a beginner, was finding my way through the famous primer written by Rabinranath Tagore, *Shastri Parlo*.

In between visits to Parisian historical landmarks, about which Sumit was often more knowledgeable than an old Parisian like myself, we would spend time reading together through the text. Sumit was vastly amused at some of the stories recounted in the book, and at what it revealed of Tagore's view of society. He even said it was worth having a closer look at the text, although he does not seem to have pursued that project. Talking to him on any subject, whether history, politics or literature, was always enlightening, as he had a vast store of knowledge on a variety of topics, and was never boring. He did not take himself too seriously, the way many academics tend to do, and always applied a good dose of his particular brand of humour to even the most serious questions.

Raised in a Brahmo milieu with strong communist leanings, his father Professor Susobhan Sarkar being a stalwart of the

Bengali intellectual left and a hugely influential teacher, Sumit remained a Marxist throughout his life, despite the growing unpopularity of that school of thought in India and elsewhere. An original contributor to Subaltern Studies with their then Thomsonian project of "history from below", he parted ways with the group when they fell under the spell of postmodernism and postcoloniality. He wrote a famous article about the decline of the subaltern in *Subaltern Studies*, which his former co-authors preferred to ignore rather than attempt to refute. He still believed that some form of "history from below" was a feasible project, although he had lost some of his illusions about the possibilities of recovering the voices of the downtrodden.

For him, as for many progressive intellectuals worldwide, the collapse of the socialist bloc and more generally of the Left was painful to digest but he did not take refuge in nostalgia. He retained a hope that things somehow would correct themselves at some point, which they did not. He was particularly alarmed at the growth of the Hindutva brand of Hindu nationalism and the threat it posed to Indian society and democracy.

He wrote about this threat in a series of pieces that were polemical but lucid, and did not become invectives. He was alert to the fact that, by undermining belief in the existence of historical truths, postmodernism had unwittingly helped in the growth of Hindu historiographies of India which had little consideration for facts.

The last years of his life were darkened by a host of physical ailments which he bore with courage and stoicism, helped by the care of Tanika and their son Aditya, both fine historians. The last time I met him was in Leamington Spa in England, where Tanika and he were spending a holiday with Aditya. He was frail, but still lucid, taking full part in the conversation, and still capable of laughing at the absurdities of the world. He will be sorely missed by us, and we share the grief of Tanika and Aditya.

The writer is a French historian of India. His latest publication is *India and the World: A History of Connections*, c. 1750-2000



MANPREET SINGH BADAL

Those before us had less. But they gave more

KARTAR SINGH Sarabha was 19 years old when the colonial rulers hanged him at the Lahore Central Jail. He had already crossed an ocean, printed a newspaper, and come home knowing exactly what was waiting for him in Punjab. He was 23 years old. Madan Lal Dhillon, 25, most of the men the Ghadar movement sent to the gallows were farmers' sons from the villages of the Majha, Doaba and Malwa regions who could not have told you the first thing about political theory. They decided that some things were worth more than a life.

I want to begin there today because we have got into the habit of thanking our freedom fighters in the abstract — as though they were a category in a history textbook rather than young men with names, families and dreams, born in villages that many of us still drive past. Punjab paid a heavy price for this freedom. At Jallianwala Bagh, in the Ghadar trials, on the Komagata Maru, in the ranks of the INA. And then again in 1947, when the freedom we had laboured for arrived as a line drawn across our own house. Millions were uprooted; families broken; a province cut in half, and its people made to walk out of homes their ancestors had built. And here is the part we do not say often enough: They did not become bitter. They arrived in Amritsar, Ludhiana, Jalandhar, and Pirozpur with nothing and started again. They ploughed, traded, drove trucks and sent their children to school. They fed this country during the Green Revolution, and guarded it on the borders. Not one of them asked what the nation was going to do for them.

So let me ask the uncomfortable question. Somewhere between that generation and ours, we changed the relationship. We stopped treating India as something we built, and started treating it as something that owes us. We queue at consulates. We take our grievances to the street before we take them to the classroom or the field. We measure a government by what it hands out, and we measure ourselves by very little at all. I do not say this as an accusation against our young people, but as an admission by my generation. We inherited a Punjab that had been rebuilt once, and we did not build on it. We let our water fall, our soil tire, our industry drift, and our best young minds board flights. That failure is ours, not theirs. But there is what gives me hope. The restlessness that took Sarabha to California and our soldiers to Gallipoli and Kohima and our farmers to Rajasthan's desert is still in us.

So to the young men and women of Punjab, and of India, I want to say this. Be revolutionaries again, but choose your revolution well. Wage it against your own limits first. Learn a skill so well the world has to come to you. Finish the degree. Stay off the poison taking our boys one by one. Look after your body and mind. Then go to your street. Teach one child who is falling behind. Save one field's worth of water. Employ one person. Build something — a business, an institution — rather than assuming everything worth building has to be built somewhere else.

That is not a small revolution than the one Sarabha fought. We are not yet the country our freedom fighters imagined. We are closer than we have ever been. Whether we get there is not a question for the government. It is a question for the 23-year-olds. Those before us had less, but they gave more.

The writer is a former finance minister of Punjab

40 YEARS AGO

August 17, 1986



Art 249 extended to J&K

THE CENTRE has extended the operation of Article 249 to J&K. This was done secretly a fortnight ago by amending the Presidential Order of 1954, which extended the Constitution to the state. Since the state legislature is suspended, the amendment was approved by Governor Jagmohan.

Scattered riots in Pakistan

WITNESSED SIDS the police wounded 12 people in Karachi during a third day of scattered riots when protesters attacked govern-

ment buildings, burned vehicles and clashed with authorities. Around 1,000 were arrested in Thatta district. Protesters also marched to demand the release of jailed opposition leaders, including Benazir Bhutto.

Car-bomb blast in Iran

ELEVEN PEOPLE were killed and about 100 injured when a car-bomb exploded in the holy city of Qom, in Central Iran, Radio Tehran reported. The radio said pilgrims, women and children were among the victims. It accused "agents of the United States" of responsibility for "shedding the blood of innocents".

Andhra villages inundated

GODAVARI FLOODWATERS entered Dowlaismaram town in Andhra Pradesh where many houses and office buildings were submerged in five to six feet of water by noon. Water from the swollen river first began leaking through a big hole in the wall by the side of the barrage. The crack widened and floodwaters poured in, submerging the town. As water began entering Dowlaismaram town, a large number of people carrying their belongings could be seen climbing the Kothapeta Hill by the side of the town. Five thousand people were evacuated.



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India's sweet revolution depends on this: Safeguard the bee, sustainability is key



ASHOK GULATI, SUVANGI RATH, AND TANMOY ADHIKARY

INDEPENDENCE DAY this year coincided with the US's National Honey Bee Day. A honey bee is a small insect that can sit on a fingertip. Why is it accorded such importance in the US? According to the UN's Food and Agriculture Organisation (FAO), the quiet role of bees as pollinators is responsible for almost one-third of global crop output. It enhances yields for 87 of 115 leading food crops.

Bees do more than improve yields. They enhance the nutritional quality of farm produce. If India has to make its agriculture productive and nutritious, bees must be treated as farmers' best friends. While passing by the mustard fields of Uttar Pradesh and Rajasthan or the apple orchards of Himachal Pradesh, one realises what these insects can do. They have helped India emerge as the second-largest producer of honey in the world, after China, and the third-largest exporter of honey after China and New Zealand in value terms.

Beyond the pollination service, bees have helped farmers augment their incomes through apiculture (honey bee farming). India's honey production has nearly doubled over the last decade, from about 76,000 tonnes in 2013-14 to nearly 151,000 tonnes in 2025-26, signalling real scale in supply and capacity. Interestingly, almost 70 per cent of India's honey production is exported (\$208 million in 2025-26), and India accounts for around 8.4 per cent of global honey exports. However, the export basket remains highly concentrated: The US absorbed about 76 per cent of India's exports (\$157.8 million) in 2025-26. Such concentration carries risks for India's export

India's Honey Production and Export Trends



SOURCE: DGFT 2026, MOAFW 2026

markets, a taste of which was felt when the US suddenly imposed high tariffs on goods imported from India. It was a big blow to Indian honey exporters and farmers, but the turnaround was also very swift in terms of diversifying export markets.

India's response was pragmatic. Shipments to countries such as the Netherlands, Belgium, Germany, and Israel have started reflecting a shift toward markets that value natural, sustainably sourced honey. At the same time, EU consumers are willing to pay a premium for traceable and environmentally responsible products, traits that India's multifloral and organic honey varieties can uniquely offer.

However, India's domestic market remains limited despite its large population. India's per capita honey consumption remains low (about 37 gm per year) — this suggests enormous potential that's yet to be tapped. As awareness of its health benefits spreads and retail penetration improves, a do-

mestic market can help stabilise producer incomes while supporting premium-quality exports.

This diversification mirrors a classic economic lesson: Trade barriers often do more harm than good. Rather than being confined to one large buyer, India's honey sector is now spreading its wings across geographies, reducing dependence on a single market and building stronger foundations for long-term export growth. However, unit value realisation remains a constraint: Indian honey's unit value is about \$1,858 per tonne, well below the world average and far from premium categories like New Zealand's Manuka. Upgrading quality, traceability and branding is therefore essential. Also, price realisation can improve if exports are in branded retail packs rather than wholesale unbranded volumes.

Reforms and investments will determine whether this moment becomes a structural transforma-

India must look beyond honey exports and recognise bees as an essential, unpaid agricultural workforce

tion or a reprieve. At the same time, investment in NMR (Nuclear Magnetic Resonance) capable testing labs, cluster-based processing, GI branding for unique floral varieties (Sundarbans, Ramban Sult), and turning farmer organisations into FPOs will lower compliance costs and enable entry into premium EU, Japanese and East Asian markets. The global bee products market (beeswax, propolis, royal jelly, pollen) is already sizeable — it was valued at roughly \$12.7 billion in 2023 and is projected to grow, offering India a high-margin diversification route beyond bulk honey.

Sustainability should be at the centre of the efforts. Expanding exports cannot come at the expense of bee health. Scientific beekeeping, pesticide management, and support for pollination services will protect both yields and ecosystem services that agriculture depends on. Initiatives under the National Beekeeping and Honey Mission and APEDA's export support are steps in the right direction, but scaling them requires sharper targeting, labs, cluster grants, export promotion, and large-scale consumer campaigns ("Honey for Health") to grow domestic demand.

Every rupee of honey we export rests on a far larger, unpriced service — the pollination that fills the orchard, the oilseed field and the vegetable plot quietly underwrites the food on our plates. The real measure of India's sweet revolution, then, will not be how much honey we sell, but whether we learn to protect the tiny worker that makes both the honey and the harvest possible. Safeguard the bee, and prosperity follows. Lose it, and no amount of policy will buy the loss back.

Can our policymakers give due priority to these silent workers that pollinate without a charge and enhance rural prosperity? Can they set a target to double honey bee colonies in the country by 2030, and double India's share in the global market by that year?

Gulati is a distinguished professor, Rath is a fellow, and Adhikary is a research assistant at ICRIER. Views are personal

Note to Bar Council: Disagreement is part of justice



MAYANK MAKHLIA AND NAMAN SHARMA

IN THE legal drama *12 Angry Men*, about the deliberations of a jury during a murder trial, one juror insists that before sending a young man to his death, they should at least examine the evidence, despite 11 others disagreeing. It is a reminder that disagreement is a necessary part of justice. The Bar Council of India's (BCI) decision to withdraw its order stopping the enrolment of 2026 graduates of NALSAR University of Law is welcome. But it raises a more fundamental question: Can the regulator of the legal profession use its statutory authority to punish law students for expressing disagreement with a constitutional functionary?

On August 13, the BCI chairman directed State Bar Councils not to enrol NALSAR's 2026 graduates until further orders, following reports that some students had opposed Chief Justice of India Surya Kant's proposed participation in the university's convocation. The BCI sought details of those who initiated or organised the campaign. Later that day, the BCI threatened to suspend the majority were innocent and consequently allowed all 2026 graduates to enrol with the State Bar Council of their choice.

The original direction deserves constitutional scrutiny because it concerned not merely professional regulation but the use of professional power in response to dissent. A law student does not surrender constitutional freedoms merely because he or she intends to become an advocate. Article 19(1)(a) guarantees the freedom of speech and expression. Article 19(1)(b) protects peaceful assembly. These rights are not absolute but the Constitution identifies the grounds on which speech may be constitutionally restricted. Disagreement with the conduct, views or public actions of a constitutional office-holder is not, by itself, one of those grounds.

The Supreme Court's decision in *Shreyya Singhal v. Union of India* is instructive. The Court struck down Section 66A of the IT Act because its vague and overbroad restrictions on expression could not be justified under Article 19(2). The judgment reaffirmed that the state cannot suppress speech merely because it is inconvenient, unpopular or offensive to some person or authority. The Court has also repeatedly recognised the constitutional importance of peaceful protest. In the Ramilla Maidan Incident case, the Court described freedom of speech and peaceful assembly as basic features of a democratic system and warned against arbitrary state action that frustrates these freedoms.

The Advocates Act, 1961 sets out the functions of the BCI. The Act does not give it unlimited powers to punish conduct it considers objectionable. Section 24 specifies eligibility for enrolment, while Section 24A prescribes the conditions for enrolment. A regulator cannot create a new disqualification by executive instruction when Parliament has prescribed the conditions for enrolment. If particular students cross the line into misconduct, they should be individually identified and proceeded against under the appropriate mechanism. The Karnataka High Court's 2024 decision in *Sri S. Basavaraj v. Bar Council of India* is significant. While dealing with the BCI's supervisory powers, the court held that general supervision and control over State Bar Councils does not automatically confer power to issue "no orders." If the BCI cannot use general supervisory power to silence advocates, it is difficult to justify an even broader use of that power against students who have not yet entered the profession.

There is an irony in the episode that should not be missed. Law schools teach students to question authority, while lawyers are expected to challenge executive action, question administrative decisions and defend unpopular causes. A profession that treats disagreement as evidence of unfitness risks teaching the wrong lesson. The BCI's responsibility is not merely to protect the "dignity" of the profession. Section 7 of the Advocates Act also requires it to safeguard the rights, privileges and interests of advocates and uphold constitutional standards.

That responsibility should encourage constitutionalism, not conformity. The BCI's withdrawal is a reminder that regulatory power has limits. For a country governed by the rule of law, the test of institutions is not how they respond to obedience. It is how they respond to dissent. If tomorrow's lawyers are punished for disagreeing with today's authorities, we will surely be surprised when tomorrow's courts have fewer lawyers willing to disagree. A democracy needs lawyers who can say "no" to power and still be allowed to practise law.

Makhlia is a Supreme Court lawyer and former special public prosecutor for the Enforcement Directorate. Sharma is a final-year student at Maharashtra National Law University, Nagpur



Assam floods are not only story of a river's vagaries



ARUPJYOTI SAIKIA

IN THE third week of July, several south-bank rivers of Upper Assam rose with terrifying speed, unleashing torrents that swallowed paddy fields and grazing lands and swept through villages and towns. Several districts, once stranger to such catastrophic floods, found themselves engulfed in a disaster beyond imagination.

Assam's growing vulnerability to floods is rooted in a long history of shrinking safety margins in a landscape that, for centuries, enjoyed stability. In July, Upper Assam felt the brunt of the disaster even before the Brahmaputra swelled to its highest. Relentless rains pounded the Naga Hills and Annapurna, soaking the slopes and unleashing sudden torrents into the southern tributaries. Many pointed to the region's land use — stone and boulder extraction from riverbeds and hillsides, a common sight in both highlands and lowlands — as a culprit that hastened the rainfall's journey, turning it into catastrophic floods downstream.

Cushioned between the Eastern Himalaya to the north, the Patkai and Barail ranges to the east, and the Bay of Bengal to the south, Assam is shaped by multi-layered environmental forces that have worked together for millennia. The southwest monsoon weaves together the highland forests, floodplains, billions of tons of sediments, and the ever-shifting channels of hundreds of rivers, creating a living, interdependent system. Each year, the monsoon decides whether Assam will bask in gentle rains or battle devastating floods. The July

Loss of forest deepened when, in the mid-20th century, a techno-bureaucratic campaign to build embankments set out to shield floodplains from floods once seen as predictable and nourishing for agriculture

flood brought this reality into sharp focus: Rainfall far beyond Assam's borders unleashed waters that surged across India.

The highlands of Nagaland and eastern Arunachal Pradesh, which feed the rivers of the south bank of Upper Assam, have undergone dramatic land-use transformations in recent decades. Driven by growing populations, cultivation cycles have become shorter and more intense. Where once a colonial system of extraction dominated, today small-scale coal mining, woven into the fabric of local economies, and which competes with the highland agrarian economy, thrives through complex networks of speculators. Such pressure on uplands, along with relentless logging and expanding infrastructure, erodes the land's ability to absorb rainfall.

The south-bank districts of Upper Assam, at the heart of the recent flood, were once among the Brahmaputra valley's most resilient regions. Thick forests, scattered settlements, and a safe distance from the Brahmaputra's main channel defined these lands. But in the mid-19th century, this calm began to unravel as these areas drew the attention of colonial tea planters. Where rain once vanished quietly into the forest floor, the land was transformed into sites of plantations, mineral extraction, and farmland that could no longer hold back the water.

The loss of forest deepened when, in the mid-20th century, a techno-bureaucratic campaign to build embankments set out to shield settled floodplains from floods once seen as predictable and

nourishing for agriculture. These barriers interrupted the flow of sediment. By 1988, even after thousands of kilometres of embankments had been built, two-thirds of the valley still lay open to flooding. During the July floods, embankments along the southern tributaries gave way before the main river crested, unleashing sudden breaches and a fall of water on an unembanked plain.

This inherited vulnerability has now deepened, as shown by new evidence that the monsoon is fast transforming. Meteorologists report that India's rainy season has become more unpredictable, marked by sudden downpours separated by long, dry spells rather than simply more rain overall. Studies focusing on Northeast India echo these findings. The big gap between intense rainfall and weakened landscape paints a fuller picture of the flash floods than only focussing on the quantity of rain.

The flooding in Upper Assam is not just a seasonal misfortune but the outcome of vulnerabilities built over two centuries. Unfortunately, the state's ecology has been treated as a puzzle for engineers and each crisis has been seen in isolation and the deeper ecological story given scant respect. Assam's environment is inching closer to its tipping point, but it is not yet beyond repair. We need to understand and mend the intricate connections between highland and lowland, water and land, forests and floodplains, and accept that the resilience lost over generations cannot be rebuilt by technology alone.

The writer is a Guwahati-based environmental historian

Just a housewife: What counts as work, who decides



MOANA BHAGABATI

A FRIEND recently remarked that my current work as a life coach was "just for pocket money". The comment lingered, not just because it stung, but because it revealed something larger about how we view women's work. Why is it that when a woman begins a new career later in life, especially after years devoted to family care, we instinctively assume it must be a hobby, a way to stay busy, a bit of extra spending money, rather than a serious professional choice made on her terms?

The question feels especially urgent given the Supreme Court's recent judgment describing homemakers as "a nation

builders", and assigning a notional value of Rs 30,000 per month to unpaid domestic labour while calculating compensation in a motor accident case. The judgment has opened a national conversation that resurfaces every few years and then fades, about what counts as work and who gets to decide.

For generations, women have been told their work at home matters, while being treated as though it does not count. A woman may spend decades managing budgets, caring for children and parents and in-laws, providing emotional support, solving crises, and creating the stability that lets everyone else pursue their ambitions. Yet she is often met with the phrase: "Just a housewife".

That single word "just" reveals the problem. Stepping away from paid work to care for family is not an absence of work. The labour remains. The pay cheque disappears,

and with it, somehow, the recognition. I experienced this directly.

For more than two decades, academia was not merely my profession, it was part of my identity. Then family responsibilities pulled me away. The years that followed were filled with caregiving, problem-solving, emotional labour, logistics, and support. Alongside, there was continuous work of a voluntary nature supporting people in need

Women are first undervalued for the unpaid years they give to family and society. Then if they try to return to paid work, especially later in life, they are undervalued again

of emotional anchor. They were demanding and productive years but left no line on a resume, or a figure a salary slip could capture. This led to the judgment to follow it into far more ordinary places. Women are first undervalued for the unpaid years they give to family and society. Then if they try to return to paid work, especially later in life, they are undervalued again. The same "just" that shrinks a homemaker's labour also shrinks a 50-something woman's profession into something done "for pocket money".

Both judgments rest on a narrow idea of what counts as real work, who is allowed to do it, and when. Caregiving years build judgement, patience, crisis management, and emotional intelligence. A woman who returns to paid work after this is not starting from nothing. She is starting from years of practice, carrying capabilities that no inter-

ship or entry-level role could have taught her.

The ruling matters because it forces a legal reckoning with contribution. But the social work to follow it into far more ordinary places. An employer who treats unpaid years as a liability and age as a ceiling isn't just being unfair to one woman. They are discarding a deep reserve of skill the country can't afford to waste. The years women spend caring for others are not empty or irrelevant. They are years of labour, growth, and quiet expertise. Recognising that has to seem more than a mere sentiment, however welcome. It has to change how resumés are read, how interview panels are trained, and how a society finally decides that beginning again, at any age, for any reason, is never just about pocket money.

The writer is a life coach

LETTERS TO THE EDITOR

Our nationalism

PERFORMATIVE NATIONALISM
— shrugging off the flawed reality
— refuses to fade from the theatre of Indian politics ("The nationalism that evokes pride, the nation we're proud of is a performance, an instant gratification from empty rhetoric, along with cutting corners, is a primary cause of India's substandard socio-economic standing. The more perfunctory the declarations are, the less tangible the groundwork. Dignified human existence for a vast populace has yet to materialise, rendering the vision of a Viksit Bharat by 2047 more of a hollow platitude. India will only truly arrive when the dignity of a good life reaches the hands of its hardest workers, for true national pride is anchored in the souls of its citizens."

Raghvi Sharma, Sunam

Women's freedom

CONCERNS ABOUT WOMEN'S safety, freedom and equal opportunity remain relevant despite progress ("An I-Day wish for my daughter", IE, August 16). Families and schools must teach boys respect, consent and shared responsibility from an early age. Public spaces need better lighting, transport, policing and swift action on complaints. Women should not have to restrict their choices for safety. Progress will come when institutions work, and social attitudes change, allowing women to study, work, travel and participate in life without barriers.

A Senthil Kumar, Kaniyur

Test for new law

THE QUESTION is not merely whether the previous policy was perfect or whether its replacement was necessary. It is whether the process of replacement itself has become means of politically distancing the present governance pattern from both the failures and the achievements of the one before it ("What was promised by NREGA's new version, where it falls short", IE, August 13). A policy may be replaced, but the history of governance through which it operates cannot be similarly erased. The test of VB-GRAM G will lie in its ability to show whether it has genuinely corrected the failures that justified its introduction.

Agnes Shikha, Gurugram

After protest, Alwar students promised new classrooms, RO water facility

Parul Kulshrestha
Jaipur, August 16

IT STARTED with a section of a roof at a government school in Jodhpur village in Rajasthan's Alwar collapsing on Thursday, August 13.

Though no one was injured — the room in question has been closed for over a year — it scores of students at the school in Thanauri town gathered in the school compound and began a protest, footage of which were widely circulated, finally catching the attention of the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP).

The next day, CJP spokesperson Ashutosh Ranka and others joined the students.

In the evening, Ranka posted a video on social media, announcing that the demands of the students have been accepted. District Education Officer Manoj Sharma told *The Indian Express* that the school had six functioning rooms and as many as 10 were declared as unsafe following a survey.

"The roof, a part of which collapsed, was in a room that had already been declared unsafe. No one used to sit in that room. Students got scared due to the incident and started protesting. We accepted their demands. The sub-divisional magistrate (SDM) has promised that under the VB-G Ram G Mission, three new rooms will be constructed. We have also sent a proposal to the state government for four new rooms."

The students and CJP leaders also demanded that the toilets should be repaired. The administration has assured them that things will improve within 15 days.

Road connectivity is another major problem faced by the students. The school is situated near the Ruparel river. As water river swells during monsoon, students often have to wade through ankle-deep water.

In a hand-written note submitted to the students, the authorities have assured to make the culvert on the river motorable within 48 hours, and build a bridge in four months.

The students have also been promised installation of RO-filtered drinking water facility.

NTA ADMITS TO ERRORS IN PAPERS

UGC-NET retest for 3 subjects on Sept 9 & 10

Express News Service
New Delhi, August 16

THE NATIONAL Testing Agency on Sunday announced that it will re-conduct the UGC-NET June 2026 examinations in English, Commerce, and Sociology subjects after a committee found that the three question papers contained many factual, typographical, translation errors and a significant number of questions repeated from previous examinations, concluding that the papers did not meet the standards of a "fair and error-free examination".

In its notice, the NTA clarified that the re-tests will be conducted on September 9-10, with no additional examination fee charged from candidates who appeared for these three subjects. The English paper will be held on September 9 from 9 am to 12 noon in Shift I, while the Commerce paper will be conducted the same day from 3 pm to 6 pm in Shift 2. The Sociology paper will be held on September 10 from 9 am to 12 noon in Shift I. According to the NTA, a committee's findings recorded the three papers containing factual, typographical and translation errors. These included misspelled names of prominent scholars, incorrect or garbled book titles, errors in the wording of questions, grammatical mistakes, gender and number agreement errors, punctuation errors and non-standard terms for established concepts. The committee also found that a significant number of questions had been repeated from previous examinations.

The decision follows complaints from candidates after the original UGC-NET examination, conducted from June 22 to 30 across 87 subjects. The examination determines eligibility for Junior Research Fellowships and Assistant Professor positions and is also used for admission to PhD programmes.

The NTA said the allocation of JRF seats, Assistant Professor eligibility and PhD eligibility in the three subjects would be carried out according to the examination's information bulletin. Numbers already allocated to each subject, it said, would not be reduced after the retest.

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‘Ashoka-era stupa, bigger than Sanchi’: 90 years on, Ujjain mound comes under renewed focus

Striking engineering and construction, says 1938 survey report

Anand Mohan J
Bhopal, August 16

THE MADHYA Pradesh government has begun a push to excavate and restore monuments linked to Mauryan-era emperor Ashoka, beginning with a fresh excavation of Vaishya Tekri — after an almost 90-year gap — in Ujjain.

The project comes amid a push by Chief Minister Mohan Yadav who has expressed interest in speeding up the excavation and restoration of the site, which belongs to his constituency of Ujjain.

Ujjain was an important city in the Mauryan world, and Ashoka was considered traditionally associated with it before he became emperor.

Dr Shivakant Bajpai, ASI Superintending Archaeologist (Bhopal), told *The Indian Express*, "We have sent a proposal to the DG, ASI, for excavation of the site. It will take at least three years for the excavation to yield meaningful results and may also take several more years for completion. Restoring the stupa will be another monumental task and our objective is to ensure it is restored without inflicting any damage to the site."

The Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) believes that there is a possibility that a stupa larger than the famous Sanchi stupa may exist at this site. However, there is a need for a deeper scientific study to establish the fact.

The renewed focus on Vaishya Tekri is significant because the excavations, carried out in 1938-39 by the Archaeological Department of the erstwhile



Vaishya Tekri has an estimated height of 100 feet against the 54-foot stupa at Sanchi, according to the excavation report

Gwalior State, had already established that the enormous mound was not a natural formation but the remains of a major stupa.

The original excavation report, preserved in the Annual Administration Report of the Archaeological Department, Cwalior State for Vikram Samvat 1995 (1938-39), provides a detailed account of what archaeologists found beneath the mound.

The excavation report described Vaishya Tekri as a "huge stupa", estimating its base at approximately 300 feet in diameter and its height at not less than 100 feet. The height of the stupa at Sanchi is approximately 54 feet.

ASI officials said the name of the mound (or stupa) stems from the queen of Emperor Ashoka, who came from the Vaishya or merchant community. Ashoka is believed to have had a palace built there during his viceroyalty of Ujjain. However, at the time, the first archaeologists who excavated the site opined that "excavations do not bear out the tradition."

What the 90-year-old report said

The monument's size was only one part of what fascinated the excavators. Its construction was unlike what they had encountered elsewhere. Instead of

a conventional solid brick structure, the heart of the monument was made from local blackish murum, rammed hard to form the massive core. The exterior was then faced with brick masonry laid in mud mortar.

"The hearing is made up of local blackish murum rammed hard, while the facing is composed of brick masonry laid in mud mortar," the excavation report stated. The bricks were exceptionally large. The report recorded the biggest as measuring 22½ inches by 18½ inches by 3¼ inches, while another variety measured 22½ inches by 15½ inches by 3¼ inches.

"The size of bricks indicates that the structure belonged to the Mauryan period (3rd century BC)." That conclusion was further supported, the report said, by two coins recovered during the excavation — a punch-marked coin and a cast Avanti coin.

The archaeologists consequently considered a possible connection with Ashoka, but again stopped short of presenting it as an established fact and opined that "it is possible that the stupa is one of the many which Asoka is said to have built." The ancient builders had also substantially altered the landscape around the stupa. The report says the

enormous quantity of murum used for the core had been quarried from the surrounding area. The excavators found that these quarry areas had effectively formed a regular square moat around the stupa, while leaving a gap between the moat and the monument itself. On the western side, they found evidence of a passage across the moat.

"In the centre of the West side of the moat there are the vestiges of a passage across the moat, for worshippers coming from the city, which was situated in that direction," the report said.

But the first excavation also demonstrated just how much of Vaishya Tekri had already been lost. "The facing of the stupa has all but disappeared and it is not possible from what has survived to determine the exact plan and elevation of the stupa," it said.

Most striking was the engineering at its base. "An unusual and ingenious engineering expedient has been employed in the construction of the masonry at the bottom of this stupa."

"This part of the masonry is built up in the shape of a bowl which supports the superstructure and with its slanting sides, resists the oblique thrust of the filling which is wide at the bottom and gradually narrows down as it rises up towards the top," it said.

The report also suggested that the monument had originally been taller than what survived. "The existing altitude of the stupa is slightly less in proportion to its base as compared with other stupas of the period but this can be explained by the fact that the top has been washed away," said the report.

The government and ASI will first have to secure control of the archaeological site. Ujjain district administration has sent a proposal to acquire the surrounding plot and land for Rs. 4 crore for the excavation to begin in the first place.

Pistol goes off at Varanasi airport during security check, two injured

Express News Service
Lucknow, August 16

IN A FREAK incident, two security officials at Varanasi's Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport were injured on Sunday morning after a licensed pistol accidentally fired during checking.

The incident took place around 9:30 am when a passenger identified as Azamgarh-based businessman Kamlesh Rai, was getting his licensed pistol screened before boarding the Air India Express flight IX-1810 to Mumbai.

During the inspection of the firearm, one round accidentally went off, leaving two screeners injured. The bullet hit one screener in the leg and the other standing nearby in the thumb.

Speaking to *The Indian Express* over the phone, Puneet Gupta, Director of Lal Bahadur Shastri International Airport, said, "Two high-class and ingenious engineering expedients have been employed in the construction of the masonry at the bottom of this stupa."

The injured screeners have been identified as Suman Kumar and Rohit Rai.

Meanwhile, police have detained Rai for questioning. He has been booked for endangering the life or personal safety of others.

Assistant Commissioner of Police (Varanasi) Prashant Singh said the investigation is underway, adding that the Airport's Authority of India (AAI) is also probing the incident separately. Police said they would initiate the process to cancel Rai's arms licence.

3 held for raping 19-yr-old girl in Lakhimpur Kheri

Press trust of India
Lakhimpur Kheri, August 16

THREE YOUNGSTERS were arrested for allegedly gang-raping a 19-year-old woman in Uttar Pradesh's Lakhimpur Kheri district, a police official said on Sunday.

Circle Officer Vivek Tiwari told reporters that the three accused, Siddharth (22), Madhumeswari (23), and Vishu Kanooja (19), have been arrested.

Superintendent of Police Dr Khyati Garg said that the incident occurred on Saturday afternoon. One of the accused, who was on friendly terms with the woman, allegedly invited her to his home, when his parents were not present. He, along with two other friends, allegedly gang-raped the woman. The three fled the scene after her condition deteriorated. The survivor returned home and informed her grandparents about the incident.

Her family then took her to the district hospital, where she is undergoing treatment, and informed the police. SP Garg informed that all three accused are residents of the same area and a case has been registered against them under Section 70(1) (gang rape) of the BNS.

IPS officer's 94-year-old mother murdered inside UP home, cops suspect robbery

Manish Sahu
Lucknow, August 16

THE 94-YEAR-OLD mother of a serving IPS officer was murdered at her home in Malipura area of Ambedkar Nagar district of Uttar Pradesh on Sunday. Police said that they suspected robbery as a possible motive since several pieces of jewellery were missing from her body.

The woman had been identified as Indravati, mother of Superintendent of Police Ashutosh Mishra, who is posted in Lucknow.

She was found dead with a cloth stuffed into her mouth and injuries visible on her body, said a police officer.

The incident came to light around 9 am when a domestic help arrived at the house and found the main door locked from outside. "She opened the door and found Indravati lying unresponsive on a cot in the verandah. She alerted a neighbour, who informed the family and police," said a police officer.

A case of murder and robbery has been registered against unidentified persons at Malipura police station on a complaint lodged by Mishra.

According to police, the officer had visited his ancestral home at Ratna Dhamra village on Saturday and returned to Lucknow later that evening.

In his complaint, Mishra said his uncle, Sachindra

Mishra, called him around 3:50 pm and told him that his mother had suffered a heart attack and died. When Mishra reached the village, he and his uncle examined the body and noticed that several pieces of jewellery were missing, including a gold chain, a tulsi necklace with gold beads, a nose pin and earrings. Her anklets were also missing. Blood was visible around her mouth, and a green towel had been stuffed inside it. Two injury marks were also visible on her lips.

Mishra told police that the circumstances indicated that his mother was murdered and that the assailants took away the jewellery she was wearing.

Kiran Parashar
Chamarajanager, August 16

PROTESTS CONTINUED for the second day in Chamarajanager and Mysuru on Sunday, seeking justice for three men killed in an alleged exchange of fire with forest officials in Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary early on Saturday morning. The families are demanding an independent probe, monetary compensation and the arrest of forest officials involved in the shooting.

Political parties in Tamil Nadu, including the DMK and PMK, claimed that the three victims were Tamils and questioned the officials' claim that they were poachers.

Hanur Police have registered an FIR against forest officials involved in the incident under Section 103(1) of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which deals with punishment for murder, after a formal complaint was lodged by the wife of one of the deceased, officials said.

Karnataka CMD K Shivakumar has already ordered a magisterial probe into the deaths of Antony Swamy (50),



John Rose Peter (42) and Kumar Sawariyappa (35), who lived in a tribal area near the protected forest. Joseph Mahima Das (44), who was accompanying the three victims, was injured in the incident.

Assistant Commissioner of Kollegal sub-division, Dinesh Kumar Meena, said they have initiated a probe. "The deputy commissioner has sought a report within a week. We have visited the spot and have gathered information. We are waiting for reports from police and other agencies," Meena said.

Forest officials said the men were poachers and were carrying at least 2kg of wildlife meat, and they opened fire at the patrol

vehicles when confronted. Three of the four men were killed in self-defence, forest officials said. However, the families of the victims said the men were searching for cattle when forest officials shot them.

Inspector General of Police for the Southern Range M B Boralingaiah informed the media that the deceased were residents of Thimiyarpalya and neighbouring villages in Hanur taluk in Chamarajanager district.

Boralingaiah said police have registered a murder case on a complaint from Mary, wife of Antony Swamy.

On Sunday, villagers gathered outside the KR Hospital where the bodies were taken for post-mortem. Mysuru Superintendent of Police Mallikarjun Baldandi told PTI that the families had consented to the post-mortem examinations.

In her complaint, Mary stated that two of their cows didn't return after grazing on August 14. Around 6.30 pm, Antony, along with three others, left in search of the cows. Around 7 am on Saturday, Mahima Das called Mary and

narrated the incident.

According to Mahima Das, between 3 am and 5 am, forest officials opened fire at them without provocation. Mary stated in her complaint.

The bodies were shifted to a government hospital, and when the news spread, villagers gathered and protested, rejecting the forest officials' version. Angry villagers and family members of the deceased even vandalised the Shyaga forest office in Hanur on Saturday.

Karnataka Chief Minister D K Shivakumar ordered a magisterial inquiry into the shootout. "I received information about the incident at 5 am. The truth will be known after the investigation. The shootout took place in a forest area. Several witnesses have been questioned, and items and guns have been seized," the CM had said.

Cauvery Wildlife Sanctuary is spread across three districts — Chamarajanager, Mandya and Bengaluru South (formerly Ramnagara). It is home to a variety of animals, including sambar, spotted deer, barking deer, elephants, tigers and leopards.

● BORN IN CHANDIGARH, FLIGHT LIEUTENANT ARSHDEEP SINGH DANG MOVED TO THE UK WITH HIS PARENTS WHEN HE WAS SIX

Britain's first Sikh fighter pilot since World War II: 'Want my success to inspire others'

Divya Goyal Gopal
Ludhiana, August 16

WITH HIS roots in Punjab, Indian-origin Flight Lieutenant Arshdeep Singh Dang, 28, has become the first Sikh to graduate as a fighter pilot in Britain's Royal Air Force (RAF). He is the first Sikh to attain wings from a Fighter Squadron of the RAF since World War II, according to the RAF.

A fast-jet pilot graduation ceremony was held at RAF Valley in North Wales on Friday (August 14), where the British Air Force announced, "Arshdeep Singh Dang has graduated as the first Sikh to attain wings from a Fighter Squadron of the RAF since World War II."

Arshdeep told *The Indian Express*: "It was my paternal grandfather Sardar Santokh

Singh Dang's dream that my son should be a pilot. But should be a grandfather died when my father was just 6. So my father never really had those opportunities or resources to fulfil his wish. My parents encouraged me, and I started to believe I could be a pilot."

Arshdeep's father Jagdeep Singh Dang is a native of Ludhiana, and his mother Gagandeep Kaur is from Amritsar. However, Arshdeep was born in Chandigarh in 1998, and the couple moved to the UK when he was 6. "I attended a school in Mohali for 2 years or so, but I don't really remember much. However, we kept visiting Punjab to meet our families. Two years ago, I visited Amritsar and Ludhiana," says Arshdeep. In the UK, the family lives in Southall.

Arshdeep attended the University of Bristol, earning a BSc (Hons) in mathematics and philosophy. He graduated from Officer Training in February 2022 and Elementary Flying Training in 2023. After serving in Cyprus, Dang was streamed to Fast Jet in 2024. He commenced his first jet lead-in training in March 2025, followed by Basic Fast Jet training in July the same year.

He was sent solo to Texas in October 2025 and passed his wings test in July 2026. On August 14, 2026, he graduated as the first Sikh to attain wings from a Fighter Squadron since World War II. He will now undergo another year of offensive training before handling fighter jets on the front line.

Arshdeep was the only pilot of Indian origin in his batch. "I



Arshdeep Singh Dang will now have to go through another year of training before handling fighter jets on the frontline

am privileged to represent my community on this historic day. I am the first Sikh to achieve this since World War II, but I don't want to be the last." "Sikhs made a major contribution to the British Indian Army during World War II. Several Sikhs were awarded the Victoria Cross, the highest British gallantry honour. But since then, there haven't been any notable achievements. I want my success to inspire others. We always have a chance to create history, not just in the UK, but in the entire world," says Arshdeep.

"Although it was my grandfather's dream to see my father as a pilot, my pillar of strength has always been my mother. She kept us grounded, humbled and never made us feel low even when we had financial constraints. She anchored our family through the toughest times. She kept those Punjab roots and Sikh values imbibed in us even after we moved from India."

Arshdeep said: "There's a very strict rule in our home. We speak Punjabi to each other, and no other language is allowed in the house. We always visit the gurdwara, have langar, and keep the core values of Sikhism intact

in our hearts. During tough times, I turn to my grandparents. We always have a chance to create history, not just in the UK, but in the entire world," says Arshdeep.

Lieutenant Indra Lal Roy was a legendary fighter pilot of Indian origin who served in the British military during WWI and became India's first and only 'Flying Ace', claiming 15 aerial victories with RFC and RAF in 1918. He was the first Indian ever to receive the Distinguished Flying Cross (DFC).

The most notable Sikh fighter pilot in British military history are Lieutenant Hardit Singh Malik, the pioneering WWI aviator known as the "Flying Sikh", and Squadron Leader Mohinder Singh Puji, a celebrated WWII fighter pilot who wore his turban proudly in combat. Both men broke racial and structural barriers to fly fighter aircraft for British services.

Malik flew with French Air Service and later received an honorary commission as a pilot in the British Royal Flying Corps (later the RAF) in 1917. Squadron Leader Puji volunteered for RAF in 1940 and flew Hawker Hurricanes in the British Royal Air Force. He earned the Distinguished Flying Cross for his bravery.

13 MAJOR AGRARIAN STATES INCURRED OVER RS 1.3 LAKH CRORE IN FARM POWER SUBSIDIES IN FY25

States ring-fence agri losses to ease DISCOMs' financial stress

Pratyush Deep
New Delhi, August 16

AMID FALTERING efforts to resolve the solvency of electricity distribution companies (DISCOMs), state governments are increasingly resorting to an easier fix: hiving off agricultural consumer load into separate entities and freeing up the rest of the utility from the burden of agri-subsidy losses. At least three states, Telangana, Maharashtra and Haryana, are pursuing plans to segregate agricultural consumers from existing DISCOMs and create separate entities for one of the power sector's most heavily subsidised categories.

While Telangana and Maharashtra have created separate agriculture DISCOMs, neither is fully operational. Haryana's proposal for a dedicated agricultural DISCOM was deferred after opposition from power sector employees.

Agriculture accounts for nearly one-fifth of electricity consumption and is the sector's most heavily subsidised consumer category. With tariffs often below the cost of supply, DISCOMs rely on state subsidies and cross-subsidies from commercial and industrial (C&I) consumers, making them vulnerable to delays in subsidy payments — which can strain working capital and constrain investment in network up-

grades, affecting reliability and power supply quality.

According to the Comptroller and Auditor General of India, state governments spent nearly Rs 1.9 lakh crore on energy subsidies in 2024-25, mainly to support DISCOMs and provide subsidised electricity to farmers and households, making power the largest component of their subsidy bill. The 13 major agrarian states, accounting for 99% of India's agricultural electricity sales, incurred over Rs 1.3 lakh crore in farm power subsidies in FY25, as per a report by the Council on Energy, Environment and Water.

Most state-owned utilities continue to incur losses and rely on borrowings to fund operating shortfalls and accumulated liabilities. Public sector DISCOMs have accumulated losses of Rs 6.77 lakh crore and borrowings of Rs 7.11 lakh crore. Telangana, Maharashtra and Haryana's DISCOMs are also losing, with thousands of crores in debt.

A new DISCOM, old liabilities

In its December order last year, the Telangana government attributed the creation of this third DISCOM — Telangana Rythu Power Distribution Company Ltd. — to deteriorating financial position of the state's two existing distribution companies: the Southern Power Distribution Company of Telan-

• SUBSIDY DELAYS SQUEEZE DISCOMS

AGRICULTURE ACCOUNTS for nearly one-fifth of electricity consumption and is the power sector's most heavily subsidised category

WITH TARIFFS often below cost of supply, DISCOMs rely on state subsidies and cross-subsidies from C&I consumers

THIS LEAVES them vulnerable to delayed subsidies, straining working capital and limiting network investment and supply reliability



gana Ltd and Northern Power Distribution Company of Telangana Ltd, whose combined accumulated losses stand at Rs 69,741 crore against a borrowing of Rs 59,230 crore.

In March, the new entity was created to supply electricity to agricultural and select water-sector consumers. Subsequently, over 29 lakh agricultural consumers, along with several hundred others, were transferred to the new utility.

Liability, too, moved with load. The new entity would be liable for Rs 26,950 crore in payables to state-owned power-generating companies and a working capital of Rs 9,032 crore. Against this, the state government infused Rs 5 crore in equity, along with assets — agricultural distribution transformers worth Rs 2,792 crore and agriculture low-tension lines

valued at Rs 2,137 crore.

However, without commercial and industrial consumers, the financial viability of agricultural-focused DISCOMs remains uncertain, with fears they could become heavily dependent on government subsidies. "These DISCOMs will become exclusive government subsidy-based agencies. If you mop out all profitable areas, where is the financial estate of these DISCOMs?" The purpose of these DISCOMs is to segregate losses and enable privatisation of profits, said K Ashok Rao, patron at All India Power Engineers Federation.

Cleaning up the balance sheet

In Maharashtra, MSEB Solar Agro Power Ltd was carved out of state-owned Maharashtra State Electricity Distribution Company Ltd (MSEDCL) as a

subsidiary of its parent, Maharashtra State Electricity Board (MSEB) Holding Company to function as a deemed distribution licensee and retail supplier for agricultural consumers, including billing.

Under the restructuring scheme notified in May, Rs 32,679 crore of MSEDCL's Rs 39,527 crore in pending agricultural dues will be written down, with the state government assuming an equivalent liability through government securities. MSEDCL will create a corresponding reserve to write down the agricultural receivables, despite carrying Rs 90,659 crore in borrowings and an accumulated loss of Rs 35,671 crore.

Shrinivas Bobade, President of Maharashtra-based Subordinate Engineers Association, said the exercise is nothing but paperwork to clean up the balance sheet of MSEDCL, as it seeks to go for an IPO. "If MSEDCL's balance sheet shows such huge receivables from the agricultural consumers, who would like to invest? So, they created this agriculture DISCOM to make their books better," he told The Indian Express.

Queries sent to the state governments, MSEDCL and MSEB Holding Company, and Telangana Rythu Power Distribution Company remained unanswered till the time of filing this report. FULLREPORT@WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Gen Z's buy-now, pay-later habit fuelling unsecured loans, worrying regulator

Aanchal Magazine
New Delhi, August 16

TWO MUMBAI-BASED teenage girls travelled with their mother to Busan, South Korea, to attend a concert of Korean boy band BTS in June, financing much of their spending through a credit card.

A young couple travelled to Thailand for a vacation last year, spent well beyond their budget on credit cards, and have since then resorted to rotating money through third-party vendors to create artificial cash flow, according to a personal finance post on Reddit warning about funding small luxuries with debt.

While India's household debt has surged in recent years, financial sector regulators are particularly concerned about the composition of that debt. Non-housing retail loans — largely used for consumption — now account for more than half of household borrowings, with growth faster than housing, agriculture and business loans, a trend flagged in internal discussions among policymakers.

As of March 2026, non-housing retail loans — primarily the consumption segment — constituted 58.4% of households' total borrowings, up from 54.9% of total household debt in March 2025. Average outstanding debt per borrower rose to Rs 4.78 lakh as of March-end 2025, from Rs 3.41 lakh as of March-end 2018, according to Ministry of Finance data. The sharpest increases have come in some personal borrowing categories. Outstanding loans against gold jewellery jumped to Rs 4.61 lakh crore as of March 2026 from Rs 74,738 crore in March 2022, while other personal loans' outstanding stood at Rs 17.32 lakh crore as of March 2026 compared with Rs 9,022 lakh crore in March 2022, data shared in Parliament on Monday (August 10) showed.

While the risks to the Indian financial system from household lending remain contained, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) has flagged household debt accumulation, particularly among lower-rated borrowers, as requiring "close monitoring". Gross NPA ratios stood at 0.7% in secured retail loans and 1.7% in unsecured retail loans at end-March 2026. "The exposure to these sectors requires close monitoring as

• Non-food bank credit, outstanding personal loans (March-end)

	2022	2023	2024	2025	2026
Personal Loans	34,66,075	41,82,767	53,46,691	59,71,696	69,39,750
Consumer Durables	17,834	20,985	23,445	23,201	21,962
Housing*	17,38,473	19,91,164	27,18,712	30,10,477	33,55,963
Education	83,693	96,482	1,19,380	1,37,456	1,55,824
Vehicle Loans	4,04,756	4,87,597	5,73,391	6,22,793	7,38,678
Loans against gold jewellery	74,738	89,370	93,301	2,06,284	4,61,373
Other Personal Loans	9,01,595	11,62,345	14,27,872	15,35,197	17,31,838

NOTE: FIGURES IN RS CR. SOURCE: RBI

* (INCLUDING PRIORITY SECTOR HOUSING)

risks to asset quality could increase, especially if overall economic conditions weaken due to the West Asia conflict and impact borrower cash flows", the RBI had said in its latest Financial Stability Report.

Unsecured personal loans remain a particular vulnerability. In the small-ticket personal loan segment of less than Rs 50,000, fintech firms have gained a higher 56.8% market share, after strong 41.6% credit expansion, well above the overall segment growth of 20.4%. Delinquencies stood at 64% as of March 2026. About 70.5% of fintech loan books are unsecured, with roughly half of these loans extended to borrowers under 35. As per the latest CIBIL, TransUnion data, the share of India's credit-eligible population that is credit-active has risen from 11% about a decade ago to around 28% now.

Of the credit-eligible population of 890 million, close to one-third have, over the last year, taken a loan or have a loan running, or are paying EMIs or credit card bills. Almost half of this credit-active population has a consumption loan — credit card, personal loan, or consumer durable loan — while nearly 10% have an entrepreneurial loan or business-oriented loan.

The number of credit-active consumers with consumption loans and business loans grew fourfold and tenfold, respectively, between 2017 and 2024, TransUnion CIBIL data showed. Consumption borrowing has been driven substantially by younger consumers, including Gen Z, often with repayment terms of less than three years. "What we need to continu-

ously monitor is that while encouraging credit growth, are we incentivising need-based credit. The other thing is the ability to pay, especially in certain segments such as younger borrowers where the leverage has gone up. In the case of consumption loans, for instance, the lender cannot be in a position to fully qualify income information and if on account of the increased leverage, the consumer is in a situation to pay or not," an executive with a credit bureau said.

The share of over-leveraged consumers rose threefold — from 5% in FY17 to 18% in FY24 — before easing marginally to 15% in FY26 after industry intervention, with excessive borrowing concentrated among younger consumers. Their share in the country's credit-active base has increased from 33% in 2017 to 39% in 2026.

Even as unsecured retail lending has moderated — it forms 25% of retail loans and 8.3% of gross advances — its asset quality has weakened relative to the overall retail portfolio. Its gross non-performing asset ratio stood at 1.8% vis-à-vis 1.2% in March 2025, with stress particularly visible in private sector banks.

The trend suggests a growing propensity to incur debt for immediate consumption rather than asset creation. Outstanding credit card debt crossed Rs 3 lakh crore last fiscal, while delinquencies — payments overdue between 90 and 360 days — rose more than 40% year-on-year, as per the data from CRIF High Mark, an RBI-registered credit bureau.

FULLREPORT@WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

How Trump's plan to sell faster access to Truth Social is doing

Soumyarendra Barik
New Delhi, August 16

MORE THAN 10 customers, primarily high-frequency trading firms, have signed agreements with US President Donald Trump's media company to receive its fastest available feed of posts from Truth Social, turning this social media activity into a potentially lucrative financial-data business.

The customers are paying between \$60,000 and \$100,000 a month for Truth API to Trump Media & Technology Group (TMTG), according to the company's interim chief executive Kevin McGurn, who disclosed details of the service during an earnings call.

At the upper end of that range, 10 customers alone could potentially generate around \$12 million in annualised revenue. That is significant for a company which reported revenue of just \$1.7 million in the June quarter, and a loss of \$2.38 million between April and June.

TMTG is now looking well beyond trading firms. McGurn said it was in discussions with hyperscalers, large news organisations, and developers of large language models, while also exploring licensing its data to prediction markets. A retail-trading version of the product is also being worked on.

What is Truth API?

An application programming interface, or API, essentially allows one computer system to automatically obtain information from another. Truth API packages publicly available posts from some of Truth Social's most influential accounts into a structured, machine-readable stream that computers can consume almost instantly. All this results in, with access to the API receiving posts on Truth Social milliseconds before regular users.

TMTG launched the product on August 1 after announcing it in July as its first data-licensing business. The feed covers posts from influential Truth Social accounts, provides access to the clock access, and includes a historical archive going back to 2022. The crucial selling point is speed.

Instead of a trader manually refreshing Trump's Truth Social profile, or waiting for a phone notification, an algorithm can



The customers are paying up to \$100,000 a month for Truth API to TMTG, Reuters

ingest a post through the API within milliseconds, interpret what it means, and potentially place trades automatically.

Although that difference may sound negligible to an ordinary user, in high-frequency trading, where computers routinely compete to execute transactions fractions of a second ahead of rivals, it could have commercial value.

Of course, Trump himself would be responsible for creating much of that value. His posts are particularly important because he has increasingly used Truth Social not merely for political commentary but to make or signal decisions on policy, foreign policy, and individual companies.

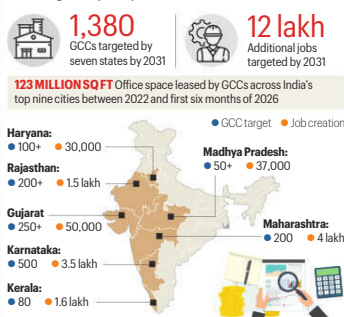
Why is it controversial?

At the heart of the controversy is a key question on whether investors who can afford tens of thousands of dollars each month receive faster access to statements made by the sitting US President that could move financial markets, even if it is just a matter of milliseconds. The posts themselves are public. TMTG has stressed this distinction, with McGurn saying the company's customers only receive "published and publicly available posts fractionally faster". Commercially licensing real-time public data, it argues, is commonplace across technology, media, and financial information businesses.

And selling faster data feeds may not in itself be unusual or necessarily illegal. Lawyers cited by Reuters have pointed out that technology platforms can offer different speeds of access to public information even if it leaves some market participants at a disadvantage. FULLREPORT@WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

• 7 STATES TARGET 12 LAKH GCC JOBS BY 2031

Seven states have come up with dedicated policies to set up Global Capability Centres (GCCs), aiming to create more jobs, according to a report by CBRE.



"The speed at which state governments have moved to formalise dedicated GCC policies is unprecedented in India's commercial real estate landscape." — ANSHUMAN MAGAZINE, CHAIRMAN AND CEO, INDIA, SOUTH-EAST ASIA, MIDDLE EAST & AFRICA, CBRE

SOURCE: CBRE REPORT - THE POLICY ADVANTAGE: POWERING INDIA'S GCC GROWTH (PTI)

Govt aims to clinch 5 BITS in 2-3 months

Prasanta Sahu
New Delhi, August 16

THE GOVERNMENT IS aiming to finalise new bilateral investment treaties (BITS) with the European Union (EU), Saudi Arabia, Switzerland, Oman and the Maldives in the next two to three months, offering enhanced flexibility to foreign investors including a shorter timeline to exhaust domestic remedies before initiating international arbitration.

Simultaneously, the Cabinet will consider the proposed BIT 4.0 regime, which revises the model text for a better balance between sovereign interests and foreign investment as well as creates a flexible framework for future negotiations.

A flexible model would allow India to tailor provisions based on the partner country's strategic importance and investment ties, sources said. FE reported recently that

the domestic-remedy timeframe could be reduced to two years, depending on bilateral negotiations.

Recently, India reduced the timeframe from five years to three years for investments from the United Arab Emirates and Israel.

"We are not offering five years to anyone any more. The negotiations are starting with three years," an official said, referring to the departure from the 2015 Model BIT. FE

DRI uncovers Rs 2,500 cr areca nut import racket

New Delhi: The Directorate of Revenue Intelligence (DRI) has dismantled a network involved in importing South-East Asian areca nuts into India by falsely declaring them as Bangladeshi origin and fraudulently availing concessional duty benefits under the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA).

The finance ministry said an investigation by the DRI has so far revealed a potential revenue loss of over Rs 2,500 crore. Nine persons have been arrested.

The import of areca nuts into India attracts customs duty of 100%. However, eligible imports of areca nuts under the SAFTA agreement are fully exempt from customs duty. PTI

• BRIEFLY

Govt sets LPG output targets for refiners

New Delhi: The Centre has for the first time fixed maximum cooking gas LPG production targets for individual public- and private-sector refineries and upstream firms, as it seeks to build a domestic supply buffer after the West Asia conflict. The Petroleum and Natural Gas Ministry, in an August 13 order, specified maximum LPG production levels for 21 refineries and upstream firms, with combined production potential set at 63,810 tonnes a day. PTI

RBI may incur \$9-12 bn in FCNR hedging costs

Mumbai: The Reserve Bank of India (RBI) could incur \$9-12 billion over five years in hedging costs if foreign currency non-resident (bank), or FCNR(B), deposits mobilised under its special swap window reach \$70 billion, with economists estimating annual hedging costs at 2.5-3.5%. The RBI has already received \$52.3 billion through FCNR(B) deposits of August 13, which would translate into a five-year hedging cost of about \$6.5-9.1 billion at the same range of annual costs. FE

• A RECENT CAG REPORT FLAGGED THAT E.COLI BACTERIA WAS FOUND IN STATIONS DRINKING WATER

Railways orders filtration system at stations after CAG report

Dheeraj Mishra
New Delhi, August 16

AFTER THE Comptroller and Auditor General (CAG) of India flagged poor drinking water quality at the railway stations and even said that total coliform bacteria, including E. coli bacteria, were found during its testing, Minister for Railways Ashwini Vaishnaw on Sunday directed immediate corrective measures — like a new 'tank to tap' water filtration system at around 20,000 locations, including water coolers.

The officials said regular water testing at the source and outlet points will be conducted.

"From now onwards, the water quality of stations will be monitored at the board level. There will be scheduled cleaning and maintenance of storage tanks. Progress and water quality reports will be published periodically to ensure transparency. This action is part of a larger drive to address all CAG observations and improve the overall travel experience," said a senior railway official.

In a recent report titled "Passenger Amenities and Sanitation at Non-Suburban Railway Stations in Indian Railways", the CAG said E. coli bacteria was found in drinking water samples collected from taps in eight rail-



E. coli bacteria was found in drinking water samples collected from taps in eight railway stations out of 49 stations. REUTERS

way stations out of 49 stations. These stations are Coimbatore, Palakkad, Hyderabad, Chhatrapati Shivaji Maharaj Terminus, Bhiwandi Road, Kalyan, Lon-

avala and Madhapur. E. coli bacteria in drinking water is a warning that sewage or animal or human faecal contamination may have entered the water.

"Inspection of the water supply system was not carried out as per prescribed periodicity. There was shortfall in testing for drinking water for residual chlorine, bacteriological analysis and chemical analysis," said the national auditor.

The CAG also found that out of the 512 stations inspected, 458 stations or more than 89% were deficient in one or more drinking water quality parameters (MEAs), including drinking water, seating, toilets, platform shelters, fans, water coolers and signage. Even the bigger stations of high-revenue and high-fare exhibited significant shortfalls. The audit was conducted for the period 2019-20 to 2023-24.

The sanitation infrastructure also remained deficient, marked by nonfunctional toilets, inadequate facilities in pay-and-use and continued existence of unauthorised entry points affecting cleanliness and safety, said the auditor.

"A review of 395 passenger amenity works undertaken during 2019-20 to 2023-24 showed that 59% of works were delayed, with delays ranging from one to over four years, and only 41% completed within stipulated timelines," it said.

FULLREPORT@WWW.INDIANEXPRESS.COM

Idea Exchange

MONDAY, AUGUST 17, 2026

NEWMAKERS IN THE NEWSROOM

WHY SHUBHANSHU SHUKLA

Shubhanshu Shukla spent 20 days at the International Space Station last year, becoming only the second Indian — the first in over four decades — to travel to space. His journey stirred the imagination of an entire generation of youngsters for whom space travel might not be as remote a possibility as it was for their elders. After his return, Shukla has taken on the role of a space ambassador, motivating students to reach for the sky. Currently, he's on ground zero, preparing for the Gaganyaan Mission planned by Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO). His book, *The Second Orbit*, details the experiences of his space journey.

Amitabh Sinha: Your book, *The Second Orbit* (Penguin), starts with 14-year-old Shubhanshu Shukla writing to his future self. And he wants his future self to reply to him. Could tell us about how this idea of the book came about?

The book idea was suggested by many people, even before I went on the mission. When I was in the US, I was advised that I should keep track of what is happening and journal it. The idea of a book was not in my mind at that time. After the space journey, I have been meeting and talking to many people. It was then that it was suggested that I should write a book. I also realised that it's not possible for me to be everywhere, in every school, in every college. So, a book is a good way to do this. I was able to relive those moments. If I had not done it at this point, then probably some of them would have been lost.

Amitabh Sinha: Tell us about the year-long process of training that you went through, the excitement, the anxiety, the sheer scale of achievement.

To become an astronaut, the sheer number of disciplines that you need to train in increases significantly. When you are up in space, there is nobody else. You have to be the pilot, commander, your own doctor, researcher, scientist, plumber, mechanic, everything has to be you. I learned microbiology, medical procedures, it was fascinating.

As for the scale, in hindsight, it is even bigger than what I probably had in mind. But when you are in training, you cannot let your mind think like that. If you do, you start taking the pressure of the enormity of it, then it has a crippling effect and you don't function very well. I don't function very well. It was only when I was in space did I realise the enormity of it — something larger than life, and something you never thought would happen.

Amitabh Sinha: From the launch (on June 25) till your return, were there any crisis moments that were completely unexpected?

Going to space is a managed crisis. Life should not exist in space. There is nothing that supports life, no air, no water. It is a harsh environment. The sheer energy and force that you experience when you are escaping the pull of gravity from Earth, it is phenomenal. So, just to give an analogy, imagine you are strapped to a seat and the seat is sitting on top of 500 tons of propellant and then you light it on fire. It is not a normal thing, but it is managed very well. That is why there are so many people reviewing these things.

When you reach space, everything is actually unexpected. You are taught very well, you are trained very well, but the environment that you experience when you reach there, that cannot be simulated on the ground. Microgravity is the new element which actually changes everything because things don't behave the way they behave when you are on the ground. Everything is new, everything is a delta that you have to navigate and experience only when you are there. There is a saying in the space flight community that you are ready for a space flight when you finish one.

Amitabh Sinha: The Gaganyaan is yet to happen. When you were selected for it, this was just before Covid and Axiom was not on the horizon. There were many delays. At any point, did you think that probably this is not going to happen?

Yeah, that is what was happening. Even in well-established programmes, like the United States and the Russian ones, the average time before an astronaut flies to space is around five to six years. Some astronauts have been selected and never flown. That also happens. So, there is no certainty that you will get to fly. Anything can change in a moment. That is why it was important to enjoy what you are doing when you are not flying.

Even now, after this flight has happened, I do not know when the next one is. If you look at the career of an astronaut, they probably fly two to three times to space, and if they are flying from the US, it is for six months at a time. So, about three times is 1.5 years. Now, for a career that spans 40 years, 1.5 years is the time that is spent in space. The rest 38.5 years is on the ground. So, if you do not enjoy that, then it is very difficult.

Amitabh Sinha: Our Gaganyaan programme is scheduled in the next year or two. Have you transformed into a trainer of sorts for your colleagues?

Not for my colleagues because we all went to Russia together, we were trained there. They, too, are experienced pilots in the Air Force. Actually, I am the junior most among the four of them. One of them came to the US as well as for the Axiom Mission and that's actual training. But, yes, there are lessons to be learned.

The primary objective of doing the Axiom Mission 4 was to learn as much as we could and then how to use that experience to enable our own mission. That is a major exercise that we are doing right now.

ON HIS LEARNINGS FROM AXIOM

I learned the importance of being a follower. Everywhere, even at the IAF, we are taught to be leaders. But, it is important to listen to others, learn from their experiences and unlearn a few things of your own



ON AN ASTRONAUT'S CAREER GRAPH

An astronaut flies two to three times in his life. From the US, it is six months at a time. About three times is 1.5 years. For a career of 40 years, the rest 38.5 years is on the ground. So, you have to enjoy what you do

'Today's kids are brilliant... you have to be with a dream for a long time, work on it, only then will it happen'

Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla on training for space travel, how the process and working at Axiom Space is different from working on the Gaganyaan Mission with ISRO and why the vastness of the space was overwhelming. The session was moderated by Amitabh Sinha, Climate and Science Editor, *The Indian Express*



Astronaut and Group Captain Shubhanshu Shukla (right) with Amitabh Sinha, Climate and Science Editor, *The Indian Express*, at the Noida office last week. RENUKA PURI

Amitabh Sinha: Do you see any difference in the way Axiom was preparing itself and the way ISRO has been doing? Are there any noticeable differences?

Axiom Space is a private company which was coordinating missions to space. It didn't actually own any hardware for the missions. The International Space Station is owned by NASA and its international partners. The vehicle in which we flew to space was SpaceX's Crew Dragon vehicle and the rocket was Falcon 9. So that was owned by SpaceX. Axiom did not own any hardware. What ISRO is doing is we are trying to make our own hardware: the capsule, the spacecraft in which the astronauts will go. So it's a very different kind of work. Here, we are trying to make it in-house and launch Indian astronauts on our own vehicle and in our own capsule. This is heavy engineering work, and robust processes and review mechanisms are being set up. So, it can't be compared.

Anonna Dutt: What are the learnings from your journey that have brought in changes to processes in the Gaganyaan Mission?

These are such complex processes that it is very difficult to put a finger on something. I travelled to space but there was a team from ISRO which was also there to see how things were happening. We witnessed this end-to-end execution of the entire mission. ISRO has launched many successful missions in the past but human spaceflight is something that we are attempting for the first time and it requires a different ecosystem. We were able to see the scale of operations and what the different disciplines are that we need to address before we actually send people to space and bring them back. That is the biggest learning. There are obviously more segmented, pointed, objective lessons that are being applied, there are so many.

P Vaidyanathan Iyer: How do you

look at life on Earth from space?

When you look back at Earth, from that perspective, it does change something in you. Even in aviation, you never see Earth as a whole. The first feeling that I got — everybody may have different experiences — but the first feeling that I got in space was that this felt like home. The planet felt like home. It really gave me that perception that I am from here. I am not pinpointing India. I am saying that I am from Earth. That was a very strong feeling I had.

The second thing, the vastness. Earth is massive. We know the dimensions but we have not seen it. So when you see that, it feels very big. But if you think about it, it is not the biggest planet. You can fit 1,300 Earths in Jupiter. And our solar system is not the biggest one in our galaxy. And our galaxy is not the biggest in the cluster that we are in. The cluster is not the biggest in the supercluster. So you can go on and on till the end of the universe. So your position, actually where you are, is very average. There is nothing special about

this. So, the thought of the vastness of space is overwhelming.

Amitabh Sinha: Most of us were very young when Rakesh Sharma went to space, and we heard his famous line, 'Sare Jahan Se Achha'. Was it at the back of your mind that you also had to come up with something which everyone remembers?

Yes, of course it was there, and even today when I speak to Sir (Rakesh Sharma), I tell him that he made my life so difficult by saying something so profound. When I was speaking from space, I was aware of the enormity of the situation. I had written a few lines but sometimes those moments are so overwhelming that you forget everything. I just spoke whatever was coming to my mind. There was no competition to say something as profound as him, but the primary feeling was this: It has taken us 40 years to reach here but this time it is different. It won't take us this long to be back in space again. India has changed a lot from



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Amitabh Sinha: More photography? Absolutely. And I would not plan the mission during monsoons because you don't get to see India at all.

Anuradha Mascarenhas: The NDA (National Defence Academy) is known for physically and mentally demanding exercises. Were there any particular drills that you disliked as a cadet but today you are grateful for?

There are two types of fun in life. There is Type A fun and Type B. Type A fun is when you are having fun in the moment, and later when you think about that experience, you still enjoy it because it was so memorable. Type B fun is where when you are doing it, you absolutely hate it. But when you look back, you really enjoy it. The NDA experience is Type B fun, most of it. It prepared you for life. That is what actually takes you to the extremes of what you think is possible.

Jayashree Narayanan: What is your message for Gen Z and Gen Alpha who are watching you?

The kids, from what I have seen, are bril-

liant. The way their thought process works, there are no restraints on them. There are no boundaries within which they feel they have to think. That is why they have been able to break free. And that is very important for us as a nation because the first step to achieving something big is to dream about it.

The second part of it is that dreaming is just one aspect. You have to really be with that dream for a long time and work on it, then only will it happen. It doesn't happen overnight. It doesn't happen in one or two days. Whatever they want to do or achieve, they will have to give it time and they will have to give it effort for a sustained period.

Divyanshu Dutta Roy: The younger generation is often said to be chasing instant gratification. Would you make a case to children and teenagers to follow your path instead, which is a path of rigour, diligence and discipline?

I think everyone understands what it requires to get to the place where you want yourself to be. You have to like what you are doing. Then it doesn't feel like a burden. Sometimes, you might not like certain things but are forced to carry on. That is where discipline comes in.

Instant gratification is probably one of the biggest challenges that the current generation is facing. Patience levels are dropping. It happens to us also. In our times, the challenge was of scarcity. Things were not available. Today, the problem is of abundance. Everything is available. So, there is a lot of distraction, and the challenge is to focus on your goals. That is a skill that has to be developed. You saw the Skyroot launch which happened recently. This work has been happening for the past decade. Those 10 years are very important for this exciting time. You have to invest time, there is no other way. You can temporarily become famous overnight, but that is not going to sustain. You have to do something meaningful for a long time for it to be really effective.

Shalini Langer: Once you've seen space, what do you think of God?

I've always believed that there has to be some sense to what is happening around us. For instance, you don't realise as we are sitting in this room, you are moving at a speed of around 30 kilometres per second. Your solar system is probably moving at around 700 kilometres per second at the same time. Now, this entire thing is explained by science. But even that understanding is limited because science itself is evolving. So I believe that there must be something which is making all this happen, and we should be grateful for what we have, and that is what makes your life peaceful and good. The experience of space definitely has strengthened my belief in the things that I used to believe even before going to space.

Shalini Langer: What about people who are paying to go to space, space tourists?

I hope more and more people go to space and the cost comes down so that more people can experience this — going out and looking at Earth from the outside. Because fundamentally, things do change when you have that perspective and change for the better. Change in the sense that you really feel that you are all in this together — this is your planet and you have a responsibility towards it. So, if you are able to get that perspective, if 100 people can get it, great. If 1,000 people can get it, even better. So it should happen. But again, you have to be very responsible in doing it.

Karishma Verma: After your mission, your mother's reaction went very viral. So what was that conversation after the mission that you had with your mother?

She could not come to Delhi because of health reasons. When I went to Lucknow for the first time (after my return), the first words that came out of her were: 'Beta ab ho gaya hai. Dobara mat jaana (It's done, don't go again).'

Shiny Varghese: Space technology has given us carbon water filters and GPS systems. What new technology did you wish you could have back home?

The water reclamation system on the International Space Station recycles about 98 per cent of the water. And so you really don't have to carry a lot of water to space. This would be something that if we can scale it up and use it on Earth as well, it would be a huge benefit to all of us. Con-serving water and using it more resourcefully, that is something that we can do with a lot more of.

Amitabh Sinha: You have worked in teams at the IAF. How was working with the Axiom team different, given that everyone was from a different country? What were your learnings?

I learned the importance of being a follower, and to learn from others. At IAF, and everywhere else, we are taught how to be leaders. And that is good. But I think, it is important also to be able to listen to others, learn from their experiences and probably unlearn a few things of your own.



WHAT EARTH FELT LIKE FROM SPACE

The first feeling I got in space was that this felt like home. The planet felt like home, that I am from here. I am not pinpointing India on the planet. I am saying that I am from Earth. That was a very strong feeling

{ WEEKLY CAPSULE }

Ozempic reveals craving centre

OZEMPIC-LIKE drugs appear to weaken more than hunger—they may also reduce cravings for alcohol and other addictive substances. Scientists are increasingly tracing this effect to the lateral septum, a brain region that helps connect memories and surroundings with rewarding experiences. Packed with GLP-1 receptors, it may act as a crucial control point between thinking about a reward and feeling compelled to pursue it. The discovery could open new approaches to treating addiction as well as obesity. GLP-1 activation directly in the lateral septum has recently been shown to reduce food craving in mice.



Keratin for regrowing bone

KERATIN EXTRACTED from sheep's wool helped damaged bone regenerate in animals, producing tissue that was more organised and structurally similar to healthy bone than tissue grown with conventional collagen scaffolds. The discovery by King's College London could turn an agricultural byproduct into a promising new material for regenerative medicine. It is a naturally derived material and is often discarded as waste by the farming industry, giving it potential as both a renewable and scalable resource. Collagen members generated more bone overall but the one with keratin scaffolds was more secure.



Blood test as health radar

UCLA RESEARCHERS have created a simple, relatively inexpensive blood test that showed promise in early studies for detecting several types of cancer, multiple liver diseases and signs of organ problems at the same time. The approach works by examining fragments of DNA that circulate naturally in the bloodstream. Since cells release DNA into the blood, these fragments can contain molecular clues about the health of many different organs. The test could eventually provide a more affordable way to detect disease earlier while also giving doctors a broader picture of a person's health.



Fruit juice lowers depression

A DAILY GLASS of 100 per cent fruit juice or a smoothie may help improve mood more than just fruit intake. In a small four-week trial, participants who added one to a healthier diet showed significantly lower depression scores, hinting that a simple dietary change could also support mental well-being. Researchers at Newcastle University evaluated changes in mood using validated questionnaires that measure symptoms of anxiety and depression. Participants who consumed fruit juice and smoothies alongside whole fruit had lower depression scores than the control group.



Why we repeat decisions

WHY DO we keep making the same choices even when better options are available? Researchers found that simply repeating a decision can reshape what we prefer, causing familiar choices to feel better than alternatives. Instead of weighing every option from scratch, the brain often remembers what it chose before and repeats it. That shortcut may help explain many everyday habits and seemingly irrational decisions. The results of a study by TU Dresden University show the pattern could influence shopping decisions, habits, and recurring routines.



INTERPRETATIONS OF MALADY

DR SURANMITH CHATTERJEE
SENIOR CONSULTANT, INTERNAL MEDICINE
APOLLO HOSPITAL, DELHI

H1N1 or flu: Fever is done but why does weakness remain?

Fatigue, body ache or a return of fever after an illness may be part of recovery

A PATIENT RECENTLY came to the clinic after recovering from a viral fever. The fever had settled, the initial tests were no longer concerning and he had started going back to work. But he was still feeling unusually tired. On some days, he felt almost normal. On others, even routine activity left him exhausted. A few days later, he developed body ache and a mild fever again. His immediate concern was that the first infection had returned.

This is a situation that can be confusing for patients, particularly during the monsoon, when dengue, chikungunya, influenza, H1N1 and other infectious microbes can circulate at the same time. The symptoms can overlap and recovery is not always a straight line.

Fever is one of the most visible signs of an infection, so people often use it as a measure of recovery. Once the temperature becomes normal, they expect their energy to return as well. But the body may take longer to recover. During an infection, a person may eat less, lose fluids, sleep poorly and remain physically inactive for several days. The immune response to the infection also takes time to settle. As a result, weakness, poor appetite, body ache and reduced stamina may continue even after the fever has gone. This does not mean that the infection is still active. A negative test is reassuring, but it is not a measure of how quickly the body has regained its strength.

Why then do some patients feel better and then worse again? One reason is that people often return to their routine too quickly. After several days of illness, a person may feel better for a day or two and resume full working hours, exercise or travel. The following day, the fatigue may become much more pronounced.

This can feel like a relapse but sometimes it is simply the result of doing more than the body is ready for. A gradual return to activity is therefore important. Strenuous exercise should not be resumed simply because the fever has disappeared. Many ask me if a new infection is possible. This is where overlapping infections become important. A person recovering from one viral infection can still be exposed to another infection. Seasonal infections may produce similar early symptoms such as fever, body ache, headache and fatigue. It can, therefore, be difficult to determine from symptoms alone whether someone is still recovering or has developed another illness.

Government guidance also notes that one infection does not necessarily exclude another, and co-infections can occur. For example, a patient may recover from influenza, return to work and then develop fever again after a fresh exposure. Another person may initially be diagnosed with a viral fever and later test positive for dengue. These situations need clinical assessment rather than assuming that every recurrence of weakness is simply "post-viral fatigue". There is another reason why a returning patient may not simply be reassured because the fever has come down. In dengue, the period when the fever starts settling can be important. The critical phase generally occurs around this time in patients who develop complications. Warning signs include persistent vomiting, severe abdominal pain, bleeding, increasing drowsiness, difficulty breathing, restlessness or reduced urine output. These symptoms require prompt medical evaluation.

Platlet count is also not the only measure of recovery in dengue. Hydration, blood pressure, haematocrit (percentage of your blood that is made up of red blood cells and is evidence of plasma leakage) and the patient's overall clinical condition are important in deciding how the illness is progressing.

If there is no evidence of a continuing or new infection, the focus is usually on recovery. Adequate sleep, regular, balanced meals, sufficient fluids and gradual physical activity are important. It is also important not to start antibiotics simply because fatigue continues. Antibiotics do not treat viral infections. Steroids and other medicines should similarly not be taken without a clear medical reason. Most people improve gradually. But persistent or worsening symptoms deserve reassessment. A returning fever, breathlessness, chest discomfort, repeated vomiting, fainting, confusion, reduced urine output or a significant deterioration in general health should not be dismissed as weakness after a viral infection.

Kidney transplant, low cost and high access: Doctor who treats – and teaches

With subsidised dialysis, crowdfunding and a push for early screening, the Chennai nephrologist is tackling fund barriers and offering accessible therapy

Arun Janardhanan

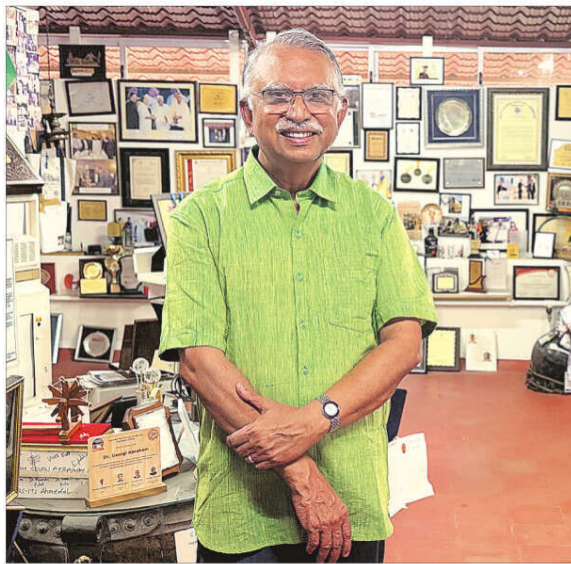
LOOKING AT Chandran driving an auto rickshaw in Chennai, one would not know that he had a kidney transplant over a decade ago. Or that he had no money for the surgery although his wife had volunteered to be a donor. That's when Dr Georgi Abraham turned to crowdfunding so that the procedure could be done. Today, Chandran lives to see his son excel at his job.

Ever since then, I realised that transplant is often a question of money before medicine," says Dr Abraham, the veteran nephrologist who is now working actively through his foundation (Tamilnad Kidney Research or TANKER, Chennai) to make transplants accessible to patients with kidney failure. "The medicine has advanced dramatically. Donor-recipient matching is better, screening is more sophisticated and newer anti-rejection drugs have helped transplanted kidneys survive longer. But for a poor patient, the path from dialysis to transplantation can still depend on whether a family can assemble enough money to cross the distance between having a donor and reaching an operating table," he says.

He is building a low-cost, high-access transplant care model built around reducing the biggest recurring costs through subsidies, expanding the donor pool by efficiently recovering kidneys from deceased donors and ensuring post-surgery care as anti-rejection medicines are expensive but ensure the transplants last longer. On average, a kidney from a living donor functions for 15 to 20+ years, while a deceased donor kidney lasts 10 to 15 years with the right follow-ups. "Many organ recipients abandon this stage because of high costs," says Dr Abraham. "Immediately after the transplantation, the cost of anti-rejection medication, depending upon the match between the donor and the recipient, could be as high as Rs 20,000 or Rs 25,000 a month to as low as Rs 10,000 a month," he says. That expenditure generally declines over time as the amount of immunosuppression required decreases.

He is working with the Madras Medical Mission to provide free or subsidised HLA (human leukocyte antigen) testing — this assesses donor-recipient compatibility — for economically disadvantaged transplant patients. Such testing can cost up to ₹40,000. The approach is to reduce the financial barriers at every stage of transplantation — from subsidising dialysis and helping patients pay for the transplant to making essential post-transplant medicines and tests more affordable. "If some assistance can be given for post-discharge compliance, then, like Chandran, a patient can meet the cost of medication from their own earnings. Since Chandran's transplant has lasted, his requirement for anti-rejection drugs is relatively low now," he adds.

Dr Abraham has already worked on reducing dialysis costs by pioneering peritoneal dialysis, a home-based treatment for kidney failure. It uses the lining of the abdomen (the peritoneum) and a special cleansing fluid to filter waste and extra fluid from your blood. One of his patients, Shanti Raj Mohan, lived with kidney failure and dialysis for 23 years. "Shanti taught me that you could be a very purpose-driven person despite having kidney failure," says Dr



ARUN JANARDHANAN

Abraham, who has provided more than 9,04 lakh free or subsidised dialysis sessions to 3,378 patients. The foundation currently provides close to 10,000 dialysis sessions a month through 16 centres, with most treatments offered free through a combination of government health insurance, civic bodies and private donors.

In the early 1990s, obtaining the dialysis fluid was difficult. "Initially it was a Herculean task because the government did not permit import of dialysis fluid to India until 1994," Dr Abraham says. That changed when the fluid was placed under an open general licensing in 1994. India now has domestic manufacturers supplying peritoneal dialysis fluid across the country. Yet Dr Abraham says the treatment remains underused. "The reluctance is because of logistical and reimbursement problems," he says.

These days he is busy with a more elementary question, why wait for the kidneys to fail? A question that has fuelled his campaign for targeted kidney screening through primary health centres across parichayats in India, using simple creatinine, urine and blood-pressure tests. The goal is to identify chronic kidney disease among high-risk populations before irreversible damage sets in. His proposed screening model is strikingly simple: a creatinine blood test, a urine examination and a blood-pressure measurement. Those who should be prioritised, he says, include people with diabetes, hypertension or heart disease, those with a family history of kidney disease, people who have previously suffered acute kidney injury, those using alternative medicines and people above 45.

"A simple blood test to measure creatinine, using a strip with a meter, and a simple urine test can identify most of the time whether you have kidney disease or not," says Dr Abraham. The urgency is considerable. He cites a 2016 publication in *The Lancet* that estimated the prevalence of chronic kidney disease in India at about 17.2 per cent. Even a relatively small failure to detect disease early can translate into an enormous number of people eventually reaching advanced kidney failure.

"Over 46 years, kidney care in the country has changed. Today, people in the 60s, 70s, 80s and even 90s undergo dialysis.

Dr Georgi Abraham with his honours and testimonials at his terrace museum



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Kidney transplantation has become safer because of better donor-recipient matching, improved screening and newer anti-rejection medicines. Patients who once might have been considered too old for aggressive treatment can now be kept alive for years," he says. Yet India has not built an equally ambitious preventive screening infrastructure so that people don't reach that stage. Transplantation, for one, cannot solve the problem at population scale. There will never be enough donor kidneys for everyone who needs one. "We cannot provide transplants to all the patients who are on dialysis. This will never happen in any part of the world," says Dr Abraham.

Besides, India now has roughly 3,300 kidney specialists, according to Abraham, compared with a very small pool two decades ago. He hopes that number can rise to 10,000 within another decade. "During a recent visit to AIIMS in New Delhi, I had watched a colleague facing a clinic load of more than 100 patients. To get every detail from each takes time," he says.

That gap is one reason Abraham believes screening cannot remain confined to specialist centres. If kidney disease can be identified earlier at the primary-care level, some patients can be monitored and treated before they reach the point where dialysis becomes inevitable, he reasons. He is also wary of assuming that India can simply import its understanding of kidney disease from Western countries. His own team recently examined lipid profiles of 1,000 dialysis patients and found differences from patterns described in developed countries. "We need to have a strong platform for research to deal with our own diseases, our own disease patterns and how to treat them cost-effectively," Dr Abraham says.

He is equally cautious about another common assumption: that India is witnessing a distinct epidemic of kidney disease among the young. What has changed, he argues, is visibility. India's population has expanded, diagnostic methods have improved, kidney biopsies and imaging are more accessible, patients are more aware and the number of trained nephrologists has risen substantially. "The challenge now is to ensure that greater visibility means early enough to make a difference," he says.

• A MODEL THAT WORKS

Dr Georgi Abraham's outreach programmes are a combination of education, interaction, screening, counselling and referral.

CHILDREN'S WORKSHOP



AT HIS kidney workshop as part of his Catch 'em Young project, children are told how their two kidneys act like tiny strainers that clean the blood and turn extra water and waste into pee. "We explain that when the kidneys get hurt, it is like their filter getting clogged. Then we focus on how taking care of their bodies helps the filters stay clean and strong rather than focusing on scary sickness. We show them how drinking plain water helps flush the system like washing out a dirty cup. We explain how too much salt or packaged junk food makes the kidneys work overtime, while fresh fruits and vegetables give them an easy job. We remind them not to hold their pee for too long so that they can avoid infection," says a volunteer. "There is a tendency among very young people to have high blood pressure in the country," says Dr Abraham, recommending annual blood-pressure checks for children from age three.

AWARENESS TALKS

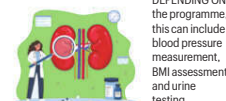
THIS INVOLVES helping people understand the connection between diabetes, high blood pressure, obesity, smoking, unhealthy diets and kidney disease. "Kidney awareness should begin with routine blood pressure and blood sugar monitoring. Systolic blood pressure — the top reading — should generally be kept around 120 mmHg, while people with diabetes should monitor HbA1c (the average blood sugar count of three months). It is normally below 5.6 per cent but ideally should remain below 6.5 per cent in diabetics, and below 7.1 per cent in older diabetics," says Dr Abraham.

BUILDING A SCIENTIFIC TEMPERAMENT



HE WARNS against unnecessary antibiotics, painkillers and unmonitored Ayurveda, Siddha or homeopathic medicines because of damaging effects on the kidneys. Since the kidneys filter waste from the blood, they are highly exposed to concentrated toxins present in unregulated supplements. This damage can manifest as acute kidney injury (AKI), chronic kidney disease (CKD), kidney stones, or complete renal failure.

BASIC HEALTH SCREENING



may add blood tests such as blood glucose, creatinine or imaging when medically appropriate to eliminate risks.

DEPENDENT ON the programme, this can include blood pressure measurement, BMI assessment and urine testing.

• UNDERSTANDING THE KIDNEY'S LINK WITH OTHER ORGANS

Link with the heart: The heart and kidneys are closely linked. Kidney problems can raise the risk of a heart attack and heart problems can damage the kidneys. Damaged kidneys often cause blood pressure to rise. High BP damages

arteries and increases the chance of a heart attack. Kidney disease is associated with inflammation and changes in blood vessels, making atherosclerosis (plaque buildup) more likely. Poor kidney function can cause the body to retain sodium and fluid, increasing blood pressure and putting extra strain on the heart.

When diabetes is a risk: The filtering units of the kidney are filled with tiny blood vessels. Over time, high sugar levels in the blood can constrict these vessels. Without enough blood, albumin (a type of protein) passes through these

filters and ends up in the urine where it should not be. Diabetes damages nerves, which carry messages between your brain and your bladder. Damaged, your brain won't sense your bladder is full. If urine stays in your bladder for a long time, bacteria grow, triggering a urinary tract infection.

Partnering with liver: The liver and kidneys act as a cooperative filtration and chemical processing team. Severe liver damage can change blood flow. This tricks the kidneys into shutting down, causing sudden kidney failure. If one organ fails, extra toxins stay in the blood and stress the other organ.

BANGLADESH'S HISTORIC WIN IN NUMBERS

3 Bangladesh needed only 3 Tests to register their first Test victory on Australian soil. That makes them the quickest Asian team to achieve the feat

1995 The result also ended a remarkable run for Australia. Before Bangladesh's victory, Australia had not lost a home Test to an Asian team other than India since Pakistan defeated them in 1995

9 The nine-wicket victory is Bangladesh's second-biggest Test win by wickets. Their biggest remains the 10-wicket victory over Pakistan in Rawalpindi in 2024

2 Bangladesh's victory in Darwin is only their second Test win in the traditional SENA countries - South Africa, England, New Zealand and Australia



Bangladesh secured their first win on Australian soil after losing their first two Tests way back in 2003. **AP**

Darwin triumph marks Bangladesh evolution

Tigers' historic nine-wicket win over Australia was more than an upset — it was a coming-of-age moment that showcased their pace-bowling strength, resilience and growing belief in Test cricket

Sandip G
New Delhi, August 16

BANGLADESH WILL forever remember the old, quaint city of Darwin, in Australia's Northern Territory. There, on August 16, they etched the most memorable moment in their cricket history, a golden hour of surrealism, when they hammered (and a hammering it was) Australia by nine wickets. "This is the biggest moment for Bangladesh cricket, and this encourages us to do something special in the future," Bangladesh captain Najmul Shantosa said after the game, face beaming and eyes moist.

He was not exaggerating. The feat and its nature were shudderingly implausible. Bangladesh out-skilled, out-powered and out-muscled a full-strength Australia at home, even if the stage was far away from the grand citadels of the country, the outlier locale reserved for whom the elites of the world condescend as minnows. Maybe that was Bangladesh's stirring inspiration. To be snubbed of the prime venues of the vast country, to be treated like a fixture-formality; to be considered trivial to not invite for a Test series in 23 years; to be mocked and ridiculed after a third-string domestic side bowled them out for 54 in the warm-up; to be not taken seriously; to be cast off from the T20 World Cup in India early this year. They are a cricketing nation fuelled by emotions; just that, often, they let the rage of emotions self-destruct them. In Darwin, they harnessed the

India's WTC final aspirations take a further hit

HEADING INTO the two Tests in Darwin and Galle, Bangladesh were in fourth position on the World Test Championship (WTC) table, one place above India, but it was largely considered a statistical quirk. After all, they had played just four games — losing 0-1 in a two-Test series in Sri Lanka, and beating Pakistan 2-0 at home. They were expected to face sterner Tests when they travelled away from the subcontinent.

India had garnered positive vibes from the 2-2 draw in England before thrashing the West Indies 2-0 at home. But the balloon was prickled by a 0-2 reversal at home to South Africa. The two Tests in Sri Lanka were touted as the first step towards qualifying for the WTC title

E. clash next year. But while Bangladesh tore up the script in Darwin, rain added to the frustration of Shubman Gill & Co after a fruitful first day, and with rain on the radar for the next three days in Galle, the visitors have all to do to stay in the hunt.

After the events in Darwin, the difference between India and Bangladesh on the WTC table has ballooned to over 18 percentage points. India probably didn't expect Bangladesh to keep up their momentum, but Nazmul Hossain Shanto and his team have rapidly improved in Test cricket.

If events in Sri Lanka don't

go to plan, India could be cycled in mid-table as their last two assignments in the WTC were New Zealand away (always a tricky proposition) and Australia at home for five Tests, where they may need something like a 4-0 win to stay in contention.

As things stand, Australia (77.77%) still lead ahead of South Africa (75), New Zealand (72.22), Bangladesh (66.67) and India (48.15).

India may also not be able to rely on results elsewhere helping them too much, as teams in the top four play among themselves in most of the remaining series, so any points dropped by one contender will be taken by another. **ENS**

force a comeback, Bangladesh didn't wither; rather, they stubbornly broke the resistance. They shed their inferiority complex. They remained unfazed when Steve Smith threatened to barge Australia back; they remained unshaken when Mitchell Starc & Co ratcheted up the aggression. Their spirit was tigerish, and not paper-tigerish as it once was. The emotions found the perfect balance.

Red-ball resurgence

The victory could be a symbolic moment in their cricket history — and just their second in a SENA country. It's the real coming-of-age moment for a country, since its red-ball debut at the stroke of the century never really seemed to crack the mood of the format. At times, they seemed to care less for Test cricket, obscured by the obsessive desire to find the tunes of shorter formats, where success was easier to find.

The resurgence could not have been better timed, for there has been a startling decline in competitiveness in Test cricket. If Bangladesh can go one step further and wrap up the series, the longest form of the game could smile after years. And the quaint and ancient town of Darwin would strike an emotional chord with Bangladesh's passionate cricket fans.

BRIEF SCORES: Australia 198 and 284 all out in 95.1 overs (Cameron Green 104; Mehidy Hossain Miraz 5/66) lost to Bangladesh 426 and 57/1 in 14.2 overs by nine wickets

they are feeble of both mind and technique. But Tanzid Hasan illustrated the skill and mind to compose a hundred of classical Test match virtues. Captain Najmul Hossain Shanto and Mehidy Hossain Miraz, who snared five wickets in the second innings, strung together valuable knocks to dispel the resolute comebacks the hosts are famed and fabled to produce. They did an Australia to Australia, to squeeze and strangle them to submission, to shut every door, window and crack of hope on their opponents.

Whenever Australia, toppers of the Test pile and favourites to nail the WTC final spot, tried to

blend of pride, anger and hurt to produce something monumental and memorable.

The seam-friendly conditions did not over-excite their fast bowlers, prone to bouts of over-exuberance. Seamer Hasan Mahmud, who embodies the discipline Bangladesh exhibited, probed nasty lines and plugged away on stingy lengths. Only 26, and if his body holds up, Mahmud could be his country's tour de force in numerous bats overseas. He's already the most complete fast bowler Bangladesh has produced, a combination of robust pace, capacity to swing the ball laterally and supreme control.

He has painted his country's cricket culture with a new identity. Moving on from left-arm spinners, Bangladesh is now a pace bowling country. Mahmud, Taskin Ahmed and Ebadat Hussain nailed all 10 of Australia's wickets in the first innings. In the second day, they claimed four, with Mahmud ejecting the openers and the centurion Cameron Green.

After they bundled out Australia for 198, the batsmen exhibited insuperable resolve to maximise the advantage. Another long-standing stereotype Bangladesh myth was put to bed. That they don't exude Test-match temperament, that



Tanzid Hasan scored 101 in the 1st innings against Australia. **AP**

now we are getting consistent grass on the wicket," Sarkar added. Bowling on bouncy pitches with the Dukes ball has helped them unearth new bowling talent. Taskin Ahmed, Hasan Mahmud and Ebadat Hossain, who played at Darwin, kept the Australian batsmen in check with their precision

“When we travel to Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and Zimbabwe, we have to leave the ball well outside the off-stump, and that is Tanzid's strength”

HANNAN SARKAR,
BANGLADESH U-19 HEAD COACH

Persistent rain dictates India's approach to victory

Venkata Krishna B
Chennai, August 16

HAVING ALREADY lost plenty of overs and time to rain at Galle, India came out with a totally different intent on Day Two. Persistent showers since morning delayed the start on Sunday till 2.35 PM, pouring cold water on India's hopes of batting once and big.

So, they had to alter the game with an eye on the weather forecast. With rain expected to play a part over the remaining three days as well, the question now is whether India could find time to push for a win. In total, 54 overs were lost.

Having ended Day One at 288/2, India's intentions were evident. They wanted to bat much of Day Two and be in a position from where they can't lose the Test. With 460/9 on board, thanks largely to Devdutt Padikkal's 167, they can still manage to overcome the weather equations and win, but it will take some effort from the bowling unit. Unless they shut the hosts to a low total in the first essay, then the chances of enforcing follow-on looks bleak.

But the intent seems clear. It is the path that India are willing to take.

From the moment they came out to bat, the domination they showed on the first day was missing. While Padikkal resumed from where he had left off, for India to bat Sri Lanka out of the game, Rishabh Pant held the key.

During his brief stay on Saturday, he had been at his attacking best. Even on Sunday, he tried to keep the scoreboard moving in quick time. Resultantly, Sri Lanka took the new ball early, which seemed a gamble as it would allow India to score freely.

But Pant committed the same mistake as Shubman Gill did on the opening day. Like Gill, the intention couldn't be faulted. Debutant Keshava Nuvantha hadn't been at his best on his first day at office, but on Sunday he found the control with his length and speed. Watching Pant in a hurry, he was prepared to slow it down and by the time the left-hander charged down, he was nowhere close to the pitch of the ball. Yet, he committed himself to hoick, which was caught at mid-off by his maiden Test wicket.

That dismissal brought in KL Rahul, who had retired hurt on 77. Having done all the hard work against the spinners, he had an opportunity to wrap up



Dhruv Jurel scored 51 off 68 balls on Day 2. **CREMAS**

his 13th Test century. But on a pitch that had been under covers, the Lankan attack found enough help. Early on, Asitha Fernando managed to induce an edge, which went through the vacant third slip. Soon, Nishan Fernando came up with some exceptional reflex work at forward short-leg to give Nuvantha his second wicket. The turn and the bounce forced Rahul to play a shot he was in no control for the first time against the spinners. A score 82 off 175 was a commendable effort, but not a complete job. It was an innings synonymous with Rahul's career so far.

Different outfit

Once Sri Lanka found the early breakthroughs, they appeared a different outfit.

Dhruv Jurel, with Sarfaraz Khan breathing down his neck, didn't look in absolute control. Even to full deliveries, he preferred to defend or nudge here and there, seldom inducing assurance. But on the occasions he played with absolute clarity, he appeared a different batsman. Each of his four boundaries and a six was a message that he can be a specialist batsman in the long run. The dismissal, trying to nudge it around the leg-side only for the ball to find the edge and Dhananjaya de Silva coming up with an acrobatic catch, only showed his limitations.

Like Rahul on the opening day, he too received deliveries he could have swept. But it remained on the shelf. Beyond Padikkal and Jurel, the rest came up with cameo. The two all-rounders Ravindra Jadeja and Manav Suthar tried to show their positive intent, but their innings were short-lived, on a 43-over day where India tried their best to take the game forward as quickly as they could. That they scored at

Scorecard

SRI LANKA vs INDIA

GALLE

Toss: India won, chose to bat

INDIA (10/288-2)

KL Rahul c Fernando b Nuvantha

29 (68b, 4x4, 1x6)

Devdutt Padikkal c Dickwells b

Jayasuriya 167 (230b, 15x4, 1x6)

Rishabh Pant c Dinusha b Nuvantha

51 (68b, 4x4, 1x6)

Dhruv Jurel c de Silva b Jayasuriya

13 (25b, 1x4)

Ravindra Jadeja lbw b Nuvantha

24 (43b, 2x4)

Manav Suthar c Udara b Fernando

11 (15b, 1x6)

Mohammed Siraj c de Silva b Fernando

12 (13b, 2x4)

Kuldeep Yadav not out

1 (4b)

EXTRAS (b 4, lb 3, w 1, nb 4) 12

TOTAL (116 Overs) 460-9

FoW: 307-3 (Rishabh Pant, 80.4 ov),

319-4 (KL Rahul, 84.1 ov), 357-5

(Devdutt Padikkal, 91.3 ov), 371-6

(Ravindra Jadeja, 98.1 ov), 432-7 (Dhruv

Jurel, 109.1 ov), 447-8 (Mohammed

Siraj, 112.6 ov), 447-9 (Manav Suthar,

113.1 ov)

BOWLING: Asitha Fernando 17

1-61; Lahiru Kumara 13-1-76-0; Keshava

Nuvantha 39-1-175-3; Prabhath

Jayasuriya 39-6-109-4; Dhananjaya

de Silva 4-0-15-0; Sonal Dinusha 4-0-17-0

four runs an over showed their

intention. If not for some untimely wickets at the start, they would have probably ended up with a bigger score on the board.

On a pitch where turn and

bounce are already manifesting,

India would hope they

would make most of the conditions.

Once the groundstaff remove

the covers, the overnight

sweating could bring in

seamers into the play. If they

can make early inroads, they

would be setting up an ideal

platform for spinners to go full-

throttle against an inexperienced

batting unit.

Over the next three days, as

much as the strip, India would

be keeping their eyes firmly on

the overhead conditions.

‘There is no pressure’, claims Jurel after scoring timely fifty

Express News Service
Mumbai, August 16

AHEAD OF the first Test of the two-match series against Sri Lanka, India had a selection puzzle to solve between the incumbent Dhruv Jurel and the returning Sarfaraz Khan for the middle-order position. The management went with the former, and the right-hander, who had scores of 19, 20 and 13 leading into Galle, responded by making 51 on Day 2, before he felt to Prabhath Jayasuriya.

Speaking after the day's play,

Jurel said he did not feel any pressure about his lack of runs coming into the game, and he looked every chance as an opportunity to play for India.

"Not at all. Because, to be honest, I am very grateful that I have the opportunity to represent India. Whenever I go in, I think this is an opportunity to do something for India. So there is no pressure. That's the only privilege that I play for," Jurel told reporters on Sunday.

The 25-year-old also revealed what India planned to do when play resumed in the afternoon.

"You can say that the plan was to make as many runs as possible. The plan was not that from ball one we are going bonkers. The plan was that we can make as many runs as possible by hitting on a sensible wicket. I, Rishabh bhai and whoever is batting down there can do that," he added.

With 9 sessions left in the Test match, India will need to bowl Sri Lanka out twice on a surface that is turning. Jurel admitted that India will have their task cut out for them to bowl Sri Lanka out twice.

what makes him so threatening to face," Sarkar said.

Memory trip

Sarkar was the opener of the Bangladesh team which last toured Australia in 2003 and got whitewashed. "We were given Test status in 2000. So, it was a very early stage for our Test cricket. At that time, our thinking was that if we played with Australia for 3-4 days, that would be a big achievement," Sarkar laughed. "But now, we play to win against any team," he said.

"Even in domestic cricket in my time, we used to see players score a maximum of 3-4 centuries in an entire season. But now that number has gone up drastically, and you see cen-

turies and double centuries frequently," Sarkar said.

This decade has seen some historic results for Bangladesh. In 2022, they beat New Zealand for the first time in Mount Maunganui and in 2024 they whitewashed Pakistan in their backyard. Sarkar said wins like these could inspire the cricketing ecosystem in the country. "This is a good boost. When the top team achieves a good result, it boosts the rest of our system. It inspires them to do well, and targets also increase."

Despite Sunday's win, however, he concluded by sounding a note of caution, stating that the next challenge for the board and the players was to consistently deliver such results.

LONG TIME COMING

Tanzid, Hasan and structural change behind an emerging force in Test cricket

Tanishq Vaddi
Hyderabad, August 16

"USKE SAATH mera relationship bahut purana hai..." "We go back a long way," said Hannan Sarkar, the delighted Bangladesh U-19 head coach, about Tanzid Hasan Tamim. The southpaw scored 101 in the first innings against Australia in Darwin, playing a pivotal part in Bangladesh's historic win on Sunday.

Tanzid's compact technique, coupled with playing the ball late, worked wonderfully well against the Aussies. One stand-out shot of his innings came when he was on 63 and square-drove Pat Cummins for a boundary. It was a shot from a batter who was in control and in sync

with the pace and bounce from the surface. His century was filled with such delightful strokes.

Sarkar has been watching Tanzid for the last 15 years and working on his game. "He has a strong technique for Test cricket," he told *The Indian Express*. It was only Tanzid's second Test. But that is Tanzid's success stems from five years of playing international white-ball cricket.

"When we travel to Australia, South Africa, New Zealand and Zimbabwe, we have to leave the ball well outside the off-stump, and that is Tanzid's strength; whenever he had the ball there for him to play his shots, he took it," Sarkar said.

Tanzid averages 40.06 in first-class cricket. Sarkar said Tanzid had taken to the red-ball format like duck to water and could bat for long periods to tire bowlers.

Domestic impact

Bangladesh has made structural changes in its domestic cricket in recent years, steadily improving the nation's red-ball ecosystem. "For the last 4-5 years, we have used the Dukes ball with the pace bowlers. The batsmen have faced tough times in first-class cricket...so, there has been improvement. That's the reason why we are playing well when we go to places like New Zealand and Australia."

"Earlier, the grass on our pitches was not compact, but

now we are getting consistent grass on the wicket," Sarkar added. Bowling on bouncy pitches with the Dukes ball has helped them unearth new bow-

ling talent. Taskin Ahmed, Hasan Mahmud and Ebadat Hossain, who played at Darwin, kept the Australian batsmen in check with their precision



Anders Antonsen classified Delhi pollution as seasonal. EXPRESS

Don't mind \$5000 fine for skipping India Open: Antonsen

Express News Service New Delhi, August 16

DANISH SHUTTLE Anders Antonsen, who skipped the India Open Super 750 earlier this year due to pollution, expressed his satisfaction with the conditions at the BWF World Championships at the IG Indoor Stadium.

However, he mentioned that he won't come back if the India Open continues to be held in the month of January or February, because of the severe air pollution then.

"As far as the conditions go, the hall is pretty and practice facilities are good," Antonsen told the media in a pre-tournament interaction. "I haven't been here for over three years. I pulled out from the India Open due to air pollution. I know there is a big difference in pollution season by season. Right now, it's fine," he added further.

Antonsen had paid a mandatory \$5000 fine for his India Open 2026 withdrawal. When asked if he will come back for the India Open next year, Antonsen said he won't mind paying the \$5000 fine if the tournament is held between January and March.

"Every year, when I see the calendar, I am like, okay, they are just instantly giving me a \$5,000 fine. I don't know if my year will be the same. I haven't really decided 100% yet," he said.

He added that it's not right to host the India Open in the heavy pollution season. "The pollution during that season is pretty insane. I don't think it is the right move for the BWF to host the tournament in January or February in Delhi. Hosting it around this time (August) seems much better from my perspective," Antonsen said.

Antonsen, who is World No. 4, is set to feature in the men's singles category and will be Denmark's medal prospect in the absence of former world champion Viktor Axelsen.

"No, I don't feel any additional pressure. The only pressure I feel is the one coming from within. I hold myself to high standards and I want to win and claim the biggest titles," Antonsen further said.

Deceptive calmness shrouds Delhi before storm unleashes

BWF WORLD CHAMPIONSHIPS

Reticent shuttlers are reluctant to do the talking, but over the coming week, their badminton will

Shivani Naik New Delhi, August 16

AS BADMINTON'S biggest jamboree returns to India after 17 years, with the hosts anxious about pulling off a global event seamlessly, the top-tier athletes are offering their approval to an "improved arena," resembling humble invitees at the mercy of hosts.

They know about the monkeys and pigeons, but laud the efforts undertaken to negate all that went wrong in January. Perhaps, the venue mirrors their own tentative mindset in an injury-ravaged season with several top names neither completely fit, nor completely confident. Badminton, indeed, revels in its reserve.

At its grandest stage, it falls back on the opposite of boxing's trash-talk. It politely reveals wounds and weaknesses, lulling opponents. A day before the World Badminton Championship, World No 1 An Se-young had ice bags strapped to her left knee when she came to speak to the press. She insisted the lead-up has been solely about injury recovery and rediscovering rhythm. Her opponent Chen Yufei concedes compatriot Wang Zhi Yi is better prepared than her, and she's only just finding her way back into battle-mode. Zhi Yi, a potential PV Sindhu roadblock, stresses on how tough it is to play the Indian.

Neither Chinese will reveal their level of preparation in the bid to reclaim a title China has not won since 2011, because the murmurs over the elusive World title have turned into a clamour. Yufei claims her strategies have nothing to do with who the opponent is. Yet, at the mere mention of Akane Yamaguchi, her facial expression freezes in time. Clipped clichés about focusing on self, follow.

Men's singles No 2 and former champion, Kunlavut Vitidsarn almost concedes he is in a testing phase after an injury lull, and says the Delhi Worlds are not much more than a training pad for the Asian Games—a title he hasn't won. He acknowledges the new generation has increasingly made his life difficult, with the likes of Alex Lanier, Lin



Ayush Shetty's clash against World No 1 Shi Yuqi will headline Day 1 of the BWF Badminton World Championships. BA

Dark horses at Delhi Worlds



CHRISTO POPOV (MS), FRANCE

Ranked 5th in the world, Christo Popov is among the more improved men's singles shuttlers in the past few months. After comparatively easy opening rounds, he will potentially clash with Alex Lanier and Jonatan Christie. Riding on confidence from the Japan Open, there is a chance that Popov can medal.



PUTRI KUSUMA WARDANI (WS), INDONESIA

World No 6, Putri Kusuma Wardani can be the surprise package in an otherwise stacked women's singles. She defeated PV Sindhu in the quarter-finals of the last edition and went on to win the bronze medal. She is likely to face the home favourite in the third round on this occasion.



RAYMOND INDRA AND NIKOLAUS JOAQUIN (MD), INDONESIA

The 12th-seeded upstarts from Indonesia can be a thorn in the flesh for any men's doubles pair. It has been a decent year for them, having reached the semis of All England and the final of the Indonesia Open. They might face the Indian pair of Satwiksairaj Rankireddy-Chirag Shetty in the third round.



LAUREN LAM AND ALLISON QUYNH LEE (WD), USA

The rapidly rising duo from the USA doesn't have a title to show, but has dished out consistent performances over the past season, with multiple semi-final appearances. They have a bye in the first round and could face the Indian pair of Tressia Jolly and Gayatri Gopichand in the second.

Sindhu begins home Worlds with renewed vigour, confidence



PV Sindhu is gunning for her sixth World Championships medal. BA

British Raj New Delhi, August 16

AS INDIAN shuttlers gear up for the World Championships starting at the IG Indoor Stadium on Monday, the spotlight will once again fall on PV Sindhu and her quest to win another medal at the prestigious event.

The 31-year-old remains one of India's best medal prospects and will feature in a home World Championships for the first time, enters the competition with confidence, having won the Japan Open Super 750 title recently.

On the tournament's eve, Sindhu, who will face Sophia Noble of Ireland in the first round on Monday, spoke to reporters about expectations and the thrill of playing at home, her newfound confidence and evolution since her first medal.

Excerpts from conversation:

On playing at home:

I am very excited that it's happening in India after a long time. I haven't won for seven years. I hope I keep the confidence from the Japan Open and win here. The Indian crowd is going to support me, and playing on home ground is going to be great for me.

Evolution after first medal in 2013:

I have won five medals at the World Championships, and it has been an amazing journey. Every medal gave me a different kind of experience. The transition was such a way that it gave me a lot of confidence.

Confidence after Japan Open win:

Japan Open gave me a lot of boost and confidence.

Difference in women's singles:

Earlier, women's singles was more attacking and fast-paced, but now it's about staying on the court, staying patient and long rallies. When I look back at 2019, I'm much more experienced in terms of dealing with court conditions. I'm more adapted to situations when things are not

“When you get a new coach, it takes time to get to know each other. But now it is good, as we understand each other's requirements. It has started clicking for me, and we can see how the results have improved.”

PV SINDHU ON WORKING WITH IRWANSYAH

going according to how I want.

Memories of 2009 Worlds:

I was a very small girl, and I used to come and watch matches from morning to evening. I used to watch top players, and it's great to see the journey when I experienced the best back then, and now I have been playing at that level.

On the new scoring system:

The new scoring system is going to be very challenging. In 21 points, you have time to come back, but in 15 points, you need to be on your feet from the word go. There is no scope for getting relaxed.

On using sports science:

As I mentioned, it was very important for me to have a sports science team. I have Wayne Lombard, Heera (physio) and Shreyashi (S&C). Sometimes the body is not 100 percent, but you still push. Injuries are unpredictable, but sports science helps in taking precautions to avoid them. The gadgets and the new metrics have helped me avoid injuries and see the changes in my movements.

On new coach Irwansyah:

My coach has been with me for the past 18 months. When you get a new coach, it takes time to get to know each other. But now it is good, as we understand each other's requirements. It has started clicking for me, and we can see how the results have improved.

{ HOCKEY WORLD CUP }

India make point against China in opener

Mihir Vasavda Mumbai, August 16

ONE MOMENT, Navneet Kaur was holding off a defender inside the Chinese circle, turning sharply and finding the space to fire India into the lead. Minutes later, she was sprinting into her own half, winning possession and giving her defence a chance to reset.

That was India's afternoon in a nutshell. Nikki Pradhan sat in front of the back three like a sentry, reading danger before it fully developed and cutting off passing lanes as China pressed. Baljeet Kaur's explosive runs ensured the Chinese defence never had the luxury of settling into shape. Deepika Soreng attacked the baseline, slipping behind defenders and stretching the field.

And when China inevitably fouled opener, Savita Punia and Bichu Devi, who alternated the quarters, were there to keep India in the contest.

There were moments of individual brilliance throughout the match. But India's 2-2 draw against one of the World Cup favourites wasn't the result of one outstanding performance. It was built on contributions from every corner of the field.

India hadn't beaten China in their last four outings. Each defeat had been more damaging than the previous one. But this Indian team is different. The dressing room that once looked fractured has found some of its



Shilpi Dabas (C) surrounded by China players. HOCKEY INDIA

old rhythm; players seem clearer about their roles, and the defensive discipline that had been missing is now becoming a defining feature.

Sjoerd Marijne, back for a third stint with the team after his previous one ended with a fourth-place finish at the Tokyo Olympics, has spent much of his time bringing that 'joy' back into the group. His four pillars have been role clarity, team unity, defensive discipline and precise finishing.

The FIH Nations Cup, which India won in June without losing a match, was an early glimpse of a programme beginning to yield results. The World Cup opener in Amsterdam on Sunday reinforced that belief.

Alyson Annan wanted her team to play fast hockey from the get-go. For much of the first half, though, it was China who were being forced to chase.

The goal didn't swing momentum China's way. India deployed a half-court press to counter China's offensive push. They absorbed pressure and recoiled like a spring whenever a counterattacking opportunity presented itself. Deepika Soreng's goal came from one such move. India won possession and charged forward. Deepika made a penetrative run down the right flank, entered China's 'D', kissed the baseline and drew a foul then won a penalty corner. She then converted it, her drag-kick taking in two big deflections before finding the back of the net.

China began the third quarter with a subtle tactical change. Their two forwards in the 4-4-2 formation pressed very high and operated in their zones, making India uncomfortable and smothering their forplay. The tactic worked as China equalised again in the 39th minute. Ma Ning drilled a powerful drag-kick to Savita's right. But India held. They could even have won had Lalremliam found a touch to Navneet's cross that flew across the goalmouth.

India, however, seemed content with a point against an opponent who will be their biggest rival in next month's Asian Games. "It's better than losing," Navneet smiled after the game. "The tactic worked as China equalised again in the 39th minute. Ma Ning drilled a powerful drag-kick to Savita's right. But India held. They could even have won had Lalremliam found a touch to Navneet's cross that flew across the goalmouth."

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Both India, England have opened their WC campaigns with wins. ■

rarely much daylight between the two teams.

Then, there was Paris. If there is one match that perfectly captures this rivalry, it is the Olympic quarterfinal in 2024. It also added needle to the duel.

India were reduced to 10 men off by Amit Rohidas was sent off in the 17th minute. Against most elite teams, that should have been a death sentence. Against Great Britain, it became one of the finest performances in recent Indian hockey history. Harmanpreet Singh gave India the lead before Great Britain equalised. What followed was a defensive masterclass. India absorbed relentless pressure for more than three quarters of the contest, defended with extraordinary discipline and somehow dragged the game into a shootout.

Number Plate 11

● Number of matches out of the last 24 between India and England since the 2014 WC that have been decided by a margin of one goal. 10 matches in the same period have ended in draws.

phies almost guarantee an intriguing tactical battle.

There is also a broader shift that has transformed the fixture over the last decade. Until a couple of decades ago, this wasn't really a rivalry. England and Great Britain were the more established international sides. It was the 2-0 loss to Britain in 2008, in fact, that led to India missing out on the Olympics. That equation has changed. India's Olympic bronze medal in Tokyo and Paris, and the evolution under successive coaching regimes have brought them back into hockey's top tier.

If the last few years have taught us anything, it's that when these two teams meet, rare favourites are hard to find, comfortable victories are even harder to predict, and the chances of witnessing another classic are remarkably high.

INDIA VS ENGLAND, 6.30pm, live on Star Sports Network and JioHotstar